

伪像报告

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虚伪聚钱®

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Chapter 1 — Mai Minghe: I Want to Pick More Daisies

When Mai Minghe woke, the room was dim and dark, and the light seeping in beneath the curtains was still the light of night.

She was a light sleeper, waking several times each night, but tonight the reason was different. A small, hard sound had pulled her from sleep, rising out of the steady "whooo—whooo" of the background noise that filled the room.

What was making that noise?

She was groggy with sleep, her mind slow to catch up.

The metallic scraping and clinking went on, until finally there came a sharp snap—the lock tumbled—and the door was pushed open with a long, creaking "squeeeak." The hinges had gone years without oiling; stiff and dry as an old person's joints, they sliced a sharp wound through the silent night.

Oh. Someone had broken in.

If her mother ever found out, there was no telling what kind of scolding was in store—a young woman living alone, and she couldn't even think to prop a chair against the door at night?

Her mother had always been uneasy about the world: checking the gas four or five times before leaving the house, peering into the back seat before getting into a car, never once letting her return a stranger's nod or smile.

Mai Minghe had always thought her mother was a bit too anxious—but here she was, someone actually breaking through her front door tonight.

The sounds that followed were hard to make out, but vaguely, a figure moved inside. Through the crack under the door, a beam of light swept back and forth—a flashlight.

Unfamiliar footsteps padded softly around the living room, occasionally drawing out a creak, and Mai Minghe knew: that was the wooden floorboard just outside the kitchen. A pipe had burst one year, and the boards there had warped from the soaking, ever since voicing their shrill complaints underfoot.

Having a burglar was actually a rather unusual thing.

She closed her eyes again and listened carefully to the burglar's movements.

He opened the door to the next room first—a very small, narrow room that had never really been used. It had once been painted as a nursery, then briefly served as a study, then been converted into a wardrobe room, yet not one of those purposes had ever truly been fulfilled; now it was simply a dusty storage room piled with clutter.

One glance would be enough to see that the room was heaped with nothing but junk, not worth rifling through—and sure enough, the footsteps retreated almost immediately, and the door was shut with a dull thud.

Honestly, if you searched the whole building, you'd probably struggle to find anything of real value.

Things did go missing often enough in this low-rent apartment building; once, when Mai Minghe hadn't latched her door properly, she came home to find a pair of ankle boots gone from the shoe rack by the entrance—it had infuriated her enough to knock on every neighbor's door, but nothing came of it. Still, lost things were one matter; it was rare for an outside burglar to actually pick a lock and go to all this trouble over people with so little to their name.

How funny—such a trivial thing, and she remembered it so clearly. Those boots had been calfskin, a smooth, polished brown, sharp-looking; she had never managed to find a pair she liked as well after that.

Whatever he wanted to take, let him take it—she didn't have anything worth making a fuss over anyway.

The burglar made his way to the bedroom doorway, pushed the door open, and the flashlight swept in, finding Mai Minghe at once.

The harsh white light pressed through her eyelids and lit up her face, yet she remained perfectly still, keeping her eyes shut, feigning sleep.

An unfamiliar voice let out a surprised "Huh?" as though genuinely taken aback.

Mai Minghe held herself still and kept quiet.

The burglar's footsteps thumped into the room; he circled around the bedroom, didn't even open the nightstand drawer, and went back out again.

Stealing things so carelessly—what could he possibly hope to find? Mai Minghe almost felt anxious on his behalf. You had to have a little patience in whatever you did, a willingness to see things through properly.

A minute or two passed, and he came back in, stopping at the side of Mai Minghe's bed; the warm, living breath of another person hovered in the air just above her.

"Hey," a man's voice said, and a hand gave Mai Minghe's bony shoulder a nudge. "Hey, wake up."

There didn't seem to be much point pretending to sleep any longer.

Why wake her up? If he was looking for something valuable, couldn't he just look for himself? Not only was he stealing things, he was being lazy about it too—people these days, honestly.

Mai Minghe opened her eyes. A dark silhouette was hunched over her at the bedside, looming above her head.

The flashlight was angled down along the edge of the bed, so the burglar's face was lost in shadow; at the rim of the light, she could just make out a pale throat, the Adam's apple rising and falling with each word.

"Don't be afraid, I just want to ask you something. Is there someone here by the name of Mai Minghe?"

"...That's me. Do we know each other?"

The man drew a breath and straightened up, taking in the shape beneath the covers.

"You—you're her?" He seemed unwilling to believe it, and raised the flashlight to sweep it over Mai Minghe's face several more times, without any ceremony.

She hadn't looked in a mirror for a long time and had no idea what she looked like now—certainly nothing good.

"What is it?" she asked quietly.

The man stood there with his mouth half open, as though still digesting something.

He didn't want her to be Mai Minghe—that much she could see; because he immediately asked again, as if she might not have heard him clearly: "Mai—the 'mai' in wild wheat. Mai—Ming—He."

"It's me," Mai Minghe said with a faint smile. "There's no one else."

The man stared at her.

After a few seconds, he asked: "Old lady, how old are you?"

How old was she? Even Mai Minghe had to stop and think.

She couldn't remember, from some year onward, how old she was—sometimes she even mistook herself for a young girl.

A year per year of age: it didn't sound like much, yet those years were like snowflakes falling thick and countless, each one an infinitesimal moment; without her noticing, they had accumulated into a lifetime.

Scoop up a handful of snow, and you don't know when it fell. A passage of life rises to the surface, and she has forgotten how long ago it came from.

The social worker had said that at her age—eighty-six—Mai Minghe's mind was still fairly clear, unlike some elderly people...

"Eighty-six?" Mai Minghe asked the social worker in her memory. "You must be mistaken. I'm not nearly that old."

The room fell quiet again, and the steady "whooo—whooo" of background noise rose once more.

The burglar seemed to notice it only now. He pointed at the small plastic tube inserted in Mai Minghe's nose and asked, "Is that... are you on oxygen?"

"Hm?" Mai Minghe sometimes forgot. "Oh, yes. It's quite a nuisance."

The burglar let out a sigh. He set the flashlight down on the edge of the bed, its beam casting a circle of light on the opposite wall, splitting the room—cutting out a bright ring of warmth, and leaving the rest to dim, heavy darkness.

"Look at me, I forgot to ask. Would you like some tea?" said Mai Minghe. It had been so long since anyone had visited that she had quite forgotten to be a host. "It's hard for me to get up... there's tea and biscuits in the kitchen, please help yourself."

The burglar shifted uncomfortably, as though he hadn't expected this turn of events.

"No, I'm fine," he said, hesitating a moment before adding: "But... would you like some? I can bring it to you."

Mai Minghe declined and thanked him; host and burglar exchanged polite pleasantries for a little while.

The burglar clasped his hands together and stared at the television in the corner of the room for a long moment before asking it: "Your health isn't good?"

"I'm quite all right—I can still get out of bed and walk on my own."

"...What about meals? Does a son or daughter come to bring you food?"

"I don't have any children," she said with a small smile. "And I don't eat much—anything simple will do... the social worker brings me vegetables and eggs now and then."

"A social worker? Do you have no family in Blackmoor City?"

"I'm used to it," Mai Minghe said. "I never had many relatives or friends to begin with, and they've all died before me. Dear, would you like to watch television?"

The burglar seemed to find the question absurd. He was silent for a moment, then suddenly took out his phone and glanced at it, and walked quickly out of the room.

"Hello?"

So he was taking a call.

"Yes, I've found her... no, I haven't done it yet." The burglar paused here, faltering. "The thing is—did you know she's an old woman? Eighty-six years old. That wasn't in the file."

The reply from the other end was brief, because the burglar spoke again almost immediately.

"Yes," the burglar said, not bothering to lower his voice—perhaps he felt there was no need. "But... does it have to be hers? She's not the only one with a passage. And besides, we don't even know what her passage is like... taking it would be hard on a young person—what about her? What if she can't hold on and dies?"

The person on the phone was very displeased; even Mai Minghe seemed to catch the faint sound of a raised voice.

The burglar bore it in silence for a time, and at last, like a student admitting a mistake, said: "No... I understand. I'm sorry. I'll get it."

Mai Minghe sometimes startled herself at the sight of her own hands.

Thick, wrinkled skin, layer upon layer draped over each bone, blue veins and blood vessels standing out in ridges, almost cold to the touch—nothing like the hands she remembered as her own. They belonged to two different people.

With that hand that seemed not to belong to her, she fumbled beneath the covers for a moment and found the pendant resting on her chest, closing her fingers tightly around it.

This time, the burglar came in and spoke at once: "I'm sorry, old lady. I need to take something from you."

She could just make him out now—he had a bright, regular sort of face, somewhere in his twenties or thirties, still young; if you didn't know, you'd never think him capable of harm.

"What would you like?" Mai Minghe asked. "I don't have much use for things anymore—take them. There's a silver brooch in the drawer..."

"No, I don't want valuables," the burglar interrupted. "I need to take something from your body."

"Is it an organ?" Mai Minghe asked, curious. Her organs hardly seemed worth taking.

"No, no, stop asking. You wouldn't understand even if I explained."

"Then... will I die?" Mai Minghe asked. "You said so just now."

The burglar was caught off guard; he went still for two seconds before saying, "I don't know... possibly."

Mai Minghe quietly studied the cracks in the ceiling for a while.

"If you need to take it, take it," she said softly. "It's just... before you do, could you grant me one wish?"

At some point the burglar had come to stand beside her.

"What wish?"

"I used to work at a library. The pay was very little, but I loved the library—I was happy there... Once, when my shift ended, one of the librarians told me there was an old book they were retiring; it hadn't sold at the clearance price, so they gave it to me to take home and read."

The burglar rested a hand on her pillow.

At his feet was a dark, bulky shape—some kind of machine—that seemed to have been brought in at some point without her noticing; Mai Minghe was only seeing it now.

"I looked, and it was a poetry anthology; I flipped through it idly when I got home," Mai Minghe murmured. "I read a little, put the book down, and later even lost track of where it went. But somehow... these past few years, I keep thinking back to one poem that was in it."

"Which poem?"

"You young people—don't you all have those... smart telephones?"

"Smartphones," the burglar corrected.

If she had a grandchild, she might have been corrected just like this.

"They say you can find anything on them?"

"...More or less."

"Could you look up that poem for me?" Mai Minghe asked. "I want to hear it one more time."

The burglar looked down at her, and something in his expression shifted—a sudden unease. He pulled a tissue from the nightstand box and pressed it into her hand. While Mai Minghe stared at it blankly, not understanding, he said: "All right, stop crying. I'll find it for you. Do you remember the title?"

She was crying?

So even at this age, she could not accept death.

Or perhaps it was that, even at this age, she had not yet had the chance to truly live.

"It's called... something with Daisy in the title." Mai Minghe deliberately left out half the title.

Smartphones held a great deal, but searching for a poem was no easy matter—and daisy was such a common image in poetry—so it took a good while, as she expected.

After finding several poems that weren't right one after another, the burglar finally lost patience: "Old lady, if you don't remember the name, that's not my fault. I still have to get back and hand in the job—you—"

"I've remembered," Mai Minghe said quickly.

This young man who had come to take something from her—he was likely the last person in her life who could let her hear a poem one more time.

Even if she could no longer put it off—even if she had to face death—it would still be a good thing to hear a little more poetry first.

"I Shall Pick More Daisies'... I think that's what it's called."

The young man glanced at her, said nothing, and tapped his fingers across the screen a few times.

This time, he quickly found the poem that Mai Minghe had kept returning to.

"I found a read-aloud video for you," he said, setting the phone on the edge of the bed.

In the quiet room thick with the smell of medicine and decay, the advertisement before the video burst cheerfully to life, announcing a deal at Little Caesars Pizza.

"The ad's almost done—you just listen. You listen while I work."

He bent down and pulled a tube from the dark, squat machine.

...If I had my life to live over,

I would try to make more mistakes.

I would relax.

I would be more limber.

I would be sillier than I have been this trip.

Mai Minghe felt the side of her face grow damp.

She had spent her whole life in anxious calculation, just as her parents had. During wartime inflation, she painstakingly rationed every meal; in peacetime, she kept a household ledger every week. When she was a child, her family ran a small shop, and no matter how desperately she wanted to, she never once dared to steal a single candy from the shelves.

As she grew older she came to many crossroads thick with wildflowers, but she never set foot in them.

People are strange—everyone knows they only have this one life, yet every single day is lived as though there is infinite time left, as though it can all be done again.

The thief lifted the blanket and pressed a cool tube against Mai Minghe's chest, and she dimly realized that the thing looked rather like an old-fashioned vacuum cleaner.

"What's this?" The thief picked up the pendant at her chest, glanced at it, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to answer, pushed it aside from the mouth of the tube. Young people generally didn't recognize it—had no idea what the thing was for.

Lucky for her that he didn't.

Amid the poem, he pressed the mouth of the tube against Mai Minghe's bony chest. He switched on the machine, and a low hum unlike anything she had ever heard slowly spiraled through the room.

...If I had my life to live over, I would travel lighter than I have. I would start barefoot earlier in the spring and stay that way later in the fall.

If I had my life to live over, I would go barefoot through the long springs and autumns.

I would play hooky more.

I wouldn't make such good grades, except by accident.

I would ride on more merry-go-rounds.

I would pick more daisies.

In the final instant that the darkness of death closed over Mai Minghe, she faintly heard the front door of the apartment burst open, and hurried footsteps and voices came rushing in together.

Carried to term for years, and at last delivered a homely child...

"I Shall Pick More Daisies" is a real poem. The poet wrote it when she was eighty-five—one year younger than my daughter. The inspiration wasn't actually the poem itself; it was only after I'd started writing that I suddenly remembered it and thought it fit perfectly.

My, it's been so long since I've updated or rambled on like this—I'm almost embarrassed, and I'm not quite sure what to say.

Thank you for coming back.

Chapter 2: Mai Minghe Rescued from Hallucination?

"You live alone,"

the social worker unfolded a small brochure to show her and said, "If you fall, no one would know—it's too dangerous. Best to get one you can wear around your neck; it won't get in the way. What do you think?"

That was many years ago now.

Mai Minghe still remembered that brochure. The product's name was blunt and to the point: "Life Alert."

The image showed a white-haired woman collapsed on the floor, with two lines of small text: "Help! I've fallen and I can't get up!"

Her older cousin had shattered her pelvis in her eighties and never got out of bed again; once you're bedridden, your days are numbered.

What year had she passed? Mai Minghe couldn't remember anymore.

The legs that had once carried her leaping onto rooftops and running wild—in the blink of an eye, even getting out of bed now required guarding against their betrayal.

The body that had followed her all her life had slowly become something foreign; she was like a stiff wheel turning slower and slower with each revolution, powerless to stop it.

"The Emergency Response System is available twenty-four hours a day, every day of the year," the social worker explained, worried she couldn't make out the text on the brochure. "No matter what the emergency, one press and someone will come... let me see—oh, they promise a maximum response time of thirty minutes, and there are participating hospitals nearby."

Mai Minghe took the brochure and studied the pictures for a moment.

She had scraped and saved every penny her whole life, but now money had suddenly lost its weight; prices were nothing but curved little symbols.

"I'll take this one," she said, pointing to the third model. "This one's the nicest-looking. Like a pendant on a necklace."

The social worker let out a laugh. "Great—it'll look lovely on you, I'm sure."

Though it looked nothing like a necklace, she wore it like one anyway; she'd been wearing it that way for years, and the first time she ever pressed the Life Alert was the night the thief walked into her living room to make a phone call.

The thief probably hadn't expected that the "necklace" on her chest was an alarm—the young and the old live in two worlds that are nearly sealed off from each other; unless you have regular reason to deal with elderly people, few know what their lives look like, let alone what things they see and use day to day.

Starting from when she'd made the thief hunt for the poem... she'd tried every trick she could think of, and had bought herself more than ten minutes by now.

No one had come yet, and she was on the verge of losing consciousness.

For some reason, the cold tube defied gravity—it stood straight upright on her chest with no one holding it. The machine hummed steadily, the sound of the poem grew more and more distant, and she sank into wave after wave of dizzy darkness, going deeper and deeper.

From the depths of that darkness, fragments of hallucination floated up like the shards of a dream.

Strange—they say that when a person is dying, they see the memories of their whole life; but all Mai Minghe saw was another version of herself, a tube connected to her chest just the same, walking step by step toward the television, then suddenly lunging forward and crashing into the screen.

She was startled by her own actions, and dimly heard a dull, wet sound from somewhere inside her chest.

With eyes half-open and half-closed, hallucination and reality overlapped; her hallucinated self slammed into the old television in the corner of the room again and again, and the screen erupted into spider-web cracks each time.

The hallucination was finally shattered by a sharp shout—an unfamiliar, low, rough voice called out: "What are you doing? Who are you?"

Mai Minghe jolted, and her eyes opened slightly.

Through her blurred vision, she saw an ink-black, lustrous tube standing upright on her chest—it seemed more alive than she was, pressing down on her with a heavy weight and pinning her to the bed.

The next moment, the tube vanished.

The thief snatched the tube behind his back, and despite his panic, kept his wits about him; he turned the question on the two people who had just burst into the bedroom: "Who are you? Why are you suddenly barging into my grandmother's house?"

Two people strode briskly in through the doorway, switched on the lights, and drove out the night; the room blazed white and bright, revealing a bedroom filled with decay, the smell of medicine, cracks in the walls, and the steady whoosh of an oxygen machine.

They were both wearing blue-and-white uniforms—nurse aides.

"Your grandmother?"

The male nurse aide looked at Mai Minghe, then turned a skeptical eye on the thief. "Her? She's your grandmother?"

"I'm two generations mixed—it doesn't show." The thief seemed to realize the difference in their skin tones and ethnicity, and reacted quickly. "Look, I have dark hair. Who are you people?"

"We're emergency-response nurse aides; we came because we received an alert signal—we thought she had an emergency." The other, a woman's voice, explained. "According to our records, she lives alone."

The thief had already composed himself completely.

"Yes," he said, giving Mai Minghe's arm a gentle pat as if to reassure her, and then addressed the nurse aides: "You responded very quickly—thank you for coming so fast. But there's been a small misunderstanding. I'm in Blackmoor City on a business trip and I'm staying with my grandmother for the time being. She's getting on in years, her mind isn't always clear, and she forgot I was coming—she probably thought I was a stranger and triggered the alert. She's fine."

The female nurse aide walked to the bedside, lifted Mai Minghe's eyelids, examined her, and asked softly, "Ma'am, are you all right?"

Mai Minghe opened her mouth to say something, but only the faintest breath passed between her lips. The female nurse aide had seen this many times before and was not surprised that she couldn't speak; she began listening to her heartbeat.

"Would you mind showing me some identification?" the male nurse aide asked the thief, still a little uncertain.

"Of course," the thief said, and right in front of the nurse aides, coolly and openly kicked the black machine with the tube attached to it under Mai Minghe's bed, muttering as he did so: "Why is the vacuum cleaner sitting there...? One moment—I'll go to the next room for my wallet. My driver's license is in it."

The bed she was lying on now was a hospital-style care bed with four wheels; the space underneath was empty and just right for storing things.

"Oh, my phone—" the thief had only taken a couple of steps before he turned back, smiled at the female nurse aide who was still examining Mai Minghe, and said: "I almost forgot. My grandmother sometimes gets frightened for no reason; I have to play poetry or music for her to calm her down."

The female nurse aide's gaze crossed over Mai Minghe to sweep over the phone screen, and her expression relaxed another degree.

Mai Minghe thought: a thief who breaks in and plays poetry for the homeowner—who would believe that if you told them? It looked far more like a devoted grandchild.

Since she was still alive, that meant the thief hadn't yet managed to take whatever was inside her, right?

Right—otherwise he wouldn't still be here playing the dutiful grandson.

Though if the nurse aides had come a few minutes later, he would have succeeded.

No one knew that death had just been sitting right beside her, leaning over and gazing down at her; she had never been this close to death before, and this was the first time she had ever had a dying hallucination...

That's right—the television!

Even Mai Minghe herself hadn't expected it, but the moment she thought of the hallucination just now, a sudden urge arose out of nowhere: she wanted to roll out of bed and go touch the television.

She had to get over there—had to get over there and look, quickly...

Driven by wave after wave of urgency crashing through her, Mai Minghe was so anxious she nearly cried out.

The dark, black television screen had become the only thing in the world with any weight to it—it pressed heavily into her field of vision and drew her toward it; the room, the nurse aides, and the thief were about as substantial as sheets of paper, and seemed on the verge of floating away.

Mai Minghe strained to lift her hand toward the television.

"Ma'am, what's the matter? What do you need?" The female nurse aide followed the direction of her raised hand, turned to look, and asked, "Do you want to watch TV?"

The door to the storage room next door opened and closed again, as if the thief had genuinely gone in to retrieve something. He had just returned as the female nurse aide spoke, handing his ID to the male nurse aide; the latter looked it over, and when he spoke again, both his tone and his posture had eased.

Mai Minghe let out a sound from her nose—a syllable of negation—but kept her hand pointing at the television.

"I'll turn it on for you," the female nurse aide said; though puzzled, she was kind about it, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to respond, switched the television on.

The television was replaying a daytime news commentary program; the host was going over and over the sudden death of Blackmoor City magnate Wellesley from the day before, recounting his business triumphs and charitable works.

"No... no." Mai Minghe finally found her voice again, which was a quiet relief—good, she could speak; her strength was coming back.

The thief quickly swept his gaze over her.

He immediately turned back to the male nurse aide, picking up the thread of what he'd been saying: "...My grandmother is getting on in years—the more confused her mind gets, the more stubborn she becomes. There's no family in Blackmoor City who can look after her..."

Such a young age, and already spinning one lie after another.

Telling them this person wasn't her grandson would probably do no good. An ordinary thief wouldn't stay on the scene to negotiate; from the nurse aides' perspective, between him being a thief and her being a senile old woman, she was the more likely candidate.

Never mind that—the television was more important and more urgent than him right now.

"Help me... help me over there." Mai Minghe pointed at the television and said quietly to the female nurse aide: "Please."

The thief glanced at her again, then looked at the television.

Before he could get a word in, the male nurse aide's question pulled away his attention: "When we arrived, you were hunched over holding a tube—what were you doing?"

"You don't have to go over there—you can watch it from here." The female nurse aide was a little hesitant.

The thief was explaining: "My grandmother cried out in the middle of the night and woke me up; I came to check on her and found the vacuum cleaner hose had fallen onto the bed."

"Please," Mai Minghe gripped the female nurse aide's hand tightly, fixed her eyes on those brown eyes, and begged: "Help me over there. Please. I... I just want to sit there for a moment."

She was coming across more and more like a muddled old woman.

"All right, I'll help you." The female nurse aide gave in. "Can you get up?"

"Yes, yes."

The thief glanced at Mai Minghe once more and, seemingly out of concern, came over on his own initiative to support her—also conveniently extricating himself from the male nurse aide's questioning. "Grandma, what do you want to go over there for? You can take a look, but then you have to come back and sleep, all right?"

Mai Minghe ignored him. He seemed like such a decent-looking young man—what on earth was he doing?

With both of them supporting her, she shuffled unsteadily to the television set; her own pale, ghostly half-reflection floated on the screen, then disappeared as the broadcast cut to footage of the Wellesley Family Estate.

She understood now.

So there really had been a reason for the hallucination after all, Mai Minghe thought.

No wonder she had felt such urgency to come over—well, she should have thought of it sooner; at her age, her mind really wasn't what it used to be.

"I'll get a chair," the female nurse aide said, and let go of Mai Minghe.

That left only the thief holding her. He held her thin, dried-up arm in a loose, light grip, as if he didn't dare exert any force.

"If everything's all right, then we'll be on our way." The male nurse aide stood in the doorway and asked the thief, "Can you get her back to bed on your own in a bit?"

The thief exhaled in relief. He nodded repeatedly and said, "Of course—sorry for making you come all the way out here..."

While he was speaking, Mai Minghe suddenly pulled her arm free, let her body fall backward, and toppled toward the television screen.

She should have thought of it sooner—her hallucination had been telling her how to save herself.

If she fell against the television right in front of the nurse aides, they would have no choice but to send her to the hospital—no matter what the thief claimed to be, right? At the hospital, with plenty of people around, she would be safe.

From the corner of her eye she saw the thief's head snap toward her, but he was a beat too slow and couldn't make it in time; Mai Minghe heard the dull, heavy crack of her skull against the television, and then the room erupted with startled cries and the sound of rushing footsteps.

The female social worker seemed to call out something from very far away, but Mai Minghe couldn't make out the words—

"Where did she go?"

Posted yesterday

but I didn't expect to actually start the book

It's only two chapters—no rush to collect on that debt yet, let's wait and see; what if the later chapters aren't good? Qidian doesn't do refunds on tips, you know.

The same goes for 95, 秋水不染尘, 相声福晋, 绾瑾, 颖佑, 西下有木名栗, 039追女娲? , 卡夫卡, and everyone else—are you all angel investors? I'm flattered and terrified...

Full disclosure: the book launches on the 12th, and I have to leave town on the 14th... My stockpile of advance chapters definitely won't survive the combination of travel chaos and bonus-chapter donations—looks like I'll be pecking away at the keyboard on the plane again.

PS: I saw some readers asking why this is posted on the male-frequency channel when it's a strong-female-lead feature. The editors have their reasons, actually—a large portion of male-frequency readers are women who don't visit the female-frequency side, so a strong-female-lead feature on the male channel is meant to draw them in; think of it as poaching readers for the female channel's benefit (?).

Chapter 3: The Sweet Illusion in Mai Minghe's Hospital Ward

As the world spun around her, Mai Minghe instinctively grabbed at a white shape nearby, but still couldn't steady herself—she stumbled and sat down hard on the ice-cold tile floor, letting out a hoarse groan.

This is bad. Could she have broken a bone?

The pain blurred her vision completely, and she couldn't even tell which bone it was that might be the death of her—one single fall was all it took to shatter her, scatter her into pieces across the floor.

After a fall like this, the nurse aide should have taken her to the hospital no matter what; yet as she caught her breath, the nurse aide who should have come rushing never appeared, and no one asked if she was all right.

What was going on?

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes and looked carefully, and couldn't help but freeze.

...This wasn't her room.

The room was dim and murky; by the thin sliver of white light seeping in under the door, she could vaguely make out that it was a very large space. In front of her and behind her stood an empty narrow bed on either side, and what she had grabbed turned out to be a corner of a bed sheet.

She let go of the sheet and looked left and right.

A row of wheeled care beds, each with a small bedside cabinet, each with a curtain divider—this was clearly a hospital ward. She had been hospitalized several times before and could recognize one at a glance.

How strange.

How had she ended up in a hospital ward? The nurse aides must have brought her here, right?

But how could she have completely forgotten the whole process of being sent to the hospital? It was as if it had never happened—as if a black hole had opened up in her memory.

Mai Minghe suppressed her panic and pain, and no matter how hard she tried to think, the last moment she could recall was still slamming into the television; she remembered the world tilting in the midst of searing pain, and then the next second, she had fallen onto the hospital ward floor.

It was as though she had fallen straight from her home into the hospital—but that was impossible.

Had she lost consciousness at the time and forgotten because of that?

"Is anyone there?" Mai Minghe called out in a hoarse voice. "Nurse? I've fallen..."

In the cold, silent ward, her cry for help was like a chip of broken ice slowly sinking into a cold river, as if it had never existed.

Whether from pain or cold, she trembled uncontrollably in waves. If this went on, something would surely go wrong—she had to call the nurse quickly. Right, there was usually a call bell at the head of the hospital bed.

Mai Minghe struggled to push herself upright, trying to stand, but the pain in her leg bones wouldn't allow it; her hands and feet went limp and weightless, and she slipped, nearly falling again.

There was nothing else for it—she had no choice but to crawl inch by inch toward the bedside cabinet, prop herself against its edge, stretch her arm out as hard as she could, and just barely graze the call bell button with her fingertips.

"If I were you, I wouldn't press that."

The man's voice came out of nowhere and sent a jolt through Mai Minghe's chest; her blood rushed up as though it might burst her brain.

She steadied herself through the dizziness and turned her head toward the sound, only then noticing that there was another bed behind her.

The bed curtain was drawn, but not all the way—a pair of feet belonging to the patient in the adjacent bed were visible.

Those feet were bare, nothing on them at all, snow-white as if dusted with heavy powder, the toes curled ever so slightly, not moving at all.

Mai Minghe couldn't help but feel a rush of relief—thank goodness, there was someone else in the room.

"Are you—are you also a patient here?" she asked, still breathless as she spoke; even as she spoke, she reached toward the call bell again.

"You really want to call the nurse?" the patient behind the curtain asked in return.

"Yes... I've fallen and I have no choice but to call."

For something minor, she wouldn't bother the nurses in the middle of the night if she could help it—Mai Minghe actually understood the adjacent patient's concern.

She pressed the call bell, and not a single sound rang out in the room.

"There, you went and pressed it anyway."

The patient in the adjacent bed knew all the same, and laughed—a stiff, flat laugh, as though each contraction of the diaphragm were deliberate and conscious, every segment precisely equal in length.

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and slowly slid down to sit on the floor, her entire body sinking into exhausted helplessness; but she quietly stole a glance at the curtain from the corner of her eye.

"Won't listen to advice... people really do get more stubborn as they get older. I was saying it for your own good."

"What... do you mean?"

The other person laughed again, two stiff and measured bursts, but gave no answer.

Something felt off, though she couldn't say exactly why.

Mai Minghe was still hesitating over whether to ask again when a deafeningly loud broadcast suddenly tore through the dead-silent corridor outside—an electronic female voice blared and echoed, reverberating through the ward door: "Room three, bed 03, calling nurse. Room three, bed 03, calling nurse!"

The broadcast gave her a fright, and a terrible jolt burst through her chest; she pressed one hand tightly over her heart—relieved that someone was coming, yet unable to stop a creeping unease from rising.

...Strange—normally, after pressing the call bell, would a broadcast go off? This loud, in the middle of the night—weren't they afraid of disturbing people's rest?

Could this be some new rule at hospitals these days?

The broadcast stopped.

In the silent room, for a moment there was nothing but Mai Minghe's trembling breaths.

"Please be advised," the broadcast suddenly blared again at the same staggering volume, startling her once more: "A figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at Room Three within five seconds. Countdown: five—four—three—"

Mai Minghe froze.

She must have been going deaf and blind, mishearing things—otherwise why would she think the broadcast had said "a figure disguised as a nurse"?

The patient in the adjacent bed began to chuckle again, the laughter chopped into segments.

"What the broadcast just said..."

Before Mai Minghe could finish the question, there came a sudden bang—the ward door was slammed hard into the wall, the ear-splitting crash making her chest tighten with a deep, dull ache.

As the ward door flew open, white light from the corridor poured in; standing in that white light was a thin, elongated, extremely tall dark shape, its head cut off by the doorframe above.

The shadow rotated its right shoulder, stepped forward with its right foot—as though its joints were misaligned and stiff—and lurched crookedly one step through the doorway, its head still left outside.

That could not possibly be a nurse.

The thought sharpened the radiating pain pulsing outward from her left chest in waves, her entire left arm as though someone had seized the tendons and was pulling them free; soon she felt herself unable to breathe.

"Oh? It's one of those?"

The patient in the adjacent bed began to laugh with rhythmic contractions of the chest, the snow-white feet beyond the curtain still utterly motionless.

"Say you're unlucky, and yet what came isn't a Resident; say you're lucky, and yet... at this exact moment, you've gone and had a heart attack—so you still won't make it out alive."

The shadow rotated its left shoulder, stepped forward with its left foot, its head swaying and scraping along the wall as it entered; angling its body, it took another step toward bed three.

From far beyond the wide-open door, someone bellowed in fury: "Who's closest?... Get to Room Three now and cut them off! Don't let whoever pressed that bell escape—the nerve, stealing our things!"

...What was happening?

Would she survive this day?

The shadow was backlit, and no matter how much Mai Minghe squinted, she couldn't make out its face. It walked with both arms and legs on the same side swinging together, and though it seemed to take only two or three steps, it had already reached the foot of the bed, trapping her between the two beds.

She wanted to ask who it was, but she could no longer speak.

Someone was sprinting down the corridor toward her, the pounding footsteps growing louder and louder until she could almost feel the floor shaking; the shadow paid no heed to the noise outside and swayed steadily closer until it loomed directly before Mai Minghe.

Was this... a person? she wondered dimly, at the edge of death. That couldn't be, could it?

Before she could understand, this life of hers was about to reach its end.

The shadow slowly bent down toward her.

Though her consciousness was fading, Mai Minghe finally saw clearly the first face she had encountered since entering this hospital.

Beneath a mass of wild dark hair, what extended from the neck was an oval, smooth, hard mirror-surface. Below the mirror, there was nothing but darkness.

It was not a person wearing a mirror over their face.

Where a face should have been, there was not the slightest contour of features or bone—only a mirror in its place, grown out from the surrounding flesh, angled directly at Mai Minghe.

Her aged, withered face was reflected in the mirror, and in that moment, it was as though the one bending down toward her was Mai Minghe herself.

Was she inside a dream right now? A mirror for a face, a heart attack—it was all a dream, surely.

Before dying, she had actually seen something so... extraordinary.

Dream or reality, this was at least the first time in her life she had glimpsed something beyond the ordinary—and it would be the last.

Mai Minghe made no expression, yet the old face in the mirror smiled faintly, the way a person smiles when they have reached a point of helplessness and have no other choice.

The reflection of her opened its mouth, lips parting and closing, speaking soundlessly to the Mai Minghe outside the mirror.

If I could live again...

I would ride the merry-go-round to my heart's content,

I would go everywhere, try everything,

...I would pick more daisies.

Mai Minghe could not move at all—whether her mind had been stilled by some outside force, or whether her old, exhausted heart, on the verge of sleep, could simply no longer be roused.

The lips in the mirror grew more and more indistinct, harder and harder to read; the shadow continued drawing slowly closer, and finally enveloped her completely.

...If you were given the chance to begin again, what would you do with it to make this new life worthwhile?

The thick, tangled, coarse black hair pressed against Mai Minghe's forehead; she was submerged in dense darkness, unable to see anything. Two arms, grotesquely long, wound around her body again and again, pulling tighter and tighter, until it felt as though the bones inside her would be snapped one by one—

"Let go of me,"

Just as the breath in her chest was about to be cut off, Mai Minghe finally struggled and shoved with both hands—but she met no resistance as she had expected, and her hands pushed

through empty air.

She quickly steadied herself and scrambled up from the floor, only then realizing that there was nothing before her at all—the shadow had vanished.

Wait...

It dawned on Mai Minghe belatedly.

She had just jumped to her feet—easily, cleanly, without any difficulty at all?

Mai Minghe raised a hand and pressed it to her chest; the pain was as though it had never existed, and from deep within, there came a steady, familiar rhythm.

Her hands... seemed a little different.

Mai Minghe raised both hands and found that the skin was full and smooth, the nails clear and lustrous, without a single fold of excess wrinkled skin. She lowered her head and stared blankly at what showed below the hem of her pajama pants—a pair of legs, evenly fleshed, fair and strong.

She had to have gone mad.

Youth, it turned out, was a sweet illusion—fierce and full to bursting, so overwhelming it left one at a loss.

For a moment she forgot everything, and frantically explored her own body: her fingers plunged into thick, abundant hair; her arms and thighs had the firm muscles she had long been without; her back had straightened, her height risen... Mai Minghe let out a breathless "ha" of a laugh, her voice trembling.

A clear, young voice she hadn't heard in at least several decades flowed into the cold air of the ward.

From the other side of decay, darkness, and ash, she had somehow been released—born into the world a second time—but wait, was any of this real?

"In here!"

A sharp shout rang out at the doorway, and Mai Minghe jolted upright, lifting her head.

Her vision was no longer clouded and grey; even in the dim light, she could clearly see a man burst in through the door, his face filled with deep wariness.

"There's a woman in here, but I don't see the Artifact."

The man fixed his eyes on Mai Minghe and called out to his companions behind him, then snapped at her: "Which House are you a Hunter for? You've got the item on you, don't you? You have the nerve to steal the Artifact Mr. Wellesley wants?"

"What?" Mai Minghe asked blankly, her mind a tangled mess of confusion—the man's question, rambling as nonsense, had to seep through the cracks of that tangle before even a little of it could reach her.

The man was about to step inside when his eyes swept to something beside her and he stopped dead in his tracks.

"Get in here, all of you," he called to those outside the door. "There's a Resident in Room Three!"

A Resident? What was he talking about?

From that brief glance just now, it seemed like there was something in the room—not far from her at all.

Mai Minghe turned his gaze in a daze and found that the originally empty Bed No. 3 beside her had its curtain drawn at some point.

The curtain wasn't fully closed, revealing a pair of feet so snow-white they looked as though they'd been dusted with powder; the toes were splayed out to either side, frozen still, not moving at all.

...Huh? Wasn't he on the bed next to her just now?

When had he moved over to Bed No. 3?

"Calling you 'old lady' wouldn't be right anymore," the patient behind the curtain said with a laugh. "I should be calling you 'young lady' now. Young lady, what you just got your hands on is a rare and wonderful thing. How about letting me take a look?"

I'm boarding a flight today—the pressure to update has kicked in, so I'll have to write on the plane. I just hope whoever sits next to me isn't one of those screen-peekers. One time I was writing an apocalypse story on a plane, and the guy one seat over suddenly grew five centimeters of neck, like a crane, and twisted it all the way over to ask me: "You writing a novel? What's it about?"

Makes you wonder if nearsightedness really isn't widespread enough.

(Why do I keep catching flights and going on long trips—truly an unsolvable mystery…)

Chapter 4: Mai Minghe Seizes a Second Life

By any reasonable logic, three to five tall, built, hostile strangers pouring in through the door should have been the most alarming threat, right?

No matter how you looked at it, they were still more dangerous than a patient lying in a hospital bed.

And yet, somehow, Mai Minghe couldn't help but fix her gaze on the pair of white feet peeking out from behind the curtain. Her heartbeat thundered in her ears like rolling drums; her palms were cold and clammy—and she couldn't spare so much as a glance for the strangers.

She was wedged between the Bed 03 patient and Bed 02, with the bedside cabinet and wall at her back. The path ahead was blocked by the intruders, and there was no way out.

She stole another glance at the patient in the next bed.

Compared to when she had first seen them, the feet looked slightly different now—she couldn't say exactly how—but looking at them now triggered something instinctive, something biological, a revulsion so deep she almost wanted to open her mouth and heave out everything: the sight before her eyes, the air she'd breathed that had touched those feet, along with every organ in her body.

Looking up again, she could tell the strangers might be feeling the same way: for all their ferocious swagger when they'd barged in, their eyes were now drifting upward, not one of them willing to lower their gaze to the feet on the bed—at a glance, they looked exactly like a group of blind men who had all just taken off their dark glasses at the same moment.

Mai Minghe wiped her nose.

Perhaps terror and tension had wound too tight, and her nervous system was seeking release; perhaps the return of youth carried an intoxicating, surging magic that even fear couldn't dispel; or perhaps it was simply that the people across from her looked too comical—whatever the reason, she suddenly couldn't hold it in, and burst out laughing.

"How did you manage that?"

She stifled her laughter, not wanting those people to think she belonged in a psychiatric ward. She turned to the patient in the next bed and said: "I don't know why, but one look at you and my

guts start churning. You'd make a great side job here at the hospital—stomach-pumping."

The red-haired man who seemed to be the leader didn't say a word, but the expression on his face said everything about what he thought of Mai Minghe—not quite right in the head.

"Miss,"

the male voice from behind the curtain was like a bag of stones clogged with thick phlegm—hearing it was indescribably unpleasant. "This is your first time in the Nest, isn't it?"

Since just moments ago, Mai Minghe had heard a string of incomprehensible terms: a figure disguised as a nurse, Hunters, Artifacts... and now another one had been added—the Nest.

"This isn't a hospital?" Mai Minghe asked.

Though it was a question, she already had the answer clear as a mirror in her mind: of course this wasn't a hospital.

She had somehow ended up in this place called the "Nest"; and that "somehow," it seemed, had a great deal to do with her falling onto the television set.

"But it is a hospital—why wouldn't it be?" the patient behind the curtain answered, in a tone that was almost friendly. "A hospital inside the Nest is still a hospital."

Mai Minghe stalled for time, thinking as she spoke: "You say this is the Nest, but you don't look much like a chicken to me."

The red-haired man let out a sound through his nose—something he'd tried and failed to suppress—and covered it with a cough.

"Doesn't even know what the Nest is," one of the people by the door muttered to a companion in a low voice. "Really is her first time in. No wonder she's still in her pajamas."

"But if it's her first time here, how could she have gotten hold of an Artifact?" another murmured.

"Wait and see," the red-haired man instructed. "Be ready—if she can't hold on, we'll have to take it from the Resident."

As they spoke, they treated Mai Minghe as though she barely existed—or rather, as though she were something that was about to cease to exist very soon.

In the span of just a minute or two, far too many incomprehensible things had happened; right now, Mai Minghe could only hold tightly to two facts.

First, after entering the Nest, she had regained her youth. Second, the thing that had restored her youth seemed to be the objective both parties were after.

Even knowing nothing else, she knew that she was like a child carrying a fortune through a busy marketplace—more like a ghost market—and that was not a good position to be in.

Behind the curtain, there was dead silence; two bare feet, pale-blue and white, rested with their toes hooked over the footrail of the bed.

"What do you want?" Mai Minghe stared at the feet behind the curtain and asked, knowing full well the answer. "How about this—you tell me what's going on, and I'll give you whatever you want. Nice and peaceful, wouldn't that be better?"

The patient behind the curtain considered for two seconds.

"Feel around on your body," his voice had calmed somewhat—less painful to listen to than before—though he still refused to explain further, only saying: "You should be able to feel something. Take it off and give it to me."

Mai Minghe reached her hand inside her pajamas and felt along her back and lower abdomen; the moment she touched it, she flinched.

Slightly raised, ice-cold, band-like things wound around her torso in layer after layer—to the touch, it was exactly like a great snake coiled around her body.

Right—that dark shadowy arm from earlier had seemed to wrap around her just like this, in ring after ring.

"Found it, haven't you," the patient in the next bed suddenly hissed, mucus churning in his throat. "Give it to me."

Mai Minghe traced the edge of the "snake-band" and felt that it seemed deeply reluctant to separate from her skin; she would have to use some force to wedge her fingertips between the band and her flesh.

"Alright, alright, I know, I'll give it to you." It could indeed be removed—she lifted her hand, and had already peeled the "snake-band" up slightly.

She thought of another question.

"I had a heart attack just now, and it only stopped after this thing appeared. Once I take it off, will the attack come back?"

"For someone your age, your mind works fast. I don't think so. What it reversed was aging, not illness—the illness disappearing was merely a side effect, and doesn't necessarily come back along with the aging."

The patient in the next bed's voice was thick and viscous. "Of course, I could be wrong—but besides being optimistic, you have no other choice. Now then, take it off."

As he said, she had no other choice.

"Fortunately, I've always been an optimist." Mai Minghe let out a breath, first peeling the "snake-band" away from her lower abdomen, then following it all the way around to her back, working it off her body bit by bit.

The tail of the pitch-black "snake-band" slipped softly out from her pajamas and hung suspended in the air, swaying gently back and forth, as though it were alive.

"Wait—don't give it to him," the red-haired man suddenly barked, stepping forward and spreading both hands wide. "Give it to me—if it comes for me, it'll leave you alone!"

He used the pronoun "it"?

The thought flashed through Mai Minghe's mind; she had no time to dwell on it, but she had already realized this was a lifeline—in this brief sliver of an opening, she might be able to escape the ward and get out alive. Mai Minghe seized the moment and immediately shouted to the red-haired man: "Catch!"

She swung her arm and pulled a dark shape from behind her back, hurling it toward his raised hands.

It may have been her imagination, but Mai Minghe could have sworn that for one fleeting instant, the patient behind the curtain in the next bed was also drawn away for a split second of distraction.

With a smack, the dark shape landed in the red-haired man's hands at the very same moment Mai Minghe seized her chance: she rolled across Bed 02 and dropped to the ground on the other side—the body of a young person was truly so strong, agile, and balanced; the movement was smooth and effortless, so exhilarating that for one brief instant she nearly forgot she was fleeing for her life.

The dark shape, soft and puffed-up, was nestled between two hands, surrounded by a ring of faces staring intently at it.

"A pillow?"

The red-haired man blinked in surprise once he saw what it was, then flung the pillow—which Mai Minghe had taken from Bed 02—onto the floor, and snapped: "Do you want to die at a Resident's hands?"

Mai Minghe had no time to reply; she had only just found her footing when she turned her head and found that the patient had followed—the curtain around Bed 02 had been drawn shut.

But not fully.

The curtain seemed to have been pulled a little wider; at some point, a pair of lower legs had extended out from it, the two knees pressed tightly together, bending over the edge of the bed and hanging down.

The patient in the next bed was lying flat, with only their legs lowered—that in itself was not strange; what was strange was that those bare feet, pale-blue and bloodless, planted flat on the floor, had rotated a full turn at the ankle and were now facing directly toward Mai Minghe.

This felt too much like an absurd dream; if she were to open her eyes in the next moment and wake up in a hospital bed, Mai Minghe would not have been at all surprised.

"Get back,"

the red-haired man said, his face taut, retreating further from Bed 02 along with the others behind him.

It was as though even the air was slowly tightening, thinning out; as though they were wild animals long accustomed to these surroundings, and had sensed the danger one step before Mai Minghe, who understood nothing.

She thought for a moment, then asked the patient in the next bed: "Did you come into the hospital for a broken ankle?"

As she spoke, Mai Minghe had a vague sense of something pulling at her waist.

"Or... you really aren't human?" She called out to the red-haired man: "Hey, young man—if it's not human, what is it? Really a chicken?"

Everything was so unbelievable that she found she'd lost her capacity for shock, and simply wanted to understand what was happening—after all, no one can keep startling themselves too frequently.

The red-haired man didn't answer her.

He and the others behind him were all staring at the lower legs dangling from beside Bed 02 and at the floor, as though Mai Minghe had already been erased from the situation—she just didn't know it yet.

The curtain rustled with a soft shushing sound; someone was slowly drawing it open.

Mai Minghe did not want to see what lay behind the curtain—it couldn't be anything good.

She quickly lowered her head again; when her gaze fell on the pair of feet before her, she noticed that the patient in the next bed's left foot had, at some point, stepped forward.

Though she herself hadn't moved at all, her own left foot had also stepped forward.

Like two old acquaintances reuniting, walking toward each other.

No wonder it felt like something was pulling at her waist...

Strange—why was it that simply seeing the other's feet caused her own feet to move beyond her control, mirroring the other's movements—no, this was not the time for puzzling and reflection.

Even with her head lowered, she could sense from the corner of her eye that the curtain had been drawn open.

On Bed 02 beside her, a long human-shaped shadow lay dimly on the mattress.

Mai Minghe drew a deep breath.

If this had been the Mai Minghe of before, she might have chosen to keep the peace and put self-preservation first, handing the "snake-band" over to it; the first time you're alive, you're always afraid that one wrong move will lead to irreversible, unbearable consequences and make this life a miserable one.

Later, when she had grown old, she found that her decades of life had been filled with nothing but loneliness, regret, and wishes long past their expiry date—not much of a good life after all. Opportunities no longer came calling, and she had run out of strength.

This "snake-band" could be the last great adventure in her eighty-six years of life; but it could also be the first choice of her life yet to come.

She wanted to try.

Mai Minghe knew that pressing the call button would not break the dead silence in the room with any sound.

"Ward Three, Bed 01 is calling for a nurse!"

The broadcast's sharp, almost piercing female voice shattered the room's silence without warning.

Before anyone had time to react, Mai Minghe pressed the call button several more times in quick succession.

The intercom, as if galvanized, announced down the corridor in increasingly urgent tones: "A figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at the ward within five seconds—a second figure disguised as a nurse is about to arrive—a third figure disguised as a nurse—a fourth figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at the ward within five seconds!"

Amid the announcements, each more urgent than the last, Mai Minghe thought she dimly heard the red-haired man curse "Are you insane!"; immediately after, a flurry of retreating footsteps receded rapidly, as though the group, seeing things had gone south, had fled the ward ahead of everyone else.

She had not lifted her head the entire time.

Mai Minghe felt the dark shape beside her rising up joint by joint: thighs lifting off the mattress, hips suspended halfway in the air, upper body still flat on the bed.

In the dim residual light, that head turned toward Mai Minghe, and spoke in a voice utterly unlike any human sound: "For an old lady, you've got quite the nerve."

At that very moment, something heavy was suddenly hurled across the room and slammed down hard between her and the patient in the next bed—landing with a thunderous thud, the nightstand instantly smashed to pieces—the shadow tumbled to the floor, and when it scrambled up against the wall, it turned out to be the red-haired man; finding himself wedged squarely between the patient and Mai Minghe, he swore under his breath.

Mai Minghe didn't look at him.

She kept her gaze fixed on the doorway of the ward, and said quietly: "Look again. I'm not an old lady anymore."

Not now. Not tomorrow either.

She would seize this second life—truly seize it—for herself.

By the time you see this chapter, I should already be on the plane—this chapter was set on a timer—having a backlog really gives you confidence! You can even schedule posts! Back when I was writing the apocalypse story, it was feast or famine!

Unfortunately, the backlog, all told, is barely enough to last a little over a week... hopefully I can manage to write at least one chapter on the plane, so once I land I can start bonus updates to pay off my debt.

Speaking of debt—dear readers, aren't you being a little too swift and decisive? The Artifact Report just came into the world and you're already stuffing in red envelopes—what if the child grows up to be the Hunchback of Notre Dame?

It feels like every time I blink, another debt appears...

Aiya, boarding time is almost here, there's a super long line at the gate, and here I am sitting cross-legged typing away—just wait until I've landed, and then we'll properly tally up how much more I owe.

So what if I'm a pack mule—I've been in this business for a hundred years! I'll gather coins with my donkey tail!

Chapter 5 — Sydney Ginn, the Hunter Plagued by a Stalker

Sydney Ginn stood before her own memorial portrait, ears ringing.

A funeral wreath was blocking her front door; open it, and the first thing you'd see was her own smiling, blurred face. The black-and-white portrait photo was crooked-nailed to the center of the wreath, and a line of savage crimson letters — "BITCH" — tore across her smile.

It was the first time in her life she had seen, in person, the kind of wreath used at Asian funerals; and even as fury and shock surged through her, some small part of Sydney found herself marveling at how authentic it looked — identical to the ones on TV — wondering where on earth someone would even get one made.

As for who had left it there, she wasn't curious, because she already knew.

Sydney kicked the wreath over, slammed the door, and walked toward the elevator, pulling out her phone as she went.

"Get up here right now and take a look at what's been left in front of my door."

She had lived in this building for three years, and today was the first time she had ever raised her voice at the building manager like this — before now, she had always been too afraid to be rude.

"What gives you the right to charge such high rent and management fees? This is supposed to be the most expensive address in Blackmoor City? Your security staff — did you borrow them as mummies from the National Museum next door? Are they all dead? I told you, didn't I, that there's been a creep following me lately — why wasn't security tightened? How did he even get the chance to reach my front door?"

When Sydney had first moved into this building, she had been deeply insecure about it.

By any normal trajectory, someone like her — born to an ordinary immigrant family, with no impressive credentials and an equally unremarkable job — could spend a lifetime saving for rent and still never pass the application screening, never gain entry into this century-old landmark, already designated a historic site.

The layered barriers of class and social networks made it difficult even for many newly minted tech millionaires to lease a unit here, let alone buy one.

Not long after she moved in, she had once encountered a woman in the elevator who struck up a very friendly conversation with her, which quietly pleased her; just before the elevator reached the lobby, the woman smiled and asked, "Who do you work for? We happen to be interviewing for household staff at the moment."

It took her several seconds to realize the woman had mistaken her for a maid.

Even dressed in much the same way, something — she couldn't say what — still allowed others to see at a glance that she didn't belong to this class. The building manager on the phone was one of them.

"Miss Ginn,"

the manager explained in a tone that bordered on sympathetic condescension, "I also feel very sorry about this. But you may not be aware that we generally prefer not to interfere in our residents' personal affairs — that has always been our policy.

"The people our residents typically associate with are all respectable individuals of standing, so this sort of thing is happening for the very first time. According to security, he said he wanted to give you a surprise, and he was carrying flowers, so we couldn't quite tell — it seemed like perhaps you and your boyfriend had some kind of romantic dispute..."

"It's not a romantic dispute, it's stalking and harassment!" Sydney snapped, too furious to even register the implication buried in the word "respectable." "And he's not my boyfriend — what he was carrying was a funeral wreath!"

The man had been on a few dates with her and had indeed visited before, having been granted entry each time; it was precisely after seeing her home and her lifestyle that he had begun repeatedly demanding money and gifts from her, and only when she could no longer bear it had she decided to cut off all contact.

She had never imagined that a simple "no" could ignite such an unhinged, consuming hatred.

"Of course, of course, I'll have someone remove the wreath right away. Security isn't like you — they wouldn't recognize that kind of wreath, which is understandable, and I hope you can appreciate that." The building manager continued, "That said, Miss Ginn, I'd also like to ask you to try to communicate with him and calm the situation down. After all, our residents here tend to prefer things quiet and low-key; they don't care for this sort of disturbance..."

"So I'm the one who should be apologizing to you?"

Sydney was too furious to catch anything else the manager said, hung up the call, and kicked the elevator door hard.

When she left the building, she didn't ask the doorman to call a car for her, and walked absentmindedly out into the Blackmoor City streets, where the morning sun was blazing.

Sydney could file a police report, apply for a restraining order — but neither was a sure thing.

For all she knew, the police wouldn't act until she'd already become a victim; and a restraining order might deter a sane person, but how much effect would it have on someone unhinged?

For an ordinary woman, there was little left beyond reporting it to the police, staying on guard, fleeing somewhere far away, and praying — but what that Anthony probably didn't know was that what Sydney could actually do went far beyond any of that.

She wandered for a while, made up her mind, and flagged down a taxi.

The timing worked out perfectly; when she reached the Buluan district, "Between the Backlight" had just opened its doors.

The bar's entrance was hidden behind a short staircase that descended from the sidewalk into the ground, and people walking past could hardly see its sign light; though in Sydney's memory, the sign light had never actually been on — so it hardly mattered whether any passerby could see it.

She pushed open the faded wooden door, and to the dry creaking of the door's hinges, stepped into a cramped, dim basement.

In the murky darkness, chairs sat upside down on tabletops, and cardboard boxes were stacked in the booths. The air was stale and cool, drifting with dust, the smell of alcohol, and a faint trace of vomit.

"You're here this early?"

The back door was pushed open, and a man peered in, then walked behind the bar. He had the face of a Shar-Pei, all drooping brows and downcast eyes, and yet, like a dog, his expression was somehow warm.

He switched the television on for Sydney and gestured toward the bar. "Sit down, I'm still tidying up."

The television mounted in one corner of the bar's ceiling lit up with the midday news. A baby elephant had been born at the Blackmoor City Center Island Zoo, and the female anchor was beaming.

"Any news?" Sydney sat down and asked. "I'm planning to head over in the next couple of days."

"There's a team that's temporarily short-handed and wants to hire an experienced Hunter with no House Faction ties. I thought — isn't that you?"

The bartender's Shar-Pei face remained buried behind the bar counter; he seemed to be scrubbing the cabinet door on his knees, and said over the shushing sound of the cloth: "Not much money — three thousand dollars, departing next week. And of course, whatever comes out of it at the end has nothing to do with you."

A few years ago, three thousand dollars would have lit her eyes up like flashlights; but now, it wasn't nearly enough to make it worth her while.

"I can't work with a group right now — I've got some personal business this time. Are there any other commissions?"

"Then there's nothing—"

He'd barely gotten the words out when the television suddenly rang out with a sharp, urgent chime, making Sydney glance up at the screen — breaking news.

"We have just learned," the female anchor said, her expression grave, "that Wellesley, founder, shareholder, and CEO of the Qunmu Consortium, was found dead this morning at his upstate estate, at the age of fifty-nine. The cause of death is currently suspected to be sudden cardiac arrest, and police have opened an investigation... Mr. Wellesley was also a state senator, a philanthropist..."

Sydney startled. "He's dead?"

The Shar-Pei face emerged from behind the bar, watching the screen. "Did you know him?"

"No, not personally. But I have a client who had some dealings with him... I thought maybe I'd be able to do business with him someday. Pity." Sydney said, and set aside the death of Blackmoor City's richest man. "No other assignments?"

"You could wait a few more days — something might come up." The bartender went back to polishing the beer taps. "When are you planning to go?"

Sydney took out her phone, intending to check the time, but found over twenty text messages on her screen, all from an unknown number; even without opening them, she could tell at a glance they were a mix of pitiful pleading, filth, and threats and curses.

She had already blocked four or five numbers, but it didn't seem to slow the harassment at all.

"I'm going tonight — no assignment, forget it." She put her phone away, her tone cooling. "There's a problem that's not huge but is deeply unpleasant, and I need to go make a trip and bring something back to deal with it."

The bartender nodded and asked, "The usual drink? Or should I pack it to go?"

"Yes," — just mentioning the drink, Sydney was fairly sure the color drained from her face — "I didn't bring a cup, just pour it into a couple of plastic bottles, whatever you've got."

The moment she thought about the drink he prepared for her, even before it was down her throat, her stomach started to heave, as though every organ in her body wanted to empty itself out in advance.

No matter how many times she drank it, Sydney could never get used to the taste of alcohol. She had been forcing herself to drink for the past several years, and she seemed to be turning into Pavlov's dog — sometimes just catching a whiff of alcohol on someone else was enough to make her legs go weak and her head swim with nausea.

"Only the drink you mix has the effect I need. If I drink anything else, my mind goes numb all right, but my limbs get heavy and sluggish, and the moment I close my eyes I fall dead asleep — that's just playing with my life."

A smile flickered across the bartender's face. "But it's still not efficient enough, is it? I'll keep an eye out and see if there's a suitable medication for you."

If she could pop a pill and get the same effect, that would be wonderful. But until she had that pill, she had no choice but to grit her teeth and force the drink down.

If she still wanted to keep living this life.

When night fell, Sydney changed into running shoes and athletic wear and pulled her hair up into a tight bun.

She packed all her usual gear into a bag — not an ordinary backpack, but a half-body-height hiking pack of the kind trekkers used, big enough to stuff a sleeping bag into.

Though she didn't plan to stay long, Sydney didn't dare be careless, and still brought a hunting knife, a ladies' handgun, and a can of bear spray.

What a shame — with real-world laws to contend with, none of these things could be used directly on the stalker; in the end she still had to go the long way around.

The time on her phone ticked over to 9:43 PM.

Harassment messages — each from a different number — kept flooding in without pause, piling up at the bottom of the screen, not a single one swiped open; the unread message count had already reached 129.

Sydney had discovered a few hours ago that the stalker had posted her number on dozens of yellow websites; since then, the messages coming in were not only nauseating but impossible to block fast enough.

She simply shoved the phone to the very bottom of her backpack, out of sight, out of mind.

Night had dyed the entire floor-to-ceiling window black; she sat on the floor before it, as if suspended in midair, adrift among Blackmoor City's skyscrapers and countless lights.

The neon glow, bright as scattered diamonds, would persist through the deep of the night and into the dawn. This city — the largest and most prosperous metropolis on earth — never slept, never rested.

The drink the bartender had prepared for her, she forced down sip by sip, enduring the discomfort, until her consciousness was soon scorched into something light and floating, her blood churning and bubbling; even though the apartment was perfectly quiet, she seemed to hear a hum coming from somewhere.

The primal fear honed by millions of years of evolution was not something that could be habituated to or overcome simply by trying again and again.

If she didn't drink large quantities of alcohol, if she didn't dull her mind into a hazy stupor, Sydney didn't even have the courage to walk to the edge of the balcony — she had always been severely acrophobic; she wouldn't even ride roller coasters at an amusement park.

She gripped the balcony railing with trembling hands, drew a breath, and stepped up onto the chair she had prepared.

The backpack hung heavy from her shoulders, and as she pushed herself up to sit on the railing it caught and scraped against it; the lurch of her body nearly sent both her heart and her stomach sliding up her throat, and it was only with great effort that she steadied her breathing, her palms soaked through with cold sweat.

Even drunk, she still dared not look down, keeping her gaze fixed on the city skyline.

Far away between the buildings, rivers of traffic flowed, countless headlights blurring into bright smears in the fine drifting rain. The cool, thin rain fell in close, slanting lines against her skin, and Sydney felt a vague worry that the cold rain might sober her up, stripping away the blessed numbness.

...Time to go.

She sat on the railing, her back to the neon lights of Blackmoor City, watching her reflection in the glass door and the faint outline of the living room beyond it.

"I'll be right back," Sydney Ginn said softly to the apartment. "Wait for me."

She closed her eyes, leaned back, and fell straight down into the cool early-November night wind.

*I'm back, everyone — first thing I did was eat until I couldn't anymore, god it felt like getting out of jail, I nearly cried over the food — wait, no, what am I saying, the first thing I did was sit my butt down and write, for real!

Hehehe I just posted four chapters and already swapped away from Mai Minghe — sorry about that. The worldbuilding needs multiple perspectives or it'll be confusing for too long, which isn't great. I won't be switching POVs that often going forward.

I should have given a heads-up at the end of the last chapter, but I forgot... donkeys have bad memories, and apparently so do I — you all are hippocampi, I'm a hippo-donkey, the pirated version glitches out, but paying readers will definitely forgive me (right?).

I've always thought one of the big reasons Western fantasy is hard to get into is the names... so I've given all the Western characters in this story names that Chinese readers can actually remember. Take Sydney Ginn — her name is translated as 金雪梨 (Jin Xuěli). If I'd called her 西

妮 · 洁, who would even know who that is, right? I picked up this trick while writing Milady, and it really works — solid 4.8 stars on the reviews.

*Why am I sticking this ramble at the end of the main text? Because the author's note section ran out of space, and I just can't bring myself not to ramble. This chapter is free anyway, so you can't say I'm padding the word count.

Let me see which impatient grannies have made themselves my creditors this time...

Alright, I now honorably owe Tiánxiá one bonus chapter (how does it always end up costing me more than it saves?), owe Magical Grey Feather one big healthy bouncing baby of a bonus chapter (didn't I just say don't be in such a rush?! I genuinely feel bad), and owe Yǐngyòu one big healthy baby (I'd be better off going to stake out the maternity ward at People's Hospital — faster that way)... what are you all doing, you're already here, you didn't have to bring gifts too (lol.

Thank you Tángmián Yè, Shí Zhī Yōulíng, Please Call Me A-Qī, and 锦o (maybe I'll scrape together one kid for the four of you — go home and split it into four pieces, my stockpile is already shivering with cold sweat)

Thank you Péng Xiǎoxī, Pūpū Hāhā, Mí Miēmiē, Mò Yuān (pronounced Black Bird), Fēitiān Dàdào Zéi, Déyún Fūjìn, Kafka, A-Shí qwq, Sān Xī Yī, Yūki Akinana, Qīngqīng Jiǔ, Me and Honeydew Are Mortal Enemies (Melon!!), Jiāng Lù Jīng Lúfù, and Today I Had a Roasted Sweet Potato — what's the rush, grannies, isn't it nicer to let this relationship flow gently like a stream? What if it turns out not good, I'm already second-guessing myself.

Counting the grannies from before, how many bonus chapters do I owe now? Five?

...Five?????

.....????????

Time flows like a river — and by "time," does that mean my stockpile?!

Chapter 6: Sydney Ginn's Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion

She had lost count of how many times she'd fallen from a great height.

Sooner or later, between the alcohol and the repeated falls, her heart would slam against her sternum one final time—and then Sydney Ginn would cease to exist.

But at least this time, she was still alive; even as the blood her heart was furiously pumping surged in waves through her skull, sending wave after wave of dizziness crashing through her.

The hot alcohol turned to sweat and burst from her pores, and the needle-sharp burning across her back faded into a cool, damp chill.

Sydney Ginn would perhaps never stop fearing the fall; but after so many jumps, she had at least learned to land without screaming—there was only her breathing now, ragged and heavy, nearly a whimper; fear like a centipede, crawling and scratching inside her chest and throat.

She had landed in the same old place again.

The room was adrift with the smell of stale dust, the kind that called to mind old cardboard boxes; dim and cool and dark, but not a deep darkness—more like a half-drawn curtain that you could push aside with one hand and find someone hiding behind it.

Sydney Ginn didn't move.

The alcohol still rolled through her like waves born inside her body, rocking and pushing at her.

Something must have been watching over her, because no matter what position she jumped from, she always landed on her feet, like a cat blessed by the heavens.

She crouched in place for a few seconds, then reached out her right hand into the darkness to feel for the wall. Every time she landed, the alcohol left her unsteady on her feet, and she would brace herself against the wall on her right—if someone shone a flashlight on it, they'd probably see the wallpaper gleaming where it had been soaked through with the oils from her hand.

The moment her hand touched something smooth, flat, and square—a plastic panel—she yanked it back as if electrocuted, cursed under her breath, and felt a cold wave of belated terror prickle across her skin.

...Impossible to guard against everything, she thought. Last time she was here, the light switch definitely hadn't been on this wall.

Fortunately, her hand hadn't had enough weight behind it to press down that eager, impatient light switch.

Sydney Ginn moved slowly into the corner and felt her way to the same spot where the faucet always was, then turned it on. She cupped her hands and drank several large mouthfuls; the faucet squeaked and squeaked as it turned two full rotations, then fell silent again.

Unlike food, water in the Nest was generally safe.

Sydney Ginn pulled a flattened fried doughnut and a can of coffee from her bag.

Drink before the jump to numb the fear with alcohol to its limit; after landing, wash the alcohol out with fried food and coffee as best she could—every single time Sydney Ginn entered the Nest, she had to go through the same routine.

She leaned against the corner of the wall and, though she had no appetite at all, forced herself to finish eating, then carefully packed the empty can and paper bag back into her backpack.

Never leave personal belongings behind in the Nest—not even if it's trash. That was a Hunter's first lesson. When she had learned it, Sydney Ginn couldn't remember anymore.

On the far side of the sink, there was a locked storage cabinet.

She fumbled in the dark for several tries before finally fitting the key into the lock; from behind the silently swinging cabinet door, she felt out a radio—cool, heavy, square, and solid.

The static crackle of electricity rose from the depths of the darkness and settled beside her; as she turned the dial searching for the channel, the static slowly resolved into a man's voice.

"Welcome to Nest Radio 173," the man's voice said quietly, as if he were about to begin telling a story. "This is the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion. I am your host."

No name—only "your host."

His—or perhaps its, since no human could live in the Nest—entire identity seemed to exist solely in relation to the radio station.

No matter when Sydney Ginn turned on the radio, the first words she heard were always "Welcome to Nest Radio 173"—as if the host were waiting at all times, and a listener turning on

the receiver was what switched him on.

"Today is Monday, November 16th, 2026."

Time in the Nest moved at the same pace as in the outside world; Sydney Ginn glanced at her phone and confirmed it once more.

On the phone screen, over a hundred ugly unread messages were frozen in place; no signal, no new texts coming in.

"First, let's bring you the Nest news."

In the darkness, Sydney Ginn listened while she waited for the coffee and food to take effect. This hideout should be known only to her, so there was no need to worry about anyone barging in.

In the Nest, where a single moment of distraction could mean the difference between life and death, she sat perfectly still listening to the radio—when she thought about it, she found it a little funny herself.

She was a solo Hunter, without the backing of a House Faction, and the Artifacts she'd managed to get her hands on in the past had all been bottom-tier; by rights, she had no room to be choosy—she should take any Artifact she could get, sell any Artifact she had.

But this one radio—this, she would never sell to anyone. It was her lifeline.

"...We trust that all Residents who truly love the Nest will be very pleased? A great threat to the Nest had only just begun to take root, yet it was swiftly stamped out through the combined efforts of all parties. We hope everyone will share this good news with friends and family—if you haven't already made them into dinner."

Sydney Ginn listened with only half her attention. Honestly, she hadn't understood it; and she had no idea what "great threat" referred to.

The broadcast wasn't made for humans; the host's audience was the Residents of the Nest, so out of every ten sentences, there were about eight that she couldn't follow.

As long as it seemed to have nothing much to do with her, Sydney Ginn couldn't be bothered to puzzle it out; the curiosity she'd felt when she first got the radio had, after nearly dying once, long since vanished completely.

She understood barely half of it, yet she listened anyway.

"A Toyota with the license plate MKA-388 has been parked at the entrance of the Buluan District Public Library for more than seven days. The owner is requested to move the vehicle as soon as possible, or it will be added to the library's vengeance list."

The license plate sounded like a real Blackmoor City plate... could a Hunter really have driven a car in here?

If it had been sitting there that long, the owner was probably dead.

The thought passed through her mind and left no mark.

Being an Artifact Hunter meant racing against the darkness; the Hunters who had been swept under by its black waves and sunk forever into the depths of the Nest were beyond counting by now.

Sooner or later, she would sink down too; she just didn't know what form her grave would take when it finally appeared before her.

"...Next, we'll bring you traffic conditions and map information."

Sydney Ginn snapped to attention, the effects of the alcohol fading considerably, her mind sharpening. She quickly pulled out a pen and a brand-new Blackmoor City tourist map, clamped her phone between her teeth, and used the faint glow of its screen to spread the map out on the concrete floor.

"First," the host said, as though even he understood the importance of this information, slowing his pace, "streets from Fifth to One Hundred and Ninetieth remain unchanged and are accessible as normal today."

She let out a breath of relief.

Whether it was a good thing or a bad thing was unclear, but the Nest seemed to have a life of its own—always slowly mutating.

Before she got the radio, every time Sydney Ginn opened a passage and dropped into the Nest, she had to brace herself mentally—even a location she'd explored more than a hundred times, the next time you pushed open the door, you might still step into a room you'd never seen before.

The Nest resembled Blackmoor City's layout, but in a distorted, off-kilter kind of way—as if the Nest were a slanted, warped mirror image, twisted by light and shadow, breeding from the

gaps and crevices of shade things that did not belong to this world.

Was this a crack in the universe, a legendary hell, or the delusion inside the mind of a madman?

Sydney Ginn had come here more times than she could count, and still didn't know the answer.

After listening to enough broadcasts, she had worked out the patterns.

"Currently undergoing construction/renovation/repair"—this meant the area was in the process of changing.

"Attracting a large number of visitors / a great weekend destination"—absolutely do not go near it; you had to give even the surrounding area a wide berth.

"Unchanged, accessible as normal"—exactly as it sounded: as long as you had previously scouted the terrain and assessed the risks, you could still trust your last experience.

The thing Sydney Ginn had prepared to deal with her stalker was hidden on 99th Street, which happened to fall within an area showing no unusual changes; if everything went smoothly, the journey from her landing spot to 99th Street would take only two days, and she could retrieve the item and return to Blackmoor City.

Two days... she couldn't help letting out a self-deprecating laugh.

By distance alone, it was at most fifteen kilometers between the two points; but in the Nest, covering fifteen kilometers in two days counted as remarkably smooth going.

By the time the traffic and map report was finished, Sydney Ginn's map was covered in circles of all sizes, along with annotations like "DANGER!" "GO STRAIGHT" and "Bus available, but don't talk to the driver."

Based on the experience she had bought with her life over and over again, the broadcasts could be trusted.

If she ever decided to retire, this radio could probably fetch her at least a million dollars.

But Sydney Ginn knew she could never retire—even with a million waiting for her, she couldn't bear to stop being a Hunter—there were too many things in this world worth trying, her desires ran too deep, and a million was far from enough.

"I'm doing him too much of a favor," Sydney Ginn thought, growing more irritated the more she dwelled on it. "What kind of rat crawls out of the gutter thinking he deserves me to bring back an Artifact just to deal with him..."

She put the map and pen away and was just about to pick up the radio from the floor—which was currently playing "Nest's Hottest New Songs Chart No. 1," a track that wasn't actually too bad, sounding like a howling wind through a forest with faint, drawn-out human shrieks woven through it—when the "music" suddenly paused and stopped.

Then again, with something like drawn-out human shrieks, who could ever tell which one was the last?

"What a soothing and melodious song," the host murmured. "I just received a listener call-in, so I'll be adding a special emergency broadcast segment."

Sydney Ginn's breath caught.

A "special emergency broadcast"—since she'd gotten the radio, she had only heard it twice.

The first time, the special emergency broadcast had helped her find a fixed, hidden, and private landing spot—the very small room she was in right now.

She hadn't even known before that, that a human could bind a landing point within the Nest.

In the past, every time Sydney Ginn opened a passage and dropped into the Nest, she had appeared in a public landing point like everyone else—City Hall, the Contre-Jour Garden, St. Louis Hospital, and so on—surrounded by Hunters, Residents, and countless other unknowns, she hadn't even dared stay in one place long enough to finish a coffee.

The second time, the Artifact she obtained through the special emergency broadcast had bought her that apartment in Blackmoor City—the kind of place an ordinary person couldn't get close to in a lifetime. Beyond the payment, the buyer had also signed an open-ended contract: for as long as Sydney Ginn lived, she would have permanent right of residence in that apartment.

Now the third time had finally come.

In that moment, Sydney Ginn's entire field of vision narrowed to the radio on the floor; she forgot to breathe, every ounce of her focus sharpening into a hook, clamped tight around every single word coming through.

"...After entering through Door D of the Museum of Modern Art, take the elevator on the left down to basement level one."

The host's voice flowed slowly from the radio, as if projecting the interior layout of the building inside her mind. "Remember—you must take the first elevator on the left. If the doors of any other elevator open, do not get in, do not look, and no matter what happens, pretend you don't notice."

Although the broadcast audience seemed to be Nest Residents, there were always these small details that made Sydney Ginn feel as though the host was issuing instructions to her specifically—or rather, to whatever Hunter happened to be listening.

"The 'Candlefall' in the first basement exhibition hall is something you'll want to keep in mind. From what I know, it only recently became an Artifact—and some might say it is one of the most powerful Artifacts the Nest has ever produced."

The host paused, as if he could sense the thudding of Sydney Ginn's heartbeat.

"To anyone thinking of going to take a look—take my advice. Human fate is as thin and fragile as a cotton cloth. The floods of this world are too many, too unpredictable—they surge and crash without mercy. A person can only be torn apart and swallowed up in the churning currents, flung by forces far greater than themselves toward a future they cannot see clearly.

"And an Artifact... is a mountain torrent and a tidal wave, a storm and a towering wall of water. It is the genie that grants your wishes, and the god that heeds no pleas..."

He got this far, and then, as if what came next was too difficult to say, he trailed off involuntarily.

The darkened room fell silent for a moment; the host had no breath—Sydney Ginn had realized that long ago.

In the room there were only four or five breathing sounds, including her own, rising and falling together in the dark.

"Dear listeners, that's all for today's broadcast. Please stay safe, everyone—until next time."

Sydney Ginn stood there in a daze for a few seconds, then grabbed the radio and stowed it away again. Feeling her way to the door handle, she cracked the door open and slipped out.

The Museum of Modern Art was in the direction she was already heading.

Go to the museum first to see the Artifact the broadcast mentioned, then head to 99th Street to get what she needed to deal with Anthony...

A day or two's delay was no big deal.

Sydney Ginn only has one chapter, there's nothing in the drafts.

I've seen people asking what Mai Minghe's English name is—Mai Minghe is actually ethnically Chinese, so her Chinese name is just Mai Minghe; but of course she does have an English name, and it's one I'm quite proud of, so pretty that I regret giving it to her—River Rye.

I kind of want to take it back for myself lol.

What's wrong with that? A daughter giving her mother a little tribute is only right, isn't it.

For minor supporting characters like that nuisance Anthony, I'm not going to bother Sinicizing the names—if you can't remember them, you can't remember them; coming up with names that sound both good and distinctive is such a headache.

Writing on an iPad while away from home is such a pain, ugh, it's really affecting my output.

Now I want an e-ink tablet again lol.

Chapter 7 – Sydney Ginn: The Hunter's Life Is No Easy Living

Night in Blackmoor City is also night in the Nest.

Wind tumbled down through the cracks between heaven and earth, tossing her bangs astray. If she squinted and peered out through the shadow of her lashes, Sydney Ginn could barely tell whether she was in the Nest or in Blackmoor City.

A Blackmoor City abandoned and desolate, its shadows twisting, every detail more unsettling the deeper you looked—at the intersection ahead, the green light on the traffic signal had gone dark, replaced by a purple one, blinking on and off; the surface of the empty road was seized by the purple light, then released, seized, then released.

Only sound was truly honest: she couldn't hear car engines, rolling tires, or honking horns; no voices in conversation, no dogs barking, no video blogger narrating into a selfie camera. At this moment, the only sound Sydney Ginn could hear was a steady footstep, one after another.

A soft "tap"—her left foot meeting the ground; before she could even lift her right foot, she heard another "tap."

The footsteps behind her had been following her for several minutes now.

Whoever it was didn't seem much like a Hunter; Hunters who crossed paths in the Nest tended to keep their distance, sizing each other up with cautious wariness—the ever-present threat of extreme danger kept everyone's nerves wound tight, and nobody wanted to invite extra trouble.

If it wasn't a Hunter, then it was a Resident.

Should she pretend not to notice?

Sydney Ginn opened her phone's camera, held it flat against her chest, angled it slightly up over her shoulder, and snapped a photo—quick and discreet.

She quickened her pace to put some distance between them, then darted a glance at the screen.

In the photo, a warped, grinning version of Sydney Ginn's own face was staring back at her.

The teeth were white and enormous, packed so densely they could barely fit inside the mouth, the lips nearly insufficient to contain them. The figure looked to be resting its cheek on someone's

shoulder, flashing a "yeah" hand sign.

Sydney Ginn recognized it at once—that shoulder was her own.

What rotten luck.

"Get lost!" Sydney Ginn hissed without turning around, slashing her hunting knife backward to drive the thing back a few steps. "Who do you think you're dealing with? You think I'm not long for this world?"

Silence from behind. A few seconds of stillness, then she heard her own voice let out a low, tittering "heh heh."

...So it wasn't going to leave on its own.

Annoying as it was, her luck wasn't entirely bad—whatever had latched onto her wasn't especially dangerous.

This type of Resident was common in the Nest. When they set their sights on someone, they would wrench their face into that person's likeness, though the result was always slightly off—an extra eyeball in the right eye socket, a single black hole in place of nostrils, or, as now, a mouth so crammed with teeth it could barely close.

They simply followed their target wearing the target's face, and while deeply unsettling, they posed no immediate threat.

Only after a target met with danger and died would this type of Resident pounce, coiling and writhing and feeding upon the corpse, until when it finally raised its face, it had become an exact, flawless replica of the original. Some said it was perhaps because they longed to return to the human world that they wished to impersonate humans and slip back into Blackmoor City in the original's place—though that was just hearsay, not worth taking seriously.

In other words, they were like vultures over a desert, perpetually circling above animals on the verge of death.

This particular Resident had probably caught the smell of alcohol on Sydney Ginn, noticed the faint sway still in her step, and decided she wouldn't last much longer.

Its technique wasn't up to par with its kind, though—ordinarily, a "Vulture" trailing someone wouldn't let the Hunters notice at all; this one was stomping along quite audibly.

Still, harmless as it might be, knowing that thing's face was hovering just over her shoulder was irritating enough.

She listened carefully, gauging the distance between footfalls with her attention, calculating whether she could create an opportunity to shake it—when a thought suddenly broke through: something's wrong.

Sydney Ginn's whole body jerked. She stopped dead in her tracks, and before she'd even gotten a clear look at the ground ahead, she threw herself sideways off the path, her back hitting the railing with a loud clang.

That noise—who knew whether it would draw other Residents now...

But this wasn't the time to worry about what came next—she'd almost fallen for the Vulture Resident's trick.

"Sydney Ginn" was still standing just a step or two away, watching her, the lower half of its face all smiles and teeth. But the eyes grew deeper and deeper, darker and darker, until they resembled a pair of holes poked by a child's finger into dough.

Sydney Ginn did her best not to look at it, and swept a glance at the ground she had almost stepped onto.

A long chalk-drawn hopscotch grid stretched out ahead, extending far beyond what she could see, covering the entire width of the sidewalk.

The chalk had faded, submerged in the dim yellow glow of the streetlights and the shadows cast by the trees along the roadside; if you didn't look carefully, it was nearly impossible to notice.

The first row had four squares. The first three were blank; only the last one, at the edge, had writing: "Right foot."

"Damn it all, waiting here for me, were you."

Sydney Ginn wiped the cold sweat from her neck with her sleeve, and hissed at her other self: "No wonder your footsteps were so clear, deliberately falling in the gaps between mine, just to make sure I heard you..."

It had been deliberate.

It had wanted Sydney Ginn to fix all her attention on what was behind her, her mind occupied with the question of "how to shake the Vulture"—and there were only so many ways to

shake someone following close behind, and whichever method she chose, she would have ended up breaking into a run and stepping straight into the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid.

If she hadn't stepped into the square marked "Right foot" with her right foot, she would have been in serious trouble.

"November 17th, the Nest, Colorado Avenue. A chalk-drawn Hopscotch has appeared here."

Sydney Ginn opened her voice memo app and briefly described what had just happened, then said, "Although the 'Vulture' did not directly harm anyone, it has shown signs of luring targets into a trap... This is a new behavioral pattern, worth noting."

She had never joined a Hunter House Faction, so when it came to gathering and updating intelligence on the Nest, she naturally couldn't match the systematic, organized approach of House Faction Hunters.

But she had her own way of surviving: she would bring whatever valuable information she'd collected to the bar called "Against the Light," where the owner—whose face looked like a Shar-Pei—would exchange a different set of information in return. He was like a human information exchange board, or a primitive version of LinkedIn.

She put her phone away and looked around, almost wanting to sigh.

To the right was a row of stone-brick townhouses; short flights of steps climbed up to each front door. Between the staircases, clusters of trees separated one from the next, and the railing she'd just slammed into stood just outside the tree line.

Never mind that she was trying to get to the Museum of Modern Art—even if she weren't, she absolutely could not just wander into a Nest building.

To the left, the road was empty; all she had to do was step off the sidewalk and walk along the street to go around the chalk house—under normal circumstances, that would have worked, but not now, because the traffic light was still purple.

"If it weren't for all this garbage, why would fifteen kilometers take two whole days to walk..."

Sydney Ginn muttered under her breath, tucked away her knife and phone, adjusted her trail pack, cinched it tight around her waist, and stepped her right foot into the square.

She stood in the square on one leg like a crane, the alcohol not yet entirely faded, rolling and pushing against her ankle in waves; Sydney Ginn broke into a cold sweat all over, swaying unsteadily, one hand gripping the railing.

The square said right foot only, so she absolutely could not add a left foot.

The smile on "Sydney Ginn's" face froze rigid, then, starting from the cheekbones, began slowly contorting. One cheekbone jutted further and further out, while the other gradually slid downward.

Was it about to give up, seeing that she hadn't taken the bait?

As a rule, when a Vulture saw that "replacing" its target was hopeless, it would abandon the target's likeness—either shifting into someone else's face, or retreating into the shadows and vanishing.

Watching your own features, your own face, warp and melt off another face the way ice cream melts on a summer day—other Hunters had said it was an unexpectedly unpleasant thing to witness.

"Get lost now, and I won't kill you."

Sydney Ginn threw out a hollow threat, turned back, switched to her left foot, and hopped to the middle square of the next row; the moment her single foot landed, the trail pack dragged heavily downward, as if someone had jumped onto her back.

Her hands spun around like a windmill several times before she finally steadied herself, and in her mind she had killed the harassing lunatic Anthony back and forth ten times over—naturally, everything bad was his fault.

But if something good came of this trip, like getting her hands on a rare Artifact, that would obviously be entirely thanks to herself.

She just had to wait for the purple light to go out, and then find a moment to jump off the sidewalk.

The first four or five rows of squares were still reasonable: though hopping forward one foot at a time with a pack weighing more than ten kilograms on her back and alcohol still in her system was exhausting work, at least it wasn't impossible.

At some point—she lost track of which square—the writing inside the squares was no longer just "left foot" or "right foot."

"Left hand," read one square.

The squares on either side of it listed penalties—"Lose consciousness," "Lose all red blood cells produced in the past year," "Visit No. 87 Colorado Avenue."

Fortunately, there was a utility pole right beside that square.

With great difficulty, Sydney Ginn hugged her pack with one arm, braced her feet against the pole, and tipped herself upside down, pressing her left hand into the square—she felt like a circus acrobat, stretching one leg out far behind her, her whole body a trembling, lopsided "Y," barely managing to land on the next square.

"Exchange food for the right to stand," said another square.

That was nothing; Sydney Ginn had no shortage of food in her pack, and good food at that.

She stood on the spot she had purchased with a beef sausage, rested her trembling limbs for a moment, then looked up—and stopped cold.

Every single square within sight ahead was covered in the same three words, packed in densely.

Copied copied copied copied copied copied copied copied

...All penalties?

Copied? What would happen if she stepped on one—

A chill shot through Sydney Ginn. She slowly turned her head, and there on her shoulder she saw a chubby-cheeked profile, flush and round.

Somehow, at some point, it had crept back up without a sound.

She was only about a hundred meters from the traffic light now, yet the purple glow kept blinking on and off, as if it had absolutely no intention of leaving.

The road to the Museum of Modern Art had barely begun, and already she was at a standstill.

Sydney Ginn thought of "The Nest's Current No. 1 Hit Song."

Truly, no exaggeration—the only "song" that could express and carry what she felt in this moment was one of long, drawn-out human howling.

Only six days in and I've already slipped up—can't keep the 10:15 update time anymore...
Whatever, I posted today! Deal with it!

Typed the whole thing with my head drooping, and now my neck is killing me (at home my computer sits on a stand at eye level, so my neck doesn't get tired).

I don't have much neck to begin with—what happens if I lose what's left.

Feeling a bit dizzy and awful, let me go eat something first, then I'll organize everyone's names from the patron list...

(Let me know when you think would be a good time to tell my mom she's suddenly got a lot of new moms.)

Chapter 8: Sydney Ginn's Blackmoor City Transportation and Tourism

Map

"What I'm about to say may be hard to believe. I find it hard to believe myself.

"I'm still standing inside the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid, and I have nowhere to go. I can't go back—I've tried. Behind me, two rows away, there's a square with 'left hand' written in it. When I came through, I could use a utility pole to do a one-handed handstand, but going back, I can't reach that pole anymore."

Carrying a heavy backpack while doing a one-handed handstand on her weaker left side—Sydney Ginn couldn't manage it. Hunters had a passage and could enter the Nest, but that didn't transform them or grant them supernatural strength.

What's more, the Resident's breathing floated constantly at her ear; in the corner of her eye, her own face lingered, vaguely distorted, like a reflection sunk deep underwater, watching her.

She had been gripping the hunting knife again for quite some time now.

Sydney Ginn closed her eyes, then opened them. On the road to her left, the silence continued to be split open—sliced through again and again by flashes of violet light, like wet viscera exposed under an X-ray.

"It seems like Hopscotch and the 'Vulture' Residents have developed a kind of... cooperative relationship."

Sydney Ginn murmured into her phone's voice memo: "I can't think of a better explanation than that they're working together."

The Vultures had tried to drive her into the hopscotch grid, and the grid had returned the favor—once she'd gone deep enough that she couldn't turn back, it had written "Copied" as the penalty in the squares ahead of her...

If she had actually stepped on one, the Resident following behind her would probably become a second Sydney Ginn.

And what would happen to her then?

The original hadn't even died yet, and a Vulture had already become the target itself—she had never heard of such a thing.

"Maybe I'm overthinking it... The traffic light on the road hasn't changed color for nearly ten minutes now. It's been purple the whole time, keeping me trapped on the sidewalk. Could it also be part of this trap? It's hard to imagine... Unlike Residents, other things don't have intelligence. How would they work together?"

The information recorded in the voice memo served more than one purpose, beyond being exchanged as intelligence later.

If she could never leave the Nest and ultimately died here, she could at least imagine that someday her phone would be picked up by some Hunter.

Who she was, where she died, the last moments of her life—none of it would sink with her into the depths of the Nest.

Perhaps somewhere in this world, another person would hear the last few words of her life and know that a Sydney Ginn had once existed. Even if in the very next moment, like wind scattering smoke, her name dissolved with a single turn of that person's thoughts.

Sometimes when she thought about it, she found it strange: someone like her, bursting with desires and devoted to pleasure, was ready to die at any moment, anywhere.

Perhaps without that readiness, you couldn't make it as an Artifact Hunter.

She put away her phone and looked at the traffic light again.

She didn't really need to look up to know the purple light was still on; but what else could she do besides staring at the traffic light over and over?

The buzz of the alcohol had mostly worn off, but her energy and stamina seemed to have evaporated along with it, seeping out through her pores, leaving behind a body that felt loose and heavy; the muscles in her legs trembled, as if they couldn't hold on to the bones.

The square read "trade food for the right to stand"—it said nothing about sitting, so Sydney Ginn didn't dare sit down; the backpack, weighing some ten-odd kilograms, she kept on top of her feet, not daring to let it touch the chalk drawings.

"Just you wait," she said quietly to the Resident beside her. "I don't believe that purple light can stay on for seven days straight."

The Resident didn't respond. It probably knew, too, that Sydney Ginn was just bluffing—even with food and water, standing for seven days straight without sleep was enough to kill a person.

Well, this was exactly why most Hunters, after a few solo runs into the Nest, would put in applications to the major Hunter House Factions... Even someone like Sydney Ginn, who hated taking orders and couldn't stand being managed by others, found herself sighing: it would be nice to have a partner watching her back right now.

She stood in one square of the chalk hopscotch grid as the night wind grew increasingly cool; the longer she stood, the more foolish she felt—what was she even doing here?

She'd survived a fall from a great height, only to stand here like a human post?

After racking her brain for a while, running through every option including climbing a tree and walking a tightrope, only to have each one shot down by reality, Sydney Ginn had even screwed up her courage and, with a what-have-I-got-to-lose attitude, shouted "someone help!" twice—whether it was good luck or bad, nothing came out of that row of stone-brick Western-style houses in response.

She'd tried several plans and was back to her old standby of being a human post.

It would've been nice if the broadcast had given a heads-up—had she known, she never would have taken this wretched road.

That said, Sydney Ginn also knew it was far too much to ask.

If the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion were to introduce the road conditions on every single street in the Nest, by the time it finished broadcasting, she'd have already gone back to Blackmoor City and there would be nothing left to do.

Thinking of the broadcast made her think of her own map, covered in annotations—wait, what if those annotations could actually be useful?

Sydney Ginn glanced over at "Sydney Ginn."

It was still standing two steps away, but it was looking more and more repulsive—when she'd turned her head just now, it had mimicked her, rolling its dark irises to the right so the whites showed, and then staying like that for a long time, unable to roll them back.

That was her own face. She'd have nightmare material for a week.

Sydney Ginn slid the hunting knife back into its sheath at her waist, took the map out of her backpack, shook it open, and studied the annotations carefully by the flickering violet light and the murky yellow glow of a streetlamp.

A few minutes later, she looked up from the map and snapped a sharp curse at the Resident beside her: "Son of a bitch!"

"Sydney Ginn," unaware it had been cursed at, stared at Sydney Ginn with rapt, entranced attention, and its lower lip suddenly drooped crookedly, as if it were trying to mimic the shape of her mouth.

"Get over here!" Sydney Ginn had found nothing useful on the map, and her anger was surging. "They all say Residents can't be killed—so you won't mind if I stab you a few times, will you? Get over here!"

"Sydney Ginn" simply would not come over.

The more she thought about it, the more furious she got. She pressed her lips tightly shut, worked her tongue around for a moment, gathered up a mouthful of spit, and "ptoo!"—spat it all out onto the chalk square at "Sydney Ginn's" feet. Not that whatever penalty the square handed out was any of her concern.

Unfortunately, the square wasn't about to be washed away by spit—though it would have been wonderful if it could—that patch of foamy wet stain dried in the blink of an eye, as if absorbed by the floor tiles, leaving the chalk drawing completely unchanged beneath.

As a result, "Sydney Ginn" mimicked her: pressed its lips tightly shut, and its tongue seemed to stir as well.

"Oh, you've got to be kidding me,"

Sydney Ginn finally panicked a little, and quickly raised her backpack, ready to use it as a shield against the Resident's spit—but thankfully the Resident seemed to be physiologically different on the inside, and when it opened its mouth, it was just a dark, dry hollow. Nothing came out.

The interlude was over, and she was still at a complete loss.

Sydney Ginn stared at the words "Blackmoor City Tourism and Transportation Map" and had no idea what to do. Her eyes lingered on the map, but her thoughts had drifted away, wandering blankly to some unknown place.

By the time she came back to herself, she realized she had been staring at several rows of small print in the lower right corner of the map's reverse side for several minutes already.

Sydney Ginn slowly narrowed her eyes.

The tourism and transportation map included a great deal of additional information—emergency numbers, police numbers, tourism website URLs, travel insurance details... Among all those rows of small print, her gaze snagged on one thing in particular.

The taxi service hotline for Blackmoor City.

Of course, this was a phone number from the real world.

She was currently inside a delusion-like, nightmare-like mirror world, where there wasn't even a phone signal...

A mirror world...

The yellow taxi—one of Blackmoor City's iconic symbols, the yellow taxi that appeared in countless films and television shows—would it also cast its mirror image inside the Nest?

The thought was like a hand placed at the back of her mind, nearly impossible to ignore.

Sydney Ginn was inwardly laughing at herself for having an overactive imagination, for being driven by desperation into wishful thinking, and yet she once again reached for her phone without meaning to—and of course, the upper right corner showed "No Signal."

She hesitated, but in the end entered the service hotline number digit by digit and pressed call.

There was no harm in trying; even if it didn't work, was she really afraid of being laughed at by "Sydney Ginn" standing next to her?

In her taut, tense anticipation, from beneath the night sky sliced into black and violet, came the sound of a dial tone—"beep—beep—beep—"

"Hello," a woman's voice came on. "Do you need a taxi?"

She stood there with her mouth half open, dumbstruck and silent. Was this a hallucination?

"Do you need one, or not?" The woman's voice wasn't impatient—it asked the question matter-of-factly, like a machine.

"I—I do!" The words were out of Sydney Ginn's mouth before a new wave of anxiety hit her. "Wait—are there any conditions for calling a taxi? What do you pay with? I do have to pay, right?"

"Of course. Please note the following Passenger Rules," the woman's voice said flatly. "One, tell the driver the address you wish to go to. Two, do not look at the driver. Three, sit in the back seat. Four, lower your head and lean it between the driver's seat and the passenger seat. Five, recall a recent experience in your mind. Six, do not panic when the driver collects payment."

"...Recall?" Even with all her Nest experience, Sydney Ginn was sometimes still thrown by its strangeness.

"Yes. Please note the following fare requirements. One, the recalled experience must be from within the past month. Two, the scenes and events in the recollection must be continuous. Three, the experience being recalled must have lasted at least three minutes when it originally occurred. Four, the driver only accepts the first experience that comes to mind automatically—deliberately screened or selected recollections are not accepted."

"Is that all? Just a memory—nothing else? I'll arrive safely at my destination and get out safely?" Afraid the other party might play word games, she went through every loophole she could think of and plugged them one by one.

"Correct."

"That works perfectly," Sydney Ginn let out a long breath. "Send a car right away!"

Never mind the past month—even going back ten years, there wasn't a single memory she'd rather die than give up; and besides, it was only three minutes.

"I'm on Colorado Avenue," she gave her address, then suddenly remembered something and quickly asked: "Can you have the driver open the car door for me when he stops?"

She looked at the square beneath her feet, then at the road beside it, and measured the distance with her eyes. That gap—she could lunge across it.

It was just that "landing" would be considerably more difficult than a normal landing; she couldn't land on the sidewalk, and she couldn't land on the road either—she'd figure out the specifics once the car arrived.

Almost too smoothly to be real, the woman's voice replied, "Yes."

Sydney Ginn's sudden rescue made her heart leap with joy; she hung up the phone, and the screen reflected half of a face pressed right up against hers.

The duck was about to fly right out of reach—it must be getting anxious too, right?

"Back off,"

Sydney Ginn used the same method as before, swinging the hunting knife in wide circles to force the Resident back a few steps—and when she came back to her senses, she was sitting in the back seat of a taxi.

...Huh?

The taxi, gradually picking up speed, glided smoothly through the purple traffic light, the numbers on the meter perfectly still. A human-shaped silhouette sat in the driver's seat, a leather glove on the hand resting on the steering wheel.

"...Where are we going?"

The question was barely out of her mouth before she realized she was breathing hard, her heart pounding—as if she had just been through a burst of intense physical exertion.

"The Museum of Modern Art," the voice seemed to be the driver answering, but no matter how she listened, it sounded like it was coming from beneath her feet.

Sydney Ginn decided not to look down.

Though she couldn't remember how she'd gotten into the cab, a little reverse reasoning made it easy enough to figure out—the first memory that surfaced in her mind was apparently something that had just happened when she boarded: the process of giving the driver the address and having her memory taken had already been handed over as the fare.

Well, that worked out; she'd turned misfortune into a stroke of luck, and could ride all the way to the Museum of Modern Art in one go.

She turned and glanced back at the other "Sydney Ginn" she was steadily leaving behind.

Even from a distance, she could tell the Resident was furious: it flailed its arms like one of those long inflatable tube men outside car dealerships, thrashing wildly, and every so often it threw its head back and let out a long howl—yet another new behavior.

Hopscotch, the Resident, the taxi... everything she'd encountered tonight was brand-new intelligence.

The Nest seemed to be changing; she just didn't know whether the changes were still within normal range.

But Sydney Ginn couldn't summon the energy to write any of it down just yet—she slumped in her seat and let out a long, slow breath.

Before the next crisis came along to torment her, all she wanted was to rest properly for a moment.

I'm dying—suddenly going back to cranking out daily word counts is a bit much... after all, my one-week stockpile of chapters took three months to write.

My update pace is probably a really bad fit for the male-demographic channels—is there a disabled-friendly channel somewhere? Maybe I should go there.

Chapter 9 — Goodbye, Sydney Ginn

"Thank you for riding,"

The driver's silhouette didn't move an inch—the one absolutely motionless object in the moving cab from start to finish. "You have arrived at your destination."

Sydney Ginn stood on the street beside the Museum of Modern Art; with a "thud," the car door closed behind her.

When she instinctively turned to look, she caught a glimpse of the yellow taxi's red taillights gliding into the fog that rose from the depths of the night and the white steam curling up from the drain grates, blurring into the distance.

...She seemed to have forgotten something.

Sydney Ginn stood in the street and watched the taillights until they vanished into the dark night, the foggy blue, and the smoky white—though she couldn't say why she kept staring after them.

She knew, of course, that a stretch of her memory had been collected as the fare, and no amount of trying would ever bring it back.

But Sydney felt that what she'd forgotten lay beyond that taken memory—as if there was something she should have noticed but hadn't. It was like the feeling she sometimes got before leaving the house, a vague suspicion that she'd left something behind; like a layer of cloud covering part of her mind, impossible to brush aside, the moon nowhere to be seen.

At times like these, no amount of thinking ever helped; you had to wait until you were already out the door and the moment actually came, and then you'd slap your thigh and suddenly understand.

Oh well—she'd gotten off the car with all her limbs intact and her head still on her shoulders, so whatever she'd forgotten clearly wasn't a matter of life and death. She'd remember it sooner or later.

She pressed herself against the glass door of Entrance D, peered inside first, then carefully pushed it open little by little.

Unlike Blackmoor City, buildings and facilities inside the Nest were almost never locked. If you came across a door that wouldn't open, it usually meant there was a Hunter inside—the faint comfort of a lock seemed to be something people who ventured into these strange and treacherous depths clung to all the more tightly.

After all, people can't survive without at least a little illusion of safety. If everyone knew exactly what was happening in the world at every moment, would anyone dare step out their front door?

Sydney held the door open with one hand but didn't go in. She waited a few seconds, and when silence held on the other side, she stepped inside as soundlessly as she could, placing her foot on the floor.

Even deep into the night, the museum had half its lights on, and the hallways, galleries, and elevator lobbies were all soaked in a white light that looked like it had been sterilized.

Perhaps because it was a museum of modern art, the lighting design and architectural style always left one with a sense of vast emptiness and coldness. Walking between the still white walls and white light, she felt almost too "alive"—too warm, too much, entirely out of place.

Following the signs, she quickly found the elevator lobby.

The broadcast had given three main instructions: one, "take the first elevator on the left"; two, "do not look at the other elevators"; three, "go to the basement level"—none of them complicated. Fortunately, the fare she'd paid getting into the cab hadn't been this particular memory, or she'd really have been in trouble.

Sydney pressed the button, planted herself in front of the first elevator on the left, and stared straight ahead at nothing.

This wretched place—sometimes it wasn't surprising in the least; when a clear "ding" shattered the still air, sure enough, the elevator that arrived first was the one on the right.

A dead silence held for a breath, then, like a zipper being slowly undone, the elevator doors parted.

Sydney didn't look, but every hair on her body stood up like a tiny antenna. Her eyes were locked rigidly on the closed elevator doors in front of her, and she had a vague sense that the elevator on the right wasn't empty—there was something in there.

Let it come, she'd made up her mind long ago—never mind a Resident, even if a flood of cash poured out of that right-side elevator, she would not turn her eyes so much as a fraction.

"How wonderful, there's someone out here..."

A woman's voice threaded out of the elevator like a strand of silk, drawn by some invisible hand, trembling in the air. "Listen to me—I came down from the third floor. Something very serious happened up there..."

Don't talk to me, Sydney told herself silently. I'm deaf and blind.

The display above the first elevator on the left glowed with a blood-red "28"; this building had only three floors above ground.

"Don't be afraid,"

The woman's voice, which had started out thin as a thread, was gradually thickening, as if voices, too, had roots. Or perhaps the woman herself was crawling out of the elevator inch by inch, and the source of the sound was drawing closer to Sydney.

"I'm a Hunter from Blackmoor City too—I came in to retrieve an Artifact I'd hidden... but after I got in, I lost track of time... What's today's date? The day I came in, Reagan was giving his victory speech."

I'm blind and deaf, I'm deaf and blind—Sydney repeated it to herself like a chant.

She shifted a step to the side as if by accident—but not too far, in case the elevator doors opened and she couldn't dart in at the first moment.

"Whatever you do, don't get on that elevator,"

Now that the voice was closer, it no longer sounded like silk thread—it had become sewage gurgling up from the mouth of a dark pit. "I never should have listened to the host... The first two times I got what I wanted and that made me overconfident; the third time it led me straight to my death. Lucky I reacted fast enough..."

The moment the words "the host" reached her ears, Sydney almost couldn't suppress the urge to turn her head. She still kept her eyes fixed on the elevator, but her heart lurched as if it had been jabbed, beating nearly out of her control, the sound of it hammering over and over in her ears.

Her gaze was propped in midair, too afraid to drop; yet a dark shadow had slowly risen from the floor and stilled at chest height beside her, as if it were listening with its head tilted.

...Did a racing heartbeat count as a response to the woman?

Sydney didn't dare make any reaction at all. Her breathing and the dark shadow at her chest held each other in a frozen standoff for a few seconds in the cool, silent elevator lobby—until another elevator arrival "ding" finally broke the stagnant air.

The door of the first elevator on the left opened.

Wait—the woman was stopped right in front of her; to get past, she'd have to go around it. But if she went around it, could that still count as ignoring it?

But if she didn't go around it, she couldn't very well walk right through it either.

Sydney watched the door part little by little, revealing an empty elevator car; just as she couldn't make up her mind, she felt the dark shadow at her chest suddenly flinch to one side and pull back.

"Annoying..." the woman seemed to mutter.

Sydney never stopped to wonder why good things happened to her when they did, because good things were fragile, and they couldn't withstand being examined too closely.

The moment the shadow stepped aside, she immediately strode into the elevator and slapped the door-close button over and over—"thwack thwack thwack"—as if she meant to punch through the panel; the whole time, her gaze stayed turned to one side, never once looking toward the doors outside.

But even without looking, she could feel it in the corner of her peripheral vision—a shadow on the floor, its limbs swaying against the ground like some enormous lizard, slowly crawling away into the distance.

Only when the elevator doors finally shut completely, grumbling as they carried her down into the basement level, did Sydney let out the breath she'd been holding clenched inside her chest.

So far, she'd followed the broadcast's instructions to the letter—nothing should go wrong again—

"...The first two times I got what I wanted," the woman's voice suddenly echoed back in her mind, "and the third time led me straight to my death."

Sydney rubbed the corners of her eyes and decided to push that nagging, distracting thought aside for the moment.

The Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion was meant to be heard by the Nest's Residents—it was no surprise at all that the woman knew about the host.

Compared to the lizard-like Resident in the elevator lobby, she still trusted the broadcast host a little more; that "trust," of course, carried within it three parts doubt, three parts wariness, and three parts scrutiny.

Yet the next few minutes seemed to prove that the broadcast host hadn't said a single false word. In the dimly lit basement gallery, she found the exhibit named "Candlefall" with almost no effort—honestly, it would have been harder to miss it.

Sydney stood before the exhibit and stared, dumbfounded.

Because the exhibit named "Candlefall" was a colossal white candle—roughly her height in diameter and easily tens of meters long—lying horizontally on the floor.

If not for its unmistakably waxy, milky-white surface, smooth and faintly lustrous, and the black wick the length of an arm drooping from one end, it would have looked more like a giant's roof beam. The candle rested on a series of iron frames specially built for it, beneath which ran a row of metal troughs whose purpose she couldn't make out.

"This thing is an Artifact?"

The candle was so enormous that Sydney walked around it for a while and still hadn't made it all the way. "Hard to say how powerful it is, but the size alone is really something..."

This big—how was she supposed to bring it back on her own? Would cutting off a piece work?

She couldn't even tell what this Artifact did, let alone whether cutting a piece off would work.

Ordinary art exhibits always came with a brief introduction to the piece and its creator; from experience, if there was detailed information about an Artifact, it was likely in the write-up.

Sure enough, when Sydney walked around to the other side of the candle, she found that the introduction for "Candlefall" covered half a wall of text.

"Some say time is like flowing water; some say time is speed. But artist Judy Picault believes time is wax... The time we are living through is a candle slowly melting away, giving us the

illusion that its form is still within our grasp; yet the moment it passes, it becomes hardened candle tears, fixed forever in the shape of history.

"...The artist's interpretation of time ultimately gave form to the exhibit 'Candlefall.' The colossal candle visitors see before them represents a long, primordial span of time.

"It is an interactive artwork. Visitors may build a fire beneath the iron frames to heat the candle, watching it gradually deform and shed its candle tears."

Among the neat rows of printed black text, there were lines of handwriting scrawled in—crooked, lurching strokes, as if whoever had originally printed the introduction for "Candlefall" had deliberately alternated one passage of orderly reason with one passage of wild, crumbling madness.

"It's an Artifact okay Artifact Artifact an Artifact that melts time"

"Melt time and you free history from its chains! Go look at your own history don't accidentally kill your past self put me inside, what do you say, put me right beside your past self"

The next passage returned to normal.

"Once the candle grows transparent from the heat, visitors will notice the contents the artist has embedded within the wax. They represent historical events that occurred within the span of primordial time. By re-melting the hot wax and reshaping it—altering the contents inside—visitors can change 'what originally happened.' The artist believes..."

Reading this far, Sydney could no longer hold back; she turned to look at the enormous milky-white candle behind her, and for a moment simply didn't know how to process the shock.

You could melt and reshape this candle to alter time—no, to alter history?

Was she understanding this correctly?

If she was, then being called "one of the most powerful Artifacts in existence" was a title it had well and truly earned.

She would need to study the specific instructions more carefully, and ideally try it herself once. She'd also need to figure out what effect it might have on the future.

She had to form a basic understanding first before she could think about next steps. Cutting off a piece to take away probably wasn't going to work; even with other Hunters to help carry it, it

couldn't be moved, since everyone's passage was different and they couldn't go back together. It seemed the only option for now was to hide it somewhere...

That was the last thought passing through Sydney Ginn's mind before she turned around and a hunting knife was driven into her throat.

After half a year off, everything else aside, my typing speed has practically gone in reverse... I've realized there's a kind of resolute beauty in all of you—I clearly have no resemblance to a donkey that cranks out twenty thousand characters a day and pays off a debt in a month, and yet when you all pledged your support, you were so decisive about it that I, a trembling donkey, was left humbled and awed.

For example, Wanjin... if you won't feel sorry for me, who will? Can't we let our bond flow on gently, like a slow stream? Alright, that's a sixth big fat baby owed. And then there's 95 — she really isn't my alt account, and I have no idea what potential she saw in me, sending people and money and effort and support my way. Alright, that's another big fat baby...

Buwenhuakaijiv, Grandma, don't you already know what I'm like — and then there's Changgoagao's Fish, Always on the Side of the Egg, Linze, Shimodege — you're all Grandma's readers, and we can really take it slow. Can't keep shearing the same flock of sheep forever, can I?

I also want to thank Haiyan Qifeng, Love Letter W0ZV, nestea, Fengyin (you two seem like new readers? or just the quiet type?), Dongxie (somehow you all feel like a matching set?), Banxia Jiejie, Jianbing Fujin (please for the love of god stop), Kafka, Qiti, Junmi xi, Xuanfeng Feiwanr, Qiwu, Weba de Qingjiatiao (did you flip it backwards?) and everyone else for all your support and encouragement... The word "thank you" in Chinese feels like I've worn it down to a nub from overuse! I haven't written anything that good either — it's really not worth all this!

Seven — seven chapter update AAAAAAAA

Maybe I should just go catch all seven Calabash Brothers instead

PS: This one definitely won't take as long to write as Doomsday! Even an eighteen-year-old values her life! Two or three years, I say with the reckless confidence of youth.

Chapter 10: A Gathering of Heroes at Mai Minghe

Mai Minghe had never heard of the Nest, and had no idea what a "Resident" was or how dangerous one might be.

But she figured that no matter how strange things appeared on the surface, nothing could ever violate the internal logic governing it.

The hospital inside the Nest seemed to operate by the same principles as a real hospital: press the call button, and a "nurse" would come—or rather, someone "disguised as a nurse" would come—and that someone's target would be whoever had pressed the button.

The only difference was that nurses in a real hospital came to take care of patients; what the "nurses" here intended to do... she didn't let herself think any further.

If she couldn't escape the ward, she was about to find out firsthand anyway—why waste the energy thinking about it?

To get out, she needed to create a few evenly matched rivals for the patient in the next bed.

There was one truth that held both inside and outside the Nest: only when multiple blades clashed against one another would gaps appear; a single blade would pass through her without any distraction.

The real question was: could she slip through the narrow gap between those blades?

Clearly, the red-haired man had figured out the thinking behind her pressing the button.

The moment he steadied himself, he drove his foot hard into Bed No. 2—its locked wheels grinding harshly across the floor—sending the patient and the whole bed crashing into the cabinet and beds behind him; amid the impact, he shouted without looking back: "Even if you wanted to draw the Artifacts out, you didn't have to press the damn button four times!"

He had a point; to be honest, Mai Minghe was feeling a little regretful herself right now.

She had just rolled off the bed again, hoping to use the moment the red-haired man was blocking her to drop down on the other side of Bed No. 1 and make a run for the door; but before Mai Minghe could even swing her leg across the mattress, she stopped dead.

On the other side of Bed No. 1, a nurse was already standing there.

What filled her field of vision was the hem of a light-colored nurse's uniform.

She froze on the bed, staring at that patch of fabric, and realized that in just a few seconds the room had filled with people.

One human-shaped shadow after another, like trees sprouting from the floor, far more than four of them, stood silent and still in the dim ward.

In her peripheral vision she couldn't make out their faces—only the vague impression of round, oversized heads, all exactly alike, every single one turned to face the corner of the room where two living, breathing people remained.

How had so many of them come?

"...Everyone's so kind. I'm actually feeling much better," she said flatly. "Why don't a few of you head back?"

As the "nurse" beside the bed slowly tilted its neck down toward her, Mai Minghe closed her mouth.

A flurry of fragmented, terrifying guesses raced through her mind; but she hadn't expected that when the figure lowered its head, she would find herself looking at a perfectly normal, healthy face.

"Where does it hurt?"

It was a young, soft round face. It—or should she say "she"?—spoke with a slightly drawn-out southern accent, as if she hadn't been on the job long enough to lose it.

If she looked only at the nurse's large eyes with their slightly drooping outer corners and ignored the round heads one after another in her peripheral vision, ignored the slender black silhouette several meters tall rising from behind the red-haired man, Mai Minghe might truly have believed everything just now was an illusion, a dream she'd been having while lying in a hospital bed.

"Get away from that nurse!" the red-haired man suddenly shouted.

Mai Minghe startled and instinctively glanced toward him—somehow the red-haired man had managed to half-climb the wall, like a knockoff Spider-Man who hadn't quite mastered his powers and looked a bit awkward about it.

The moment he climbed up, what had been behind him was exposed: the slender black silhouette with its head pressed against the ceiling was walking toward Mai Minghe, one step at a time.

On the left and right of the bed, Residents; the only way out was at the foot—

As if heaven had heard her thoughts and set out to grant her wish, Mai Minghe suddenly felt a tightening around her ankle, as though something had seized it and gave a sharp yank; she was pulled helplessly down onto the bed, the nurse's face and the ceiling sweeping past her eyes as she was dragged straight toward the foot of the bed.

Cold and hot sweat broke out all at once; Mai Minghe frantically reached out both hands and grabbed the edge of the bed, but all that accomplished was leaving her palms burning raw—it did nothing to slow her at all.

Whatever was gripping both her feet from beneath the bed and dragging her toward the foot possessed a strength no human could match—never mind Mai Minghe, even a Marine would be no match for it; in her desperation, she called out: "My ankle!"

The little nurse tilted its head.

"My ankle hurts!"

Even as those few words left her mouth, most of her body had already been hauled off the bed, her feet nearly touching the floor.

The slender shadow that had come down from the neighboring bed was standing at the foot of the bed, waiting for her.

It was nothing like what she had planned—the thing wasn't interested in where Mai Minghe was about to be dragged at all: because as she was being pulled off the bed, her pajamas had ridden up, exposing her lower abdomen—and the coils of "snake bandage" wound around it.

The slender shadow reached its hand toward her stomach.

"Oh?" The girl's southern drawl stretched long and warm: "If the ankle's gone, it won't hurt anymore."

Every word she had ever been told a proper young lady shouldn't say made a lap through Mai Minghe's mind.

At the same moment, the slender shadow made contact with her abdomen.

The instant those ice-cold fingertips touched her skin, Mai Minghe nearly lost consciousness.

It was as though the fibers of her skin, her blood vessels, her fascia—all of it seized and twisted together at that icy touch, tying itself into knot after knot; her mind could not endure the agony of her nerve endings knotting up, and darkness was already rising before her eyes.

The little nurse wasn't stopping the slender shadow, her ankle looked like it was about to be lost, and all the while she was still sliding down toward the floor beneath the bed...

Just as Mai Minghe thought all hope was gone, in a flash she heard a screech erupt from beneath the bed.

The emotions that screech stirred in the human ear were almost impossible to describe: the closest comparison would be discovering that your jackpot lottery ticket had fallen into the toilet—watching a winning ticket spiral away with the waste, that gut-wrenching feeling was more or less what it felt like to hear the screech from under the bed.

But regardless, her feet were finally released.

The little nurse let out a small "Hmm?" It had been standing by the side of the bed just a moment ago, yet somehow had already moved to the foot of the bed as well, crouching down to examine Mai Minghe's ankle.

"There's something on your ankle," the little nurse said. "I didn't get through it just now—let me try again."

As it spoke, it raised its hand—and it was the first time Mai Minghe got a clear look at that hand: extending from the wrist was not a hand at all, but a dense cluster of thick, silver-bright steel needles.

In that instant, she thought she understood.

The nurse had jabbed its needles at her ankle, but a pair of hands was gripping that ankle, so the needles had naturally gone straight into those hands instead...

Mai Minghe understood now, but with her elbows propped on the bed and her feet on the floor, even without anything restraining her, she could barely hold herself up enough to keep from sitting down on the ground—she couldn't move at all—because the slender patient was standing right in front of her, body half-folded down, long fingers slowly peeling away the "snake bandage."

Every time they touched, that agony of knotted blood vessels and nerves left her unable even to breathe, let alone walk or run.

"My stomach," she stared at the countless densely packed needle-tips, forcing the words out: "my stomach hurts now... stick it in my stomach..."

The little nurse seemed unable to see the other Residents, or if it could, it paid them no mind; it glanced down at Mai Minghe's abdomen, raised the needle-cluster high, and jabbed downward.

The slender patient finally stopped peeling away the "snake bandage," and suddenly flung its arm in a sweeping swipe at the little nurse—its arm unfolding joint by joint through the air as if it had an unknowable number of joints hidden within it—it sounds slow described like this, yet in the blink of an eye, a curtain was pulled from nowhere, and the little nurse and its steel needles were blocked behind it.

What kind of strange trick was that?

Mai Minghe certainly wasn't going to sit there and wait to see if the little nurse could get out from behind the curtain.

She seized the opportunity, leapt up, darted past the slender patient, and sprinted for the ward door—from the moment she had first spotted the little nurse to now, only a few seconds had passed, and already she felt like half her life had been used up.

"Keep it up," a round-headed figure said from the darkness.

Do I need your encouragement?

"Duck," said another round-headed figure, still in place, in a flat tone.

Who would duck at a time like—

Mai Minghe slammed to a halt and dropped into a crouch. She immediately felt something whip past just above her head—and something went thud against the doorframe of the ward.

She was only five or six steps from the door now, yet she had no choice but to turn back; unwilling to give up, she shot a quick glance—there seemed to be a pale white hand embedded in the doorframe, attached to an impossibly long arm.

A spiderweb of cracks spread across the wall around the doorframe.

If she hadn't ducked, that hand would have landed squarely on the back of her head and smashed her against the doorframe like a fly.

Well. She really did need the round-heads' encouragement after all.

"Hey!" Mai Minghe ran toward the cluster of motionless round-headed figures and called out: "What's the deal with all these big heads?"

From behind one of the round-headed figures, a shadow suddenly stirred—Mai Minghe had barely startled before she heard it suck in a sharp breath, as if fighting through pain, and answer: "I've never seen this kind of Resident before. I don't know either."

Apparently the red-haired man had come down from the wall at some point and seemed to have been injured in the process; probably to avoid the slender patient, he had also moved close to this cluster of round-headed figures in the center of the room, separated from her by several shadowy forms.

Mai Minghe badly wanted to keep asking him what Residents he had seen, and what Residents even were, but this was clearly not the time—the slender patient had already turned its head in this direction, and the sound of its crown scraping against the ceiling made a soft, rasping hiss.

As if terrified of the slender patient getting close, the red-haired man quickly threaded himself between the round-headed figures; his face was ashen, slicked with sweat, as he edged sideways in small steps through the crowd toward the door, not daring to brush against any of the round heads.

Mai Minghe followed his lead and quickly stepped into the forest of round heads as well.

The moment she got a clear look, it felt as though every organ inside her had lost its support and dropped deep into her gut.

The reason they had all looked identical was that in the dimness, every head appeared swollen and round and enormously large; but up close, the round-heads were actually of all kinds—men and women, old and young, their features all different.

Yet what should have been normal human skulls had every bone separated—the facial bones, the cranium, all of it—and some gas-like substance beneath had inflated the skin outward, forcing the shattered bones and human skin together into a perfect sphere: the fragments of bone shattered beneath the skin were still recognizable by their shapes, calling to mind the continental plates drifting on the surface of the earth.

The eyes, one on each side, were set separately into either side of the skull, like two blisters risen from the flesh, swiveling to follow Mai Minghe's footsteps; the nasal bone had been split cleanly in two down the middle, pulling two crooked, elongated nostrils open across the "face."

The mouth, at least, was normal; beside the corners of the mouth, across every face, long lines of deep-purple sunken grooves ran everywhere—the marks left by skin stretched until its fibers had torn.

A guess suddenly surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind. "Could these originally have been people?"

The red-haired man rounded the last round-headed figure, stepped clear of the cluster, and strode toward the door. "Sorry—you're the Resident's target, and there's nothing I can do about that. If I ever get the chance to see your body again, I'll bring it back to Blackmoor City for you."

He truly wasn't the target; he was nearly at the door of the ward already, and the slender patient paid him no attention whatsoever.

At this point the nurse was still standing blankly behind the curtain, only its shoes visible below; the two hands reaching out from under the bed were also motionless.

Only the thin, elongated patient drifted slowly back and forth before that cluster of round-headed silhouettes, as though waiting for an opportunity to strike at Mai Minghe.

"It can't get in," said one of the round-headed figures standing to Mai Minghe's left, almost as if to reassure her.

The one on the right said, "We'll all surround you,"

A round-headed figure behind her finished the thought: "and walk together toward the door — you'll be able to get out."

Ugly as these things looked, they had a surprisingly good heart, and their idea wasn't bad either — Mai Minghe lowered her head, staring at the floor, and a thought that had surfaced not long ago flickered through her mind again.

No matter how bizarre the surface appeared, nothing could ever violate the inner logic by which it operated.

She snapped her head up and called out, "Hey, young man — stop right there, don't you dare step outside!"

Honestly, I was perfectly comfortable in the women's fiction side of things, and it was never my intention to come stir up the men's fiction scene... The numbers on the women's side aren't great, sure, but it's a nice little space for a small community to enjoy themselves. The mood is calm — everyone's numbers are more or less the same, there's no real difference between first place and tenth, and it's all very harmonious.

Men's fiction is a different story. The vibe feels anxious and high-pressure, like everyone's grinding out ten-thousand-character daily updates trying to blow up and dethrone the kings, chasing votes, chasing tips, rushing the plot, fast-forwarding to the power fantasy moments... I don't have that kind of firepower. Looking at all the rankings and charts and votes, I don't know how to put it — it feels like being swept into a roaring current, and it wouldn't be surprising to sink to the bottom any moment.

I still hope to work slowly and carefully, and write as well as I can. I also hope everyone will feel free to ask me to take days off — I'll absolutely say yes, every time.

Chapter 11: Mai Minghe's Rock-Paper-Scissors

In truth, Mai Minghe didn't really expect that the red-haired man, upon hearing her shout, would immediately pull back his foot and not step outside.

With an escape route right in front of him, who would hold back from taking that one step?

So what happened next truly exceeded her expectations by a wide margin: the red-haired man urgently pulled back the foot he'd been about to step into the corridor with, the motion so sharp he nearly lost his balance; he pressed one hand against the wall, hopped back two steps on one foot, and stopped in the doorway between himself and the round-headed figures, letting out a curse.

"How did you know?" His gaze passed over the round-headed figures one by one and landed on Mai Minghe.

The room was packed with "Residents" ready to move against them, yet at this moment there was a hairline gap between the knife's edges—a rare opportunity to exchange a few words.

Mai Minghe answered immediately: "I don't know what's going on exactly—I only know we can't go out there. What did you see? You didn't stay in just because some elder told you to, did you?"

"Don't talk down to me like you're my elder." The red-haired man rubbed his face irritably and said, "There's a Resident at the doorway."

The ward door stood wide open, revealing a hollow, brightly lit corridor; in the corridor's light, there was not even a shadow on the floor tiles.

"Really? Well, that's something—don't tell me it knows how to turn invisible?" Mai Minghe said, surprised, and couldn't help marveling, "Have they actually made that work? I remember back in '75 or '79, some scientist said they could use electromagnetic waves or something..."

"Stop rambling about nonsense," the red-haired man cut her off, his expression darkening further. "How did you know we couldn't go out?"

Mai Minghe first glanced at the tall, thin patient.

In her youth she'd stood five foot eight, yet even then she could only have seen the tall, thin patient's navel; the hospital gown was far too short, hanging at chest level, and there was a dark,

gaping hole in its stomach—she didn't dare look long, and quickly averted her eyes.

Mai Minghe hadn't forgotten that inexplicable step she'd taken outside.

The tall, thin patient still seemed unwilling to give up, but just as the round-headed ones had demonstrated, as long as she was surrounded by them, it appeared to lack the nerve to come inside.

She had a moment to catch her breath, though she had no idea how long it would last.

"These things came here to harm people, didn't they?" Mai Minghe explained. "They're so eager to help me get out—that means we definitely can't go out."

The red-haired man paused, as though Mai Minghe's words were a handkerchief stuffed into his mouth. "...That's it?"

"There are two other reasons, actually," Mai Minghe said, a little sheepish. "I don't know if you'll agree. You seem familiar with the Nest—take a look: are there a lot of lines on the faces of these round-headed ones?"

The red-haired man gave a nod—only half his attention was on Mai Minghe; the other half kept shifting back and forth among the round-headed figures, the tall, thin patient, and the empty doorway, staying alert.

"Same principle as stretch marks," he said in a low voice, "except they've grown on their faces."

For someone who didn't look like a married man, he knew a fair bit about that sort of thing; Mai Minghe couldn't help thinking that in the old days, if a man knew too much about women's bodies, it was somehow considered shameful.

Young people nowadays seemed different—though she wasn't sure how much things had really changed.

"Right. Their heads have been stretched as full as a nine-month belly, so it's no wonder they've developed those marks—but marks like that only appear when the fibers of living human skin are pulled apart and torn.

"It occurred to me: the bird-like Residents inside the Nest aren't human at all, so why would they bother growing stretch marks? If the round-headed ones were once living people... what on earth turned them into this?"

A bubble-like eyeball swiveled around and looked at her.

The red-haired man kept his gaze on the doorway, nodded, and said, "Makes sense. It means whatever turns people into Residents like this hasn't shown itself yet—it's lurking somewhere."

Even though it was invisible, the thing was right there in the doorway; thinking about it that way, no wonder the round-headed ones were all gathered in the center of the room, leaving the door clear instead of blocking it.

If Mai Minghe hadn't pressed the call button four times, if the thing hiding in the doorway were the only Resident she'd summoned, she would surely have woven past the figures in the room and made straight for the exit—and in that situation, she would almost certainly have walked straight into its hands.

From below the ceiling came the tall, thin patient's voice: "Had enough of the deduction game?"

The voice slid into her ears with a sticky, slithering quality, and Mai Minghe was hit by another wave of dizziness—nauseated to the point of retching—the biological instinct to expel invading pathogens and toxins from the body.

The tall, thin patient slowly bent at the waist; its face was about to emerge from the darkness and into the light of the doorway.

The red-haired man suddenly cried, "Don't look at it!"—Mai Minghe instantly turned her gaze away, retreating behind one of the round-headed figures, her heart hammering again. She noticed her mouth had gone dry and bitter; she didn't know how long it had been.

"Give it to me,"

The tall, thin patient was bent over, its skull hovering above Mai Minghe, its voice echoing and dripping down, so that one almost had the illusion that the sound itself carried slime and shreds of flesh.

Its hand circled above the crowd several times as though trying to grab Mai Minghe, yet it never reached down; it only howled: "Give it to me! Give it to me give it to me give it to me give it to me!!!"

Mai Minghe hunched over, her stomach acid surging up without control, spattering onto the floor.

Dizzy and weak-legged, she reached out and grabbed one of the round-headed figures by the arm; the round-headed figure immediately began to moan softly, murmuring, "It hurts... it hurts so much..."

Your skull is splitting open and you don't call that pain, yet me grabbing your arm for support is?

Mai Minghe steadied herself, straightened up, and let go; the round-headed figure fell silent.

"Damn it, this thing is dead set on getting the Artifact." The red-haired man stood against the wall, staring at the tall, thin patient. "Residents inside the Nest who want Artifacts are actually pretty rare—and of all things, you ran into a troublesome one."

Even without looking at it or going near it, the mere sound of the tall, thin patient's ceaseless howling was unbearable; if Mai Minghe kept vomiting, she would be dehydrated and unconscious before long, left as helpless as a fish on a chopping block.

The red-haired man had more than just experience—he probably had a way to deal with this too. She was about to ask him what to do when she heard him speak again: "...Rock, paper, scissors."

What?

A rustling sound came from below the ceiling, and even the elongated patient seemed to turn its head toward him.

"Are you casting a spell?" Mai Minghe asked with a wry smile.

"No, I just suddenly thought of that game." The red-haired man pressed his back against the wall, standing in a spot far from Mai Minghe and all the Residents, and said, "Think about it—why does the tall thin one want to grab you, but won't actually reach out and do it?"

"It's... wary of something?"

"Right, it doesn't dare touch the round-heads. The round-heads said it themselves—they counter it. So it won't make a move on the Residents by the door either, because the moment it turns around, the round-heads behind it can pounce." The red-haired man continued, "As for exactly why, I don't know either. And then the tall thin one counters you—no question about that —"

Hearing this, Mai Minghe understood.

"Like rock, paper, scissors, where each one beats another in a cycle," she said, cautiously reaching out toward one of the round-heads. "So next would be... I counter the round-heads?"

The moment she touched its arm, the round-head immediately began buzzing and moaning, its legs even starting to tremble and shake.

"I don't understand why they're afraid of you either," the red-haired man said.

"It's not fear, though..."

The elongated patient laughed in halting, staggered bursts, as if it had realized it could torment Mai Minghe with its own voice—and it had to be said, it had found the right approach.

"These humans—after being caught by the thing at the door, it pumps its own bodily fluids into them, turning them into flesh tentacles, each one standing upright from the ground, used specifically to deal with other Residents."

Mai Minghe wanted to hear more information; she just wasn't sure whether her insides would hold out.

As the elongated patient spoke, she stood half-bent over, feeling as though some great beast were churning deep in her abdomen, trying to force its way up her throat; all she could do was curl like a shrimp, wracked with spasms—she was completely helpless.

"A person has to be alive to serve as a flesh tentacle. When stimulated by another living person, the anesthetic effect of the bodily fluid diminishes, and the flesh tentacle risks regaining consciousness, separating from the host, and dying." The elongated patient explained with almost patient deliberateness. "When you touch them, it's the same as waking them back up—dragging them into unimaginable pain."

"Shut up," said one of the round-heads at the front, in a flat tone.

Mai Minghe was of the same mind—please, shut up.

"So that's how it is—the situation's at a stalemate." The red-haired man let out a small sigh of relief and said, "If the flesh tentacles attack the tall thin one, they have to move, and the moment they move, they expose you. If the tall thin one seizes the chance to grab you, it can use you to make the tentacles wake and detach, and in the end the two of them destroy each other. But that has nothing to do with me—getting dragged into this is a real injustice."

No one, human or Resident, paid him any attention.

...He had probably already made his plan—to use the moment the Residents came for him as a chance to escape.

Mai Minghe was furious, nauseated, and envious all at once, wishing desperately she could trade places with him.

"We can take a page from the human spirit of negotiation. Give me the person," the elongated patient said, not the least bit concerned about whether Mai Minghe would vomit up her stomach, "and give me the Artifact."

That was bad.

"How do we give her?" one of the round-heads asked.

"You have the flesh tentacles part," said the elongated patient. "I take the Artifact off her, then toss her to the door—toss her right into your mouth."

"And you guarantee it?"

"Of course. I have no interest in her."

The round-head was silent for a moment, then answered: "Agreed."

Mai Minghe felt very much not agreed.

But cold sweat was already breaking out across her back, and she had no idea how to stop this. Even if she could counter the round-heads, so what? Could she actually bring herself to wipe out her only line of defense?

Sure enough, the round-heads began to part in front of her, and all she could do in that moment was follow along behind them—wherever they retreated, she retreated too. For a moment, it was almost like playing a deadly game of duck-duck-goose.

"If you'd just given me the Artifact at the start, I might have let you live out your days as a little old lady," the elongated patient said, utterly unbothered by her stalling and resistance, laughing in a flat, measured way. "But you had to be clever, and in the end you'll only bring about your own ruin..."

It hadn't even finished speaking when Mai Minghe involuntarily doubled over again in another round of dry heaving. She had already emptied everything there was to empty; her consciousness was swimming and dim, and she could feel the round-heads hurrying away from her side.

No good—she had to stay with them—

She had no time to straighten up before the elongated patient reached down one hand and closed it tightly around her calf.

1. A stockpile of saved chapters is like snow under the summer sun—every glance shows there's less of it, and sooner or later it runs out completely... Last chapter I saw how enthusiastically everyone was asking me to take a day off. In male-oriented fiction where even one chapter a day can get you cursed out, isn't that something of a revolutionary force? It'll happen, it'll happen—I'll make sure everyone goes home happy, welcomed in like guests, cozy and chatting away.

2. I'm getting on a plane again on the 23rd—this year's theme is just one long haul after another. By my count, over the next few weeks I'll have spent thirty or forty hours in total curled up on planes. Every airline would find life a little emptier without me.

3. The world of the Artifact Report has a lot of settings and details to cover from every angle, plus the shifting POV format—I'm not sure how you all are finding it so far? Does the worldbuilding need to be laid out more plainly? Even though it's a modern Western setting, it doesn't feel like too much to swallow, does it? I stuck with Western-style translated names for the locations—otherwise Sydney Ginn getting into trouble on Red Flag First Street would feel like a completely different show.

4. I just love rambling. After all, a mouth is a mouth—when I'm bored it's either eating or talking, and talking nonsense doesn't put on any weight.

Chapter 12: Mai Minghe's Comedy Horror

In the instant the world tilted, Mai Minghe remembered only two things.

The first was sharp and overwhelming, driving away all capacity for thought and conjuring a warped hallucination before her eyes—for some reason, she found herself thinking of a time more than forty years ago, when she had gone on an outing in the countryside and seen a large tree.

It was the ugliest tree she had ever seen in her life: infected by some fungus or virus, the entire trunk was covered in gnarled, knotted burls, one piled on top of another, galls and warts crisscrossing every which way, so that at first glance it looked almost nothing like a tree—more like one great mass of brown, misshapen, overgrown flesh.

In cold sweat, trembling, and pain, she looked down at where her right calf should have been, and had the illusion that she was looking at that tree from forty years ago again—she hadn't even noticed when her head had struck the floor.

Thin, sickly fingers wound around her calf, joint by joint, long and slow.

The second thing was not really a feeling at all—it was a dull thud she heard, as though some heavy object had struck something, not far from her.

When she first heard it, Mai Minghe's mind had been wiped blank by the onslaught of pain, and she had not thought at all about what the sound might be; but something—whether it was the slick floor beneath her palm, or a flicker at the edge of her vision—struck her like a bolt of lightning through her hazy consciousness, and her mind suddenly lit up.

...So that was it.

Because the Slender Patient had been deliberately tormenting her, she had barely done anything since this all began—she had been doubled over retching amid the circle of Round Heads, unable to do much else; but no one in the ward had anticipated that this torment would bring with it another entirely unexpected consequence.

Which was that the ceramic tile floor of the ward was now smeared everywhere with slick, sticky patches of vomit and stomach acid.

In the "eagle catches the chicks" game just now, five or six pairs of feet had tramped back and forth through this slippery filth, spreading it all over the place—which meant that anything

walking on two legs faced a very real risk of slipping and going down hard enough to knock its teeth out.

No matter how strange a flesh-tentacle thing might be, if it walks upright on two legs, it still has to eat dirt when it slips—right?

The moment that thought came to her, strength surged from Mai Minghe's battered body; and as the Slender Patient's shadow loomed over her, she wrenched herself around with all her might and saw it.

Not far away, one of the Round Heads had indeed just fallen to the floor and was flailing, feet skidding, trying to get back up.

In that moment, if Mai Minghe could have laughed, she would have laughed out loud—think you can run?

No matter how bizarre the surface might be, the underlying logic could not escape; it seemed that the basic laws of physics applied to the strange things inside the Nest just as well.

In that moment, Mai Minghe forgot the Slender Patient entirely, lunged forward, stretched out her arm, and grabbed that Round Head by the ankle.

At the same moment, the Slender Patient's hand touched her abdomen again.

It would not have been strange at all if she had lost consciousness; what was strange was that she didn't.

The Slender Patient's shadow loomed high above her, and she still did not dare look at its face—her eyes fixed only on the ankle gripped in her left hand, staking everything on it.

Through the pain that blurred her mind, through the growing emptiness and dread as the "Snake Band" was peeled away from her body inch by inch, Mai Minghe held on to that Round Head's ankle without loosening her grip one bit—and then a pained groan that did not belong to her shuddered through the room.

"Tell it... tell it to get lost..." she wheezed, her words barely intelligible. "Otherwise I won't... I'll never..."

She didn't finish the sentence, but it didn't matter—the Resident at the door understood perfectly well.

Within a few seconds, one of the distant Round Heads said aloud, "Let her go!"

The Slender Patient appeared not to hear, still peeling the "Snake Band" away little by little, its movements slow and careful, almost gentle—yet no matter how delicate its touch, the pain it inflicted was still enough to blacken her vision.

"Hurry up,"

all the Round Heads urged in unison, striding toward the Slender Patient in perfectly synchronized steps. "A mature flesh-tentacle can't be lost—make her let go, or—"

"I know," said the Slender Patient, which was indeed wary of the Round Heads; seeing them all advance together, it finally released the hand gripping Mai Minghe's calf—its other hand still held the "Snake Band," and it clearly was not willing to let go of the Artifact.

The moment it let go, blood began to return to her calf, and what had been a knotted, tumor-covered tree slowly became a flesh-and-blood limb again.

But it was too late for that to help her.

Mai Minghe watched as a long, ghastly pale hand drifted through the air above her, its fingers unfurling joint by joint—how many joints were there?—and swung down toward her arm; never mind how much it would hurt when it connected, she had no confidence whatsoever that she could withstand that sweeping blow without having her hand knocked away.

If her hand was knocked away, wouldn't all her effort be wasted?

Before it could reach her, Mai Minghe shoved off the floor, barely managed to twist her body, and shot her right hand out toward the Round Head's ankle—if one hand wasn't enough to hold on, would two do?

She knew this idea was perhaps naive. She knew she had been driven into a corner that an ordinary human could not fight their way out of.

The world seemed to run its wheel over a person again and again, all just to make you bow your head, make peace with it, and swallow your resentment; she didn't know how she had lived through eighty-six years of it. The days that had felt endless at the time, like she could never endure them to the end—they had all passed in a flash.

If she had pushed back a little more often, resisted a little longer here and there, perhaps she wouldn't be carrying so much regret today—too much to bring herself to think about.

Compared to all the tangled suffering that people in this world had made for one another, these strange creatures were refreshingly simple and direct—almost endearing in their straightforwardness.

All she had to do was reach out one more hand. She could do it.

She could definitely—

The thought hadn't finished forming when a brief darkness swallowed Mai Minghe's mind and she knew nothing at all.

When the shapes around her came back into focus, she found herself lying on her side, both hands slack and empty against the floor.

The Round Head had long since scrambled up and retreated; the Slender Patient was peeling the last section of the "Snake Band" from her back—just one more coil and it would be gone from her entirely.

...She had failed?

Even two hands hadn't been enough to keep hold of the Round Head.

Mai Minghe lay on the floor smeared with her own stomach acid, her body seeming to have gotten a head start on returning to her eighty-six years, all weak softness and heavy weight.

The Slender Patient extended two fingers—long enough to skewer a person clean through—and flipped Mai Minghe over like a lump of dead meat, laying her flat on her back, then continued to peel away the final stretch of "Snake Band."

Being flipped like that, Mai Minghe's right hand flopped softly onto her own chest.

...Hm?

Her fingertips were wet—she didn't know if it was blood or filth; her nail beds especially were thick with it, a heavy, uncomfortable layer.

Wait.

...Blood?

The thought that surfaced in her mind sent a shudder through her whole body; as though driven by pure survival instinct, without thinking, she raked her hand down at the Slender Patient's arm.

Every time she had touched the Slender Patient before, the pain had been unbearable—so the Slender Patient had probably never imagined that Mai Minghe would willingly reach out and touch it. But there was something else it had imagined even less.

The instant Mai Minghe's fingernails made contact with the Slender Patient, it burst suddenly into a great churning mass of billowing shadow.

It was as though her touch had been an agony beyond all measure—so painful that the Slender Patient hurled the Artifact away, its long body writhing and shuddering, like a plume of grey-white, startled mist rising in the dim air.

...Just as she had thought.

Mai Minghe did not dare waste a moment; she immediately pushed off the floor and hauled herself upright, and the "Snake Band," as if alive, wound itself around her body again in coil after coil.

Once she was on her feet, she quickly stretched out her hand and flicked the liquid from her fingertips hard toward the Slender Patient—and as she flicked, she thought it over, and couldn't help but start laughing between gasps, the sound like broken glass, halting and sharp and bright.

It wasn't that she had a strange personality, laughing in circumstances like these—it was that the scene was genuinely funny: a spindly shadow with its head pressed against the ceiling, writhing and rolling, arms and legs flailing; and next to it, a woman flinging her hand at it in tremors so violent they looked like a stroke—one person, one ghastly thing, both looking like they'd grabbed a live wire.

Anyone who saw it would have to agree: even if you'd blundered into a horror film, this was a comedy horror.

"What's happening?" the red-haired man asked blankly from the other end of the ward. "Did it take the wrong medication? Did you?"

He was standing beside a hospital bed, pushing it toward the door, and at the sight of the Slender Patient's condition he had stopped moving altogether.

The moment Mai Minghe saw him, she understood immediately what he was doing, and called out at once: "Wait—take me with you!"

Even as the words left her mouth, she had already skirted around the Slender Patient and sprinted toward the bed; before the red-haired man could react, she leaped onto it and rolled on,

crying urgently: "Go, go, go—it's not dead yet!"

The red-haired man looked like he wanted to curse, then seemed to realize he had no time for it.

"You've got a nerve, hitching a ride—"

He bit off his complaint halfway, gripped the bed rails, and broke into a run, pushing the bed at full stride; just before they reached the doorway, the red-haired man grabbed the side rail, shoved off with one foot, and jumped onto the bed—and with the momentum already built up, the bed went rattling and rolling straight out the door, carrying both of them with it into the corridor.

"Don't touch the floor," the red-haired man shouted, kicking off against the wall to send the bed sliding farther down the corridor. "That Resident is underneath the floor!"

"It really is under the floor?" Mai Minghe gripped the bed tightly and said, "I told you not to go out the door because I'd noticed what looked like lots of fine lines drawn on the floor tiles between the Round Heads—I knew something was off about that. Thank goodness it wasn't invisibility."

"Invisibility has nothing to do with it!"

As the bed slid past the doorway, the floor tiles seemed to sense something; blood-red threads suddenly seeped up through them, like the countless red veins that appear in an eye filled with urgent fury—but both of them were seated on the bed, not touching the floor, and the "eye" could only watch helplessly as they glided away down the corridor, bed and all.

"What made that tall skinny one suddenly go berserk?" the red-haired man asked, pushing off the wall to move forward, not forgetting to ask.

The explanation was actually quite simple: when Mai Minghe had made that grab for the Round Head just now, she hadn't caught it, but her right hand had scraped open the skin of its ankle.

Before falling into the Nest, she had been a bedridden old woman whose fingernails had gone uncut for a long time and had certainly never been filed smooth—that desperate, clawing grab had dug deep enough to break the skin, and her nails had come away coated in the Round Head's blood.

"...Doesn't the Round Head counter it?"

Mai Minghe gave the wall a kick as well; the bed advanced through the corridor in a Z-pattern, and with each lurch as it struck one wall, it jolted whoever was speaking mid-syllable.

"Then whatever's inside a Round Head's body must counter it too—right? So I smeared that bit of blood on its hand. I really didn't expect it to have such a big effect."

The red-haired man couldn't help but smile. "And this is really your first time in the Nest? Well done."

"Are they going to catch up?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Very likely," the red-haired man glanced back down the corridor—still empty for now. "Get ready—we'll slide a bit farther, then we'll have to jump off and run."

As they spoke, the bed carrying the two of them glided past the window of one of the rooms.

In the glass, Mai Minghe caught a fleeting glimpse of her own reflection: hair in disarray, face pale, one side smeared with filth...

But a smile played at the corner of her mouth, and she looked the very picture of someone in the prime of their life.

Tomorrow I have to leave for the airport at five in the morning, and there's another flight the day after landing — absolutely exhausting. Watching the last little bit of my stockpiled chapters about to run dry, I feel like a wastrel who's squandered his inheritance: my ancestors left me a thousand taels of silver and ten thousand acres of farmland, and I've gambled it all away. It's over!

Before I board the plane, let me take a moment to sincerely thank the following new patrons:

Thank you Haynes for feeding me McDonald's (I already know exactly what I'll spend it on) — your support will surely be converted into body fat, keeping me company on my person, possibly for the rest of my life...

Thank you Ironclad Baitang for the several cups of coffee you gifted (you're back for the new book! Coffee is the only thing in the world keeping me from turning into a zombie) — if you ever catch a whiff of coffee in a chapter from now on, part of it is thanks to your support;

Thank you Weibaodeweimaor for the Minoxidil gift; why, you ask — seeing your username gave me quite the illusion that I'm Sun Wukong, as if plucking a hair and blowing on it would summon an enthusiastic reader to support me. What a bargain that would be. I want to grow more fur.

I also want to thank vitang for the sweets (my life ambitions really aren't all that grand), and to thank Kankankǎn Sherlock, Miemie's Little Fatty Soap, and the whirlwind Feiwán who treats gifting like checking in daily — thank you all for the encouragement. See you after I land!

Chapter 13 — Mai Minghe: The Way Things Tend to Go

"We've been through life and death together — I saved you, and you saved me."

The red-haired man was covered head to toe beneath a white sheet, and his voice came out muffled when he spoke.

In the room thick with the smell of disinfectant, an old incandescent bulb began to hum the moment it was switched on; Mai Minghe opened her eyes, only to find a white cloth draped over her face, her whole field of vision a murky, dim white.

"With that in mind, I won't go after the Artifact on you — for now. But if you run into any of my other Hunters, and they come for you, I certainly won't stop them. This is our mission, after all, and my people risk their lives to enter the Nest — I have no right to ask them to give that up."

"...That part I can live with,"

Mai Minghe spoke from beneath the white sheet, a warm, damp breath of air trapped between her and the fabric. "What I want to know is why we're lying in the morgue pretending to be corpses."

A few minutes earlier, the two of them had decided they were far enough from the Residents below, and had leapt off the hospital beds and bolted, desperate to put as much distance between themselves and the ward as possible and shake the Residents for good.

But as Mai Minghe ran, she had glanced back in a hurry, and in the distance she caught a dark shape flashing across the doorway of the ward — it looked like a Resident had given chase. The red-haired man noticed too, and hissed under his breath: "Running isn't going to work. We need to hide — follow me!"

The Spindly Patient was three or four meters tall and could stretch its body further still; if that was the one chasing them, there was truly no outrunning it.

What Mai Minghe hadn't expected, though, was that the red-haired man would lead her straight into a stairwell, clatter down to level B1, and then push open a door marked "Morgue" as if he'd done it a hundred times before.

When she hesitated in the doorway, he turned and shot her a glare. "Get in here — what are you standing around for? Do you want the Residents to catch up?"

Easy for him to say — who sees the word "Morgue" and feels any urge to rush inside?

Still, when she saw that her only living companion in this godforsaken place had already stridden in, it became clear that staying outside wasn't really an option either.

The moment she stepped through the door, an involuntary shudder ran through her; the temperature inside the morgue was at least three or four degrees colder than out in the hall.

"Find an empty bed," the red-haired man said, switching on the morgue light. He lifted a white sheet off one of the beds, lay down on it, and pulled the sheet back over himself. "Do what I'm doing — cover yourself head to toe, and don't move. If a bed already has someone in it, leave it alone; it'll be fine."

Mai Minghe stared at the gurney in the corner of the room — the white sheet draped over it rose and fell in the shape of a human body. The light flickered on and off, and she couldn't make out whether the figure beneath it was breathing, let alone whether it was a person, a corpse, or a Resident.

At any rate, whatever lay under that sheet hadn't exploded upright to greet them when they walked in, which was probably a good sign.

"Um..." She pointed at the gurney, only managing two words before the red-haired man, already flat on his back and fully covered, prompted her from beneath the sheet: "Hurry up."

In the span of a moment, the entire morgue had come down to one living person still standing — Mai Minghe — and two figures shrouded in white.

As she climbed onto the gurney and pulled the sheet over herself, a faint sense of unreality washed over her: an eighty-six-year-old woman, first admitted to a hospital ward and then ending up in the hospital morgue — it really was very much in keeping with the way things tended to go.

The whole night felt like a metaphor; for what exactly, she wasn't wise enough to say.

The red-haired man let out a sigh beneath his white sheet.

"First-timers in the Nest are nothing but trouble — they don't know anything," he said, dropping his voice. "Training new recruits is one of my least favorite parts of the job."

"It's not as though I wanted to lie in a morgue either," Mai Minghe replied. "You can't get through life without doing things you'd rather not do."

Including playing dead.

"Don't be so put out — the morgue is the 'door of life' in this hospital. Sounds ridiculous, right? How can a place for dead people be a door of life?"

Mai Minghe made a sound of agreement right away.

"The Nest contains countless locations, and each one has its own distinct terrain, dangers, and opportunities. St. Louis Hospital is a location my House Faction knows fairly well — this is my third time here. In St. Louis Hospital—"

"Wait, this is St. Louis Hospital?" Mai Minghe couldn't help cutting in. "You said this was the Nest — but St. Louis Hospital isn't far from my home at all."

She had been to St. Louis Hospital a few times before, and she'd never seen anything like this.

"No — the one you're thinking of is St. Louis Hospital in Blackmoor City. What we're in right now is the St. Louis Hospital that exists within the Nest.

"The Nest exists entirely outside the human world."

The red-haired man was quiet for a few seconds, as if giving those words time to truly sink into Mai Minghe's understanding.

"Perhaps the universe cracked somewhere, and the shadow that Blackmoor City cast into that crack became this Nest — a place full of danger and strangeness, an otherworld that only a handful of people can enter. Any place name you know from Blackmoor City, you can find here in the Nest as well, though it will almost always be a twisted, darkened version of itself."

As if afraid she might interrupt again, the red-haired man pressed on: "Long story short — we've found that when a person encounters a danger they can't shake inside St. Louis Hospital, say, when a Resident has set its sights on us, the morgue acts as a kind of 'reset' point."

"Reset?" Mai Minghe was working hard to absorb what he was telling her, and whatever she couldn't absorb, she fixed firmly in her memory.

She wasn't always up on the words young people used; smartphones — or was it "smart phones"? — had taken her quite a while to figure out too.

"Right. Simply put: you come to the morgue, pull the sheet over your face, lie still for a bit, and in the eyes of St. Louis Hospital, you've 'died.' The person the Residents were chasing is dead, so naturally they stop chasing. When you walk back out, you're a brand-new living person — nothing's after you anymore. It sounds absurd at first, but think it through and it actually makes

sense, doesn't it? Someone who's ended up in a hospital morgue — of course the hospital forgets about them quickly enough."

"It's the same in ordinary life," Mai Minghe murmured. "It's not only hospitals that forget you."

"Which is exactly why I brought you here," the red-haired man concluded. "Count yourself lucky — if you were a Hunter from any other House Faction, I would never have brought you along so easily."

"Why not?"

"Rivals don't do each other favors."

Mai Minghe understood, more or less. These people called themselves Hunters, and the Hunters were apparently divided into many House Factions; they had no way of knowing whether other factions had discovered that the morgue was a reset point, and if they hadn't, there was naturally no reason to give away something so valuable.

"But why do you all come to the Nest in the first place...?"

"Come on," the red-haired man gave a short laugh. "Feel the Artifact on your stomach and think about why. The effects Artifacts can produce are endless — from raising your IQ by five points to overturning fate itself, nothing is beyond them; they can even bring the most impossible human fantasies to life. But Artifacts only exist in the Nest. Back in Blackmoor City, there's no shortage of powerful people in politics and business willing to pay a fortune for them. Where there's demand, there's supply — economics is what leads us all into the Nest."

He paused, then said: "That's why we're called Artifact Hunters."

Artifact Hunters...

In the very city where she had lived her whole life, there was apparently a whole world of people chasing and trading in things as fantastical as something out of a dream...

And now, through her own carelessness, she had stumbled into a world beyond the world, and been given a second life.

Mai Minghe lay on the gurney, her heart thudding.

What surprised her was that she felt no fear right now, no urge to flee back home; instead she felt rather like a child who had wandered into an amusement park in the dead of night — the

darkness was its own domain, and the unfamiliar, eerie silhouettes of the park in the dark were as irresistible as they were vast and wondrous.

The Nest... in the deep blackness of a shadow-filled night, a fairground where she could climb onto a spinning carousel horse and ride toward the extraordinary.

"I never imagined... that I would ever fall into a place like this," she said softly.

Set against tonight, all the years before seemed to have suddenly shriveled and gone dull.

"It's understandable that you didn't know the Nest existed before now. Without someone experienced to guide you, finding your passage by sheer luck and stumbling into the Nest on your own is not something that happens often—"

"Passage?" Mai Minghe seized on the word, nearly bolting upright like a corpse reanimated. "After I ran into the television screen, I fell straight into the ward. Does that mean the television screen is my 'passage'?"

The red-haired man considered this and gave a low "hm."

"So that's how you got in... You've never run into a television screen before, have you?"

Of course not — nobody goes around headbutting televisions for no reason.

"Every Hunter's passage is different." The red-haired man gave a quiet laugh and said: "Of all humanity, only one percent are born with a passage that can lead them into the Nest. The conditions vary from person to person, and most of them are pretty strange and demanding. So even within that one percent, who knows how many people live out their entire lives without ever opening their passage — never even knowing the Nest exists..."

Wasn't that exactly her situation? Eighty-six years, right up until the night a thief broke through her front door—

Mai Minghe gave a start.

...Right. That thief was an Artifact Hunter too.

"Some people have relatively ordinary passages," the red-haired man went on. "I've heard of someone who could enter the Nest simply by sitting down in a full bathtub. Not that his luck was anything to envy, mind you — the first time you take a bath, you're small and young and bare and you haven't brought anything with you. What are the odds you make it back out of the Nest alive?"

"Then there are people whose passages are more troublesome — standing in the toilet bowl while flushing, opening a door in an abandoned building, and so on and so forth, the list goes on. The conditions for simply opening a passage are already so exacting that a huge number of people are eliminated right there; and on top of that, there's one more important requirement for entering the Nest."

"What requirement?"

"Your passage can only be opened in a city with a population of over ten million. We don't fully understand why, but..."

The red-haired man lowered his voice. "The general belief among Hunters is that the Nest is a byproduct born once human civilization reaches a certain scale. So the most densely populated places are the ones connected to the Nest."

Mai Minghe lay quietly for a moment.

Every word he had just said was like a piece of a puzzle, slowly assembling in her mind into a deep world she had never imagined existed; she very much wanted to reach up and press her fingertips to her temple — the spot swollen from hitting the television screen — just to confirm she wasn't dreaming.

"All right,"

There was a rustling of fabric nearby, the sound of the red-haired man lifting the sheet and sitting up. "That should be enough time — the reset ought to be complete. If you want to hold on to that Artifact, you'd best not let any of my companions see you."

The young man did have a decent streak in him after all.

"The Artifact I'm carrying — are you planning to hand it over to Wellesley?" Mai Minghe asked.

"That's right, he's the one who hired us," the red-haired man said, startled, turning to look at her. "You know about that too?"

"He's already dead — he can't buy the Artifact anymore." Mai Minghe thought back to the news that had been running nonstop on television for the past two days and asked, "Haven't you heard yet? When did you all enter the Nest?"

The red-haired man gave her a skeptical sideways glance, then looked away.

He clearly didn't believe her.

The Artifact Wellesley wanted had happened to land in her hands, and the moment it did, she was already saying Wellesley was dead and couldn't buy it anymore — it was a little too convenient a coincidence, no wonder he didn't buy it.

"Ha — he's not about to die. Those Artifacts he has on him are so powerful that—" The red-haired man stopped himself mid-sentence, rubbed his nose, and let the thought drop. "Dead or alive, I've already said I won't make a move on you. My advice is to get back to Blackmoor City as fast as you can."

"How do I get back?"

Though the Nest was both terrifying and captivating, Mai Minghe's best move right now was to get out while she could—for the Artifact's sake.

"Haah, this is really..." The red-haired man let his shoulders drop, looking a little deflated. "In for a penny, in for a pound—I'll take you to the exit. But let's get one thing straight: the moment a House Faction Hunter spots us, I'll have no choice but to join them in taking the Artifact from you."

Hello, friends—what you're seeing now is yet another message from on high; I have ascended the throne, so doesn't that practically count as a divine decree?

Day after day it's nothing but power struggles—one minute crowning myself, the next getting knocked off the pedestal.

I have a question rattling around in my stomach (sorry, it's not a baby): I've seen readers mention that Qidian now puts a lot of weight on something called "chasing-read" numbers—what's that? Does it literally just mean the number of people following the updates? What happens if it's too low? What counts as enough? Can I count myself as one... Writing a novel has me on edge every single day.

Chapter 14 — Chase, Where the Sea Meets the Sky

"...AED defibrillator, cardiac stimulant, epinephrine,"

The brilliant neon lights on the distant shore fell into the water and were jostled by the waves, gradually dissolving into patches of dim amber and murky green ripples that rocked along with the hull atop the pitch-black swells.

"Last one — broad-spectrum antibiotics, in case we need to be out here for a while."

Once each item had been introduced, a silver-white medical case snapped shut with a sharp clap; a large hand with long fingers reached under the seat and pulled out a black cylinder.

"This is a cauterizing gun. It can seal large wounds, sear through blood vessels and nerves, and keep a person from bleeding to death — very handy."

Accompanied by a cheerful voice, that large hand gave a hearty slap on the shoulder of the man in the white coat sitting beside him.

"Let me introduce you — Dr. Nate, a decent man. Not only has he supplied me with everything, he's also willing to come in person to handle any unexpected situation... For instance, after I cut off your limbs, he can guarantee you'll neither die nor lose consciousness."

Dr. Nate didn't say a single word. His lips were pressed tightly together, his face contorted, a sickly pallor washing over him — he looked like a wisp of fog floating in the night.

The cauterizing gun was set down, and a pair of hands clapped together loudly. "Come now, say thank you to Dr. Nate."

What answered him was a muffled, incoherent cry — a man with his limbs bound behind his back, wrapped from head to toe in tape so tightly that only his eyes and nostrils were exposed, thrashing desperately, rocking the small boat back and forth and stirring up soft lapping waves.

"I'll speak for Dr. Nate — you're welcome, it's the least I could do."

The man in the expensive suit, tall and broad, his smile never wavering, leaned in and gave the bound figure a friendly pat.

His black hair was combed back, sleek and neat, catching faint glimmers of light in the night above the sea.

"Don't be impatient — I haven't finished making introductions."

He spread his pale hands wide, and with a flip and a grab of his right hand, effortlessly pulled a heavy weight plate from under the seat. "Each arm and leg, once severed, will be tied to a twenty-five-kilogram plate. You'll be able to watch your own limbs go plunk — sinking to the bottom of the sea..."

He let out a low whistle, his fingers swaying nimbly from high to low, like fish gliding down into the depths.

"...Just like that."

The man mummified in tape let out another garbled, heavy groan, like a wild animal trapped in a bag and unable to break free.

The suited man leaned back in his chair, studying his captive with an air of leisurely amusement.

"Ready to start talking?"

The bound man twisted and writhed furiously: "Mmph, mmph!"

The suited man flicked open a knife, gauged roughly where the mouth was, and drove the blade in a deep slash across the tape — blood and a shriek of pain erupted together into the night.

Slender fingers worked into the blood-slicked slit in the tape and pulled out a large wad of medical cotton.

The moment it left his mouth, panting and retching poured out of the man in broken spurts: "You — who are you? What do you want..."

The suited man leaned in close, fixing his gaze on his prey, his eyes so dark they reflected not a single glimmer of light.

"I'll cooperate with whatever you want — there's no need to be this brutal..." As the bound man spoke, the wound on his lips tore wider, and the pain twisted his face; in the darkness his face was slick and wet. "I'm nobody — I'm nothing to anyone..."

"That's the wrong thing to say."

The suited man raised one index finger and cut him off. "A nobody who's nothing to anyone — like an extra in a movie, they die and they die, and no one cares. If you want me to let you go, you first need to make me care about you. Isn't that right?"

The bound man was taken aback.

"You're probably wondering — how do I get you to start caring about me? Well, I'd have to understand you first, empathize with you as a person."

The suited man laced his long fingers together, forming something like a pale bridge in the dark of the night. The face of his watch caught a faint, thin arc of light in the darkness.

"Come then — tell me. Who are you?"

"I... my name is Ivan. I'm twenty-nine years old, I'm originally from—"

"No, I don't want a résumé — that's boring." The suited man cut him off, his tone encouraging. "I want to know: what hopes do you carry in your life? What has left you disappointed? What are your dreams?"

Ivan stared, his face streaked with blood and tears. "My... my dreams...?"

"Yes. Surely you don't plan to be Wellesley's bodyguard for the rest of your life?"

Ivan gave a start, and a flash of sudden comprehension lit up his eyes.

"Could this have something to do with Mr. Wellesley—"

"Furthermore," the suited man continued, deaf to the remark, "Wellesley died a violent death yesterday, and today you can barely save yourself — you weren't much of a bodyguard. No great loss giving it up."

"I don't know anything..."

"Don't waste your energy." The suited man's thin lips curved into a smile like a knife's edge. "A character who can't move me is just a sack of skin — I don't care how many pieces of it end up on the ocean floor."

Silence fell over the boat for a few seconds.

"Speak."

It probably never crossed Ivan's mind, not even in his wildest dreams, that he would find himself in a situation like this, baring his innermost thoughts.

"I... I understand. My dream is to become someone like Mr. Wellesley..."

"The wealthiest man in the city? A state senator? Recipient of the Distinguished Contribution Award on Climate Issues?" The suited man asked with a smile: "...Or the true power behind

Blackmoor City?"

Ivan only nodded without speaking. He stared vacantly at Blackmoor City in the distance — at the neon advertisements on shore, the skyscrapers. Across the central bay lit up by countless lights, dark waves gently lapped and rocked the small boat.

"Good." The suited man nodded. "What have you done to pursue that dream?"

"I haven't done anything," Ivan snapped back to attention and said quickly, "Mr. Wellesley's death has absolutely nothing to do with me..."

"Wrong direction." The pale hand waved through the darkness with the air of a director giving notes to an actor. "I didn't say you had anything to do with his death — but after he died, you took no action at all?"

"I don't understand..."

"With nothing but ambition and no action to back it up, a character that spineless is impossible to empathize with." The suited man seemed nearly exasperated. "If you won't even help yourself, why on earth should I let you off the hook?"

Ivan's bleeding mouth hung open. After a moment's hesitation, he finally ventured: "After Mr. Wellesley died... I didn't leave. I stayed. Does that count?"

"Oh?"

"Mr. Wellesley had dismissed me the night before," Ivan said quickly. "I was supposed to leave, but I didn't want to go, so I didn't tell anyone."

"Why did he dismiss you?"

"It was just bad luck." Ivan's wet, glistening lips went still. After a moment, he said quietly: "I hadn't done anything seriously wrong... I only tried on a pair of trousers..."

The suited man raised one eyebrow and the corner of his mouth. "Trousers?"

"Yes, yes... once you hear it, you'll understand." He paused, then said suddenly: "Do you know that Mr. Wellesley had a very soft voice? When I first started working for him, I was surprised — a man of such importance, I'd imagined he would speak loudly."

Ivan's teeth were stained blood-red, but he seemed to have forgotten his wound; once he started talking, he couldn't stop.

"Later I came to understand: because his voice was soft, everyone else had to give him their full attention when he spoke. When he opened his mouth, he wasn't concerned about whether others could hear him — that was the listener's problem to worry about.

"You see, even the way his voice rose and fell had its purpose, had its wisdom... So in my free time, I gradually began to carry myself the way Mr. Wellesley did, to dress the way he dressed. I even wore a cologne with a similar scent, and I felt like people looked at me differently when I went out."

The suited man held out a cigarette to Ivan.

He took a drag; in the murky darkness above the sea, the tip of the cigarette flared red; pain made his cheek twitch again, but his tone and composure steadied considerably.

"During this period, Mr. Wellesley and a number of us staff had all been staying at the estate in the Upper District. The night before last, he went to attend a banquet, while I was off duty and didn't go with him. When he came back unexpectedly early, I happened to be in his room putting on a pair of trousers, and he caught me right in the act.

"He probably thought I was having an affair in there... his face turned purple. But how could I possibly be doing something like that? He didn't believe me — he shoved me aside and went through the bathroom and dressing room from top to bottom before he was finally convinced I'd really been alone..."

Ivan gave a bitter laugh: "Then he noticed I was wearing his trousers. I only wanted to know what it felt like to wear them... but he flew into a rage and fired me on the spot, told me to pack my things and leave the next morning."

The suited man threw his head back and laughed, the sound deep and resonant, crashing against the night.

"Amusing — but that's all." His large hand patted the cauterizing gun. "You want to reach the pinnacle of wealth and power, and the action you took was secretly trying on someone's trousers? With that, what could you ever amount to?"

"It's not that simple, obviously,"

Ivan was stung into a flash of anger, and blood sprayed as he argued back.

"Dressing and carrying myself like him was only one part of it — I never let slip an opportunity for action either. The moment I heard yesterday that Mr. Wellesley had died in his

study, I immediately realized: word of my dismissal hadn't spread yet. Only Mr. Wellesley and I knew, and with him dead, as long as I said nothing, it was as if I'd never been dismissed — no one would ever know.

"So I rushed to the study door at the first chance. On the surface I was pretending to guard the scene while waiting for the police, but in reality I was secretly—"

Ivan suddenly stopped.

In the darkness, there was nothing left but the sound of waves and his own heavy, ragged breathing.

The suited man fixed his eyes on Ivan, slowly leaning his body forward, like a great python lowering itself inch by inch from a branch.

"So... you went inside the study." He said quietly.

Ivan seemed to realize it then — that when an interrogator conceals their true purpose, the person being interrogated ends up committing mistakes they didn't even know they shouldn't commit.

"...And what happened after you went in?"

Seeing that Ivan refused to answer, the suited man raised both hands. In the darkness between sky and sea, they looked like two vague, enormous white fans — each one large enough to cover an adult man's entire head and face.

"Strange, isn't it? I introduced you to all the first-aid supplies, yet I never showed you what I'll use to sever your arms and legs. That's because I only remembered when I got on the boat — I forgot to bring the electric saw. Fortunately, I have some confidence in the strength of my hands... nick an opening in the skin, and I can peel you apart layer by layer. The bones are easy enough — wedge them against the side of the boat and one stomp will snap them."

In the darkness, the suited man broke into a silent grin, his white teeth bared in even, gleaming rows.

"Why did you go into the study?"

This time Ivan answered quickly. "I — I just wanted to see if there was anything worth taking... in case there was something valuable. I saw a watch..."

"Why did you go into the study?" The suited man's hand came to rest lightly on Ivan's arm.

Ivan swallowed a mixture of blood and saliva.

"You likely know as well — what went missing from Wellesley's study does not belong to this world. Those who had no business touching it yet touched it anyway will only end up as you are now: swept under and swallowed by the fate it carries. An endless sea with nowhere to turn."

The suited man closed his eyes, drew a long, slow breath through his nose, pulling in the salt-smell of the sea, the petrol fumes from the boat's engine, and Ivan's fear — all of it drawn deep into his lungs.

When he spoke again, his voice had gone hoarse.

"The Artifact from the study — where have you hidden it?"

The mega-ordeal begins today... Yesterday, the moment I landed, I got a text saying my connecting flight had been cancelled, so I scrambled to refund and rebook—only to find no flights available, leaving me no choice but to travel to Guangzhou today to catch a flight out. A huge detour added for no reason, and a huge chunk of time lost.

The days ahead are going to be stressful, chaotic, and miserable. Adjust for jet lag? What a luxury that would be—a blink counts as sleep at this point.

Ugh.

All I want is to go home and hole up for a solid year, ideally with a new e-ink tablet in my arms.

Chapter 15: Chase, Hunter Among Men

Chase drew a silver comb from his suit pocket and slowly combed a loose strand of hair back behind his head.

The comb was small, its inlaid emeralds casting a deep, crystalline light that sank into the black hair and shattered between the strands.

Luxurious and precious things exist in this world to be used. Chase would never lock a comb away in a jewelry cabinet just because it was a valuable antique.

"I stripped his clothes off with my own hands."

Chase leaned back in his chair and said, "I don't mind finding a new use for the cauterizing gun, but Dr. Nate was afraid I'd be too rough and puncture his intestines, so he handled the search himself. I watched the whole time—I can confirm there was nothing on that bodyguard."

Rolan Kay, sitting across from him, made a low sound of acknowledgment.

He was past sixty, his hair faded to iron gray, like the heavy fog of a cloudy morning. Wrinkles carved out a hard face with few expressions, and his pair of pale blue eyes always seemed to be watching people from a great distance, as if peering through deep mist.

In his presence, Chase sometimes still felt like a small child.

"What about his home?"

"I only got back from his place this morning—there isn't a single unbroken tile left." Chase thought for a few seconds and continued, "I searched the car too. Nothing. I also checked the driving records and surveillance footage—after he left the estate, he drove straight home and didn't go out again before I found him. Aside from a pizza delivery driver, he hadn't met with anyone. If he hid the Artifacts at the estate—"

"Not a single one left at the estate," Rolan Kay said quietly. "The newly arrived Hunters have already scanned it."

Chase nodded, his thick dark brows knitting together.

"Out of the four Artifacts that went missing from Wellesley's study, the bodyguard didn't take a single one?" Rolan Kay asked.

Chase stared at the ceiling and thought for a moment.

"No," he murmured, "he got one... he got at least one."

"How do you know?"

Chase straightened up, a hint of irritation in his movement, his two large pale hands clasped tightly together, tendons rising on the backs. A thin line of dark reddish-black stain still lingered in the creases of his fingernails—he hadn't yet had the chance to clean them.

"I searched every place I could think of to hide something, and there were no Artifacts anywhere. The man couldn't take pressure—all it took was one broken left arm and he was already begging me to search his home, his car. He didn't even wait for me to ask before giving me the address of his sister's place outside the city."

He pulled out a few banknotes, folded them into two stacks, rolled them up, and used their sharp corners to slowly clean out the stains from his fingernails.

"My search was thorough—I'm confident I missed nothing. But as I watched him on the boat, a feeling gradually took hold of me... I can't explain it, but I just knew." Chase stared at the dark reddish-black on the corner of the banknote and said, "He got an Artifact."

Ivan had been terrified and in agony, willing to do anything to escape the small boat and escape Chase—and yet there was something... something indescribable, like bone itself, that held up the man who was weeping and convulsing and howling, and made him grit his teeth and keep the secret.

Someone who had seen another world seemed to gain a certain distance from the reality before their eyes. Even bodily pain, at first, felt as though it were filtered through a layer of cotton.

This was a feeling Chase had encountered before, in Hunters who had just returned from the Nest.

Ivan was not a Hunter; he had only come into contact with another reality through an Artifact, and so carried only a faint, vague trace of that same quality.

But on his own, he wouldn't have been able to hold out for much longer.

The moment Chase thought of this, his hands wrenched together with a sharp, restless twist.

No matter how precious an Artifact, it could not be worth more than life and limb; even a rare Artifact capable of granting someone supreme wealth and status would not be worth

becoming a human torso.

In the deep of the previous night, Ivan had sat naked in a pool of blood, shaking violently in the cold sea wind, his arm snapped in several places and dislocated at the shoulder where a bloody hole had torn open, hanging a full length longer than his right arm.

Looking at him, Chase had known that even without resorting to real measures, the man was not far from his breaking point.

By any standard, Ivan was not a man of iron will.

A few more minutes, and he would have talked—but it was exactly at that moment that a light suddenly pierced the pitch-black curtain of night over the distant sea; the roar of a large speedboat's engine carved through the waves, pushing its light steadily into Chase's field of vision.

Dr. Nate snapped his head up and said under his breath, "Is that the—the Coast Guard?"

From what Chase knew, the Coast Guard didn't usually appear in this location at this hour, but out of caution he still dropped the bloodstained dumbbell plate he was holding; it landed with a heavy thud, making the hull shudder faintly.

"Get down," he ordered the bodyguard, then said, "Doctor, hand me the cover cloth under the seat."

The cloth normally used to cover the boat was thrown over Ivan hood-first, concealing pale flesh and dark crimson blood all at once.

Chase stepped over the trembling, rustling cloth in one stride, took a can of beer from the liquor cabinet, tossed it to Dr. Nate, and said, "Drink."

The crisp crack of the pull-tab was swallowed up by the engine sound growing ever closer; Chase could already make out, faintly, that the approaching vessel was a large speedboat very much resembling standard Coast Guard craft—by the look of it, within a few minutes it would come crashing through the waves and pass right in front of them.

"Great, the taxes I pay, coming to get in my way."

Chase muttered as he sat down and picked up a fishing rod from the boat, not even casting the line into the water.

That night the clouds were thick and formless, with no stars or moon to be seen, and visibility on the sea was extremely poor—a few meters out and one's gaze seemed to tumble into a black

void.

If the other vessel didn't shine a searchlight on them, they wouldn't be able to tell how many people were on the boat, let alone spot a fishing line; the cloth, the beer, and the fishing rod were prepared purely as a precaution.

Boats out night-fishing at two or three in the morning were rare enough, but the central bay was never short of private pleasure craft, and the Coast Guard seemed to have a different target altogether—it plowed straight past them without the slightest interest in Chase's small boat, not even slowing down.

The large speedboat racing past threw up wave after wave, tossing the small boat up and flinging it back down, again and again—and in the midst of the rocking, Chase suddenly cursed under his breath, leapt to his feet, and lunged toward the cover cloth.

He lost his footing and slammed into the railing from the pitching of the boat, but he seemed to feel nothing of it; he swept out an arm, and a large hand with long fingers closed around the cloth.

"What's wrong?"

Amid Dr. Nate's startled cry and the crash of waves against the hull, Chase pressed down on the cloth that was heaving and shifting beneath him, and closed his fist around it—Chase was confident in his grip; if he locked his hand around someone, they couldn't get free unless they pulled a gecko and shed a limb.

And yet Ivan had slipped away all the same.

At the time the whole thing happened so quickly that it was only afterward, thinking it over, that Chase was able to piece together how Ivan had escaped.

Taking advantage of the boat's pitching in the waves, Ivan had crawled from under the cloth toward the railing, trying to jump overboard while Chase was distracted; Chase had noticed in time, lunged over, and grabbed him, yanking him back—but in the rocking of the waves, with the cloth between them, Chase hadn't anticipated that what he'd grabbed was the very arm he himself had broken and torn open.

As the bodyguard's shoulder was wrenched by that pull, the wound that had just been cauterized and sealed tore open again, deeply; a long cry of agony rang out from beside the railing, piercing sharply into the night.

Along with that cry, a gush of fresh blood poured from the body.

The pain was unbearable, but it was precisely the flood of blood that acted as lubrication—and so Ivan finally managed, in a sway of the waves, to wrench out his broken arm by sheer force and roll overboard off the small boat. All of this happened in the span of two or three seconds; but by the time Chase rushed to the railing and swept his gaze around, the bodyguard had already sunk below the surface and was nowhere to be seen.

The night was dark and the sea was vast; even with a flashlight, one could only see a few meters of churning water.

Though the bodyguard was dragging an injured arm, if he held his breath and swam underwater for a while, moving beyond Chase's range of visibility was not difficult.

"He thought he could swim back to Blackmoor City with an injured, bleeding arm?"

Chase tried to smile, but found the muscles of his face too heavy to move. "He most likely died in the central bay long ago—who knows where the current will carry him. I'll keep an eye out over the next few days for any reports of a body being found."

"You're going to wait for news of a dead man before you know how to proceed?" Rolan Kay smiled slightly and asked.

"No... of course not, Uncle Kay."

Chase couldn't help it—even his voice dropped lower. "I'm planning to go find his sister, and the pizza delivery clerk."

Rolan Kay, however, seemed to have no interest in his next steps. He took a sip of black coffee and said, "Anything left in plain sight for you to see isn't where something is hidden."

Chase made himself swallow those words.

He had nothing to say to that.

Before Ivan had jumped off the boat, Chase had already gotten hold of his keys, phone, documents, and even important passwords—all that had escaped was a bare body. In principle, even if the bodyguard had gotten away, as long as he'd hidden things somewhere he'd been, Chase should sooner or later be able to find a lead.

But Chase had searched every inch of every hiding place he could think of, and had still come up empty.

Just where had he missed?

Chase's hands had been unconsciously twisting and grinding against each other all this while; only now did he notice that the banknotes he'd used to clean his fingernails had been reduced to a scatter of fine shreds, drifting down into the carpet—he felt a sudden flush of embarrassment.

"Uncle Kay, let me get the vacuum. Is the handheld one still in the usual spot?"

He had barely risen to his feet when Rolan Kay said, "No rush. Sit down."

Though puzzled, Chase sat back down.

"Force cuts both ways," Rolan Kay said slowly. "The full weight of a punch thrown at someone else inevitably reverberates back into one's own bones and heart. That's why interrogators who use violence either start out numb and dull, or gradually become numb and dull through violence."

A warm, tingling sensation spread from his palms to his chest.

"I'll be careful, Uncle Kay," Chase said, with genuine gratitude. "It's just blood. I can handle it."

"That's not what I mean."

Chase's heart suddenly sank. He waited for what Rolan Kay would say next, the way one waits for a punch that is about to land in the gut.

"A numb, brutal enforcer is the most worthless thing in this business," Rolan Kay said. "You grew up at my side. I thought you would conduct yourself with more intelligence than this."

It was only after a brief moment that Chase's breathing returned to normal.

"For a Hunter House Faction to grow, the Nest is merely the foundation. What truly matters is how we establish ourselves and act in the human world—how we build influence. A truly powerful Hunter House Faction holds dominion over the 'reality' that every one of us must live within."

Rolan Kay gave a low, slow chuckle from the back of his throat.

"...And yet dominating 'reality' cannot be achieved through violence and bloodshed alone. Don't tell me that's the only card you have."

Chase hadn't known his own head could feel so heavy; for a moment he wanted nothing more than to drop it into his hands—and it wasn't because he hadn't slept all night.

He knew that Rolan Kay had not grown angry, but he would have preferred the man to lose his temper—to question him, scold him for failing to get things done.

Chase stood a full head taller than Rolan Kay now, trained and formidable, a man even Hunters were wary of. And yet when Rolan Kay was disappointed in him, Chase still felt that drowning sensation of sinking into ice water—because he could not stop being disappointed in himself.

He stared at his own hands; faint white scars ran across the backs, extending until they disappeared behind his watch and cuffs.

In his youth, trying to locate his own passage, Chase had run many experiments on himself and left all manner of scars and hidden injuries on his body.

Only 1% of humanity possessed a "passage"—a channel through which they could enter the Nest; but no one knew what their own passage was until they tried every method one by one. He had tried every known method of opening a passage, yet still stood in the mortal world, unable to see the Nest.

Now he was thirty years old, and he still could not forget the moment when Uncle Kay finally accepted the truth that he had no passage—the way he had lowered his eyelids and said nothing.

Like watching a work of art shatter on the ground, revealing the foam padding inside.

The scar on the back of his hand was not from the experiments. It was from after the experiments—Chase had cut it himself with a hunting knife, and he didn't know why; perhaps he had believed, in that moment, that he could cut open a passage that way.

"I understand." Chase said it, then noticed his voice had gone hoarse, and cleared his throat. "Uncle Kay, I made you a promise—everything on this side of the world, I will deliver to you."

He could not enter the Nest, but he could become a Hunter in the mortal world, seizing every scrap of power and wealth that could be taken and bringing it into the Kay family's hands.

Because what Uncle Kay truly wanted, he could never give him.

Chapter 16 — Chase and the Artifact Submerged in the Metropolis

"According to the surveillance footage we obtained,"

Chase said as he drove, "Ivan left the gates of the Wellesley Family Estate at 7:21 a.m. on November 16th, and never looked back."

The bodyguard naturally had no intention of going back; the moment he'd stolen the Artifact, he put his job out of his mind without a word to anyone and headed straight for Blackmoor City.

"What about his movements after leaving the estate? How do you pin those down?" The young woman in the passenger seat wore her hair in long, thick dreadlocks dyed a deep violet, and when they fell over her shoulders, they looked like a great cascade of flowing lavender.

"His GPS records are in my hands. The route we're driving right now is the same one he took on the 16th."

The young woman paused at that and glanced over at him.

"I know," Chase said, his expression unchanged. "The fact that a route is logged in his GPS doesn't mean he actually drove it."

"Right — I've heard you'd need to pull the route data from the manufacturer to know exactly where he went," the dreadlocked woman replied. "That'd be hard to manage without police resources, wouldn't it?"

Generally speaking, that was true.

But Chase had always had good luck.

He quickly discovered that a grocery store sat across from Ivan's apartment building — since people lived on the second floor, the owner had installed a smart security camera out front that recorded all comings and goings.

Posing as a police officer, he smoothly pulled up the time window he needed: at 10:47 a.m., Ivan's car had turned onto the street, circled for a bit, and snagged a parking spot.

That day was a Saturday, with no rush-hour traffic. Ivan had taken 3 hours and 26 minutes to get from the Upstate District to Blackmoor City — only thirteen minutes more than the GPS

estimate. Given the overcast, rainy weather, a discrepancy of a few minutes was not significant at all and fell entirely within the normal range.

"If he'd taken a different route, the timing wouldn't have lined up so neatly."

Every other GPS route would have added at least twenty minutes, making the timeline impossible; and besides, Ivan had been fleeing with the Artifact — by all logic, he'd want to move as fast as possible and wouldn't take the long way around.

This meant the possibility that Ivan had made a detour en route — to his sister's place, for instance, or a rented storage unit — and handed the Artifact off to someone else for safekeeping was virtually nonexistent, because a few minutes' discrepancy simply wasn't enough time for any of that.

But what if Ivan had called ahead and asked his sister to wait for him somewhere?

As he drove past, all it would take was passing a package through the window — a delay so small it would never show up in the driving record.

That theory, however, was quickly dismantled by Chase himself.

He had everything of Ivan's in his possession, and he easily pulled the call records from the carrier, finding that Ivan hadn't made a single outgoing call that morning, and hadn't been in contact with his sister in the days before or after, either — in fact, Ivan's entire call log for the 16th contained only two entries: the first was a call from the head of the bodyguard team, demanding to know why he had quit without authorization; the second was a call that afternoon to a pizza place, ordering one large pepperoni pizza.

Surely no one would hand over a priceless Artifact to a complete stranger making a delivery.

If the two knew each other, that would be one thing; but according to the Hunter sent to investigate, the delivery driver had no connection to Ivan whatsoever.

It was possible he had used someone else's phone — there was just no evidence to support that at the moment — and Ivan didn't seem like the kind of man capable of thinking that far ahead.

Regardless, Chase still had to exhaust every possibility.

He had to bring back what Uncle Kai wanted for the House Faction; before that single objective, no obstacle could be allowed to remain one.

"Mr. Monroe, I have a question—" the young dreadlocked woman began.

"Just call me Chase," he cut her off. "When other Hunters call me Mr. Monroe, it means they know they're in trouble."

Kingsley had not been with the House Faction long — she'd previously been an unremarkable Hunter of no particular renown — but recently her reputation had suddenly soared and she'd become a sought-after talent. Since she'd been recruited into the Kay household, today was the first time Chase had actually met her in person.

As far as Chase knew, this kind of transformation in a Hunter wasn't all that unusual.

The Nest took on a thousand forms, strange and fantastical beyond all imagination; aside from the Artifacts that could be brought back into the world, Hunters might encounter creatures, rules, domains, or things that defied all definition — their interactions with such things produced no telling how many kinds of consequences and effects. Not all of them, of course, were good.

The vast majority were not good.

But occasionally, a lucky soul like Kingsley would draw the winning lot — returning from the Nest one day in possession of abilities she'd never had before.

"Chase," she corrected herself, then said: "I swept the Wellesley Family Estate. I can confirm there isn't a single Artifact left inside or outside the grounds. All along the road we drove in on, I didn't sense any Artifact presence either. That supports the idea that the bodyguard took the Artifact and carried it straight to Blackmoor City without stopping — that part is still easy enough to follow.

"But why did he lock himself in his apartment after he got home? If he went to the trouble of stealing an Artifact, he must have understood what it meant and what it was worth — he'd know people would track him down. If it were me, I'd go home, grab what I needed, and run — actually, I might not even go home at all. I'd leave everything behind."

Before answering, Chase lifted his chin toward the window.

Outside, a heavy, overcast sky hung there grey and sullen, brooding with the constant threat of rain; beneath it, a dull, dark-green blur of trees streamed steadily past.

"Well? Are you getting anything?"

Kingsley furrowed her brow, paused for two seconds, then said, "It overlaps quite a bit with my last detection range... still no Artifact."

Chase glanced at the time and said nothing.

He had no idea what method Kingsley used to sense things.

For a Hunter, the ability to "detect Artifacts" was fundamental and invaluable — but the problem was that Kingsley's detection precision was truly terrible.

He had been driving at fifty kilometers an hour for several minutes, and they still hadn't left the range of Kingsley's last sweep.

By rough calculation, her Artifact detection range was about a five-kilometer radius — as for exactly where within that five-kilometer radius an Artifact might be hiding, only heaven knew.

With a sensing method this vague, was she really a prize worth poaching for a Hunter House Faction?

Chase had never set eyes on the Nest himself, so he didn't know the answer to that question.

"That Ivan — he had a bit of cunning about him."

He pulled his thoughts back to the present, fixed his gaze on the road ahead, and said: "He knew people would track the Artifacts that went missing from the study, so he gambled against fate — he bet he could slip through the cracks."

"Slip through the cracks?"

"If Wellesley's former bodyguard fled the moment he died, everyone would have known immediately that something was wrong with him. Never mind that no one even knows yet whether Wellesley's death was natural or not. If it was murder, running would tie Ivan to it as well.

"If Wellesley was murdered, a fleeing Ivan would draw the attention of three different parties.

"First, the police investigating the cause of death; second, whoever killed Wellesley, who wouldn't want any loose ends discovered; and third, the various Hunter House Factions suspecting he'd stolen the Artifacts."

Kingsley nodded. "That makes sense... he'd be better off acting like he didn't know anything. Even if he planned to run, he should at least lay low through the first few days and not attract attention."

"Exactly. He couldn't stay at the estate, because the estate would be the first place anyone searched for Artifacts. Wellesley had fired Ivan before he died — as long as he used that as his excuse, he had a reason to leave. And since four Artifacts went missing, and he'd likely only taken one, if he kept a low profile, there was no guarantee anyone would come looking for him specifically."

"So how did you find him?" Kingsley asked with genuine interest.

"...I got lucky."

"Lucky? I don't believe in luck," Kingsley said, looking at the road ahead with a smile.

"Everything I have, I earned for myself."

What a young thing to say.

The Nest was not a primary school teacher; the Nest did not reward sheer effort — but Chase kept those words to himself.

"Is that so? Then I suppose you wouldn't care about what the other Hunters say about me."

"What do they say?"

"That the reason I have such good luck is that I draw the good luck away from the people around me."

Kingsley probably thought he was joking and started to laugh, glancing over at Chase as she did — then, like a cloud shadow passing overhead, her smile dimmed and faded quickly, leaving her quiet.

Anyone who became a Hunter had sharper instincts than the average person, to some degree or another.

Following the GPS route, Chase exited the highway and entered Blackmoor City proper.

A forest of modern towers built from glass and steel, classical buildings that had stood and settled over centuries past, neon advertisements layering light and shadow over one another, office workers striding briskly down the streets, tourists perched atop red double-decker sightseeing buses with their phones held aloft — like pieces of a puzzle, it all gradually assembled before his eyes into the most prosperous, vibrant, and diverse metropolis in the world.

Chase had lived in Blackmoor City for thirty years, yet everything he'd learned about it probably didn't amount to the tip of the iceberg; accompanying its vast and endlessly varied

population was an unknowable quality — the sense that no one could predict what the next moment might bring. Chase had never wanted to leave Blackmoor City, and beyond his ties to the Kay household, it was because he needed that unknowability, the way he needed air.

If every day of his life were the same as the last, he would be as good as dead already, just waiting to be buried.

To minimize distractions, Kingsley closed her eyes and rolled down the window, as though listening to the pulse of the city.

"Nothing... nothing... up ahead is Buluan 5th Street?... nothing there either."

"Are you sure?"

Kingsley's eyes snapped open. "Wait!"

Chase lifted his foot off the accelerator. The moment the car slowed, a wave of irritated honking erupted from the line of vehicles behind them.

Blackmoor City residents were not known for their patience or their courtesy.

"Got one!" Kingsley's eyes went wide as she twisted her head left and right, scanning around — yet a shadow of puzzlement wouldn't leave her face. "Hold on, let me just—"

"Where?"

Kingsley seemed not to hear him. She craned her head out the window, held still for a few blank seconds, then dropped back into her seat with a thud.

"It's gone," she said quietly. "I thought there was an Artifact nearby... but it's strange — the feeling flashed past, and by the time I focused and tried to sense it again, it had vanished. I swear my instincts are usually spot-on; I've never run into anything like this before..."

Flashed past?

The car crawled along, and the honking and shouting from behind had been completely shut out of Chase's mind.

His attention spread outward like a searchlight sweeping in all directions: the road, the streets, the buildings, the pedestrians, the signs — scenes he had passed by countless times before all registered in his mind one by one, sharp and vivid, as though he were seeing them for the very first time.

An Artifact that "flashed past" within a range this large — a full five-kilometer radius...

His eyelids gave a sudden twitch, and his gaze landed on a round sign in the distance bearing the letter "D."

A thought occurred to Chase.

He looked over at the oncoming lane, waited for a gap with no approaching cars, then gave the steering wheel a sharp turn, cut across half the road, and swung onto the other lane.

Amid the shriek of brakes, blaring horns, and furious curses, he pressed down on the center of the steering wheel and leaned on it without letting up, while the car had already mounted the sidewalk; the pedestrians who scattered to either side in fright were like waves the car had thrown up in its wake.

Kingsley gripped the overhead handle with both hands and cried out, "What are you doing? Where are you going? You're going to hit someone!"

With one set of tires on the curb and the other on the road, the car tilted forward at an angle; they tore past a row of storefronts, startling a customer who had just stepped out and sending coffee splashing all over him.

The chaos and commotion outside the car meant nothing to Chase.

He kept his eyes fixed ahead and said, "I know where the Artifact is."

Friends, yesterday I got up early in the morning and headed out to take care of some things — I even sent the chapter from the car. Chapter numbers, author's notes, none of that was on my mind; I just needed to get the food on the table first, and if I remember the cutlery later I'll bring that too. For now just eat with your hands, we've been at this long enough, we make do.

As for what I'm doing today — as I write this, I'm once again on my way to the airport. If you went to the headquarters of every major airline right now, you'd find my portrait hanging there. Seriously, go look if you don't believe me.

As for writing author's notes, I have mixed feelings — I can't bring myself to leave out all this pointless rambling, but whenever I do write them, I always end up seeing comments saying the notes are better than the actual chapters, and honestly I don't know whether to be happy about that. Maybe after the novel goes on the paid roster I'll just post nonsense — sound about right?

Chapter 17 — Chase: The Hunted Hunter

Ivan was either a genius or an idiot.

No, Chase thought, perhaps he was a mixture of both; they say that when an idiot has a flash of brilliance, even the smart ones can't compete.

"Are you trying to get yourself killed? Don't drag me into it!" Kingsley forgot to be polite to her superior in her panic and cried out, "This isn't the Nest — this is the real world! There are consequences for driving like this. You hit someone, you go to prison — do you not hear the sirens behind us?"

It had only been a few minutes since he'd blown through a string of traffic laws before he heard the sirens.

The wail of sirens carved through the sky behind them like circling knife-tips, slicing again and again; sometimes growing more distant, making Chase think he'd shaken the last patrol car, only for them to close in again as new ones joined the chase from other directions.

But the patrol cars never managed to cut him off, because they couldn't do what Chase did — tear across sidewalks, drive the wrong way through red lights, and blast through intersections as if the road were empty.

Along the way, he lost count of how many pedestrians he saw throwing themselves to the side of the road in frantic panic, and lost count of how many times he heard the sharp screech of tires grinding against asphalt.

Wherever the car went, chaos followed — running, honking, screaming; and by some miracle, by the time Chase finally straightened out and roared down the open road, he had only knocked a side mirror askew and caved in one headlight, without causing any truly irreversible damage.

"Hold on," he said, glancing back at the vast sweep of flashing red and blue lights behind them. "I'm going to accelerate."

"More? You—"

Kingsley didn't get to finish — the car surged forward and the force of inertia drove her back into her seat.

Chase spun the wheel; the car twisted around the vehicle ahead, then cut sharply in front of it, drawing a chorus of furious honks. "The search I had you run earlier — you still have it open, right?"

Kingsley let out a sigh and brushed her lavender hair back from her face.

"It's open," she said, holding her phone up into the edge of Chase's vision; the screen was indeed lit up with a map app. "Fine — it's not like I'm the one driving. Where exactly are we going?"

"Buluan Community College," Chase answered briefly, blasting between two more cars.

"...Why?"

"When you sensed the Artifact flash by, I caught a glimpse of the subway sign for 'Fullington Station' on Line D. Buluan Community College is the terminal station for Line D in that direction."

Kingsley absorbed this, blinking several times in quick succession.

"Wait — you're saying you think that bodyguard hid the Artifact at Buluan Community College Station?"

"No," Chase said. "I think he hid the Artifact on the subway."

Kingsley's jaw dropped. Two seconds passed before she pulled it back up. "The subway? Blackmoor City's subway? You — he — is he out of his mind?"

Somehow, she had the feeling that what she'd originally meant to say was something more like "are you serious."

Blackmoor City's subway could be called world-famous — just not for being busy or crowded.

Beyond ordinary commuters and tourists, the cars were always filled with cult members recruiting followers, vendors selling fake newspapers, people announcing the deaths of public figures who were still very much alive, prophets warning of the coming apocalypse, performers changing clothes in public to beg for money — an endless parade of strange and colorful characters.

People often said that to tell whether someone was a true Blackmoor City native, all you had to do was watch them on the subway — if they could sit there, completely unfazed, from the moment they boarded to the moment they got off, then they were the real thing.

Anyone's first instinct, if they needed to hide something, would not be to hide it in a place like that.

And besides — once the subway pulled away, how would Ivan ever retrieve it?

"There's a lot I don't understand," Kingsley said, thinking it through. "Ivan stopped the car on his way into Blackmoor City, went into the subway station, and came back out quickly — that part makes sense, and he would have had time for it. But how do you know he hid it on the subway?"

"You said the Artifact 'flashed by,' right? If your detection method is really as reliable as you say, then it means that at the moment you sensed it, it was at the very edge of your detection range, moving forward at high speed, and left your range an instant later.

"In other words, before you began detecting, it had already been traveling through your detection range at a certain speed for some period of time — that's exactly why, at the moment you started detecting, it happened to be right at the edge of your range, and ultimately 'flashed by' like that."

Her detection range was enormous. Pedestrians, bicycles, even cars moving at city speed limits — if they weren't moving fast enough, they couldn't leave her detection range in any short span of time.

Based on the picture they'd pieced together so far, Ivan had not been in contact with anyone; and within the city, what could travel continuously at high speed without being restricted by traffic, carrying the Artifact out of Kingsley's detection range?

When Chase's gaze had landed on the "D" sign, it came back to him: Fullington Station was right nearby.

While they'd been searching without finding anything, deep beneath their feet, a subway train had been thundering off into the distance — with the Artifact on board.

The possibility that another Artifact had simply happened to appear along Ivan's route was something neither of them had stopped to consider — "possibility" and "probability" are two entirely different concepts. Even with any number of Hunters tirelessly trying to carry Artifacts out into the world, the total number of Artifacts in existence remained very small.

Kingsley glanced back at the cluster of patrol cars refusing to give up the chase, and resigned herself to her fate. She gripped the overhead handle and said, "No wonder you cut across the

streets and didn't hesitate to drive against traffic and over the speed limit — you're racing the subway, and just taking a regular shortcut probably wouldn't be enough. Though this is genuinely terrifying. If I don't die in the Nest but end up dying in a car crash, that would really be too ironic."

Chase didn't respond to that. He glanced at the time and said, "When you detected the Artifact, it was around 10:03."

He had an obsessive habit — no matter the situation, he had to know the time, and it had to be precise to the minute.

The habit had held for over twenty years; now, even without checking his watch, his internal clock was nearly flawless. Before he'd even looked, he already knew it was 10:13 — he had been speeding through the pursuit and blockades of patrol cars for nearly ten minutes.

Ahead of him, there were still any number of red lights waiting. Every one of them was a choice: stop and get caught by the police? Run it, and get split in two by oncoming traffic?

He needed to think of something — how to carve an empty road out of Blackmoor City's sea of traffic?

Chase asked, "What's the current interval between trains on Line D?"

Kingsley glanced at the map app on her phone. "Seven minutes," she answered.

"Check your navigation — how many minutes until the next train departs from Fullington Station? And how long does it take to reach the terminal?"

"The next train departs in two minutes. It takes thirty-five minutes to reach the terminal."

As Kingsley said this, she caught on as well, her eyes gradually lighting up. "Ah — the train with the Artifact on it will reach the terminal station at 10:36! We just need to get to the platform before 36 minutes past."

People who could treat "entering the Nest to hunt" as a career rather than a final hobby before death were never slow on the uptake.

If the next train departed at 10:15, then the ones before it had left at 10:08 and 10:01 respectively. When Kingsley had started detecting at 10:03, the subway that had left at 10:01 was just about to leave her detection range; by the time it traveled from Fullington Station to the terminal, it would be exactly 10:36.

"But I still have one question," Kingsley said, frowning. "How do you know that subway was heading toward Buluan Community College Station and not going the other direction?"

"I don't," Chase said.

Kingsley's head snapped toward him and she stared.

"I only know one thing," Chase said — he was more patient with Hunters from his own House Faction than with anyone else, and he explained: "When you go down into Fullington Station, the platform on the first underground level is the one heading toward Buluan Community College Station. The second underground level is the one going in the opposite direction."

"Oh," Kingsley's frown relaxed and she nodded. "So you're betting that the bodyguard just got on the nearest available train. That tracks — he only took thirteen minutes more than the GPS-estimated route; factor in the time to park, get out of the car, and wait for the train, and it means he didn't linger in the station at all. He was in and out."

Ivan only needed to ride one stop — once he'd hidden the Artifact, he could get off at the next station and, without even waiting, cross the platform and catch the subway going the other way.

"Still, to know a random subway station has two platform levels," Kingsley remarked, "you must have been born in Blackmoor City. You know this place so well."

Chase didn't answer. He simply said, "Make a call. Report it to the police."

Kingsley blinked twice, unable to help glancing back at the patrol cars behind them. One had gotten very close; the spinning flicker of its lights cast blue and red across the rear window glass.

"We're not short on police," she pointed out.

"Don't waste time." Chase kept his foot steady on the gas, continuing toward the intersection ahead where the light was red. "Call it in — tell them you're on a speeding car, and have them seal off the area from Columbia Avenue and East 106th Street to Cherry Street within ten minutes."

"You're the boss either way." She muttered as she opened the dialer.

Kingsley had barely finished pressing the three digits when her eyes yanked away from the screen — from the road on their right, a large truck had just crossed through the intersection and was now rumbling toward them, on a direct collision course to slam into the black Mercedes broadside.

"The truck—"

Chase didn't brake — he accelerated, flooring the gas pedal level with the floor, and the engine let out what sounded almost like a cry of desperation as the car shot straight ahead at breakneck speed.

Kingsley's involuntary scream filled and echoed through the cabin, then was swallowed by the thunderous crash that struck the rear of the car — though only the corner of the tail end was clipped, the impact wrenched the entire vehicle hard to one side, nearly spinning it to a sideways stop in the middle of the intersection.

Two large hands wrenched the steering wheel hard over, and amid the shuddering groan of metal and engine, the car broke free of the intersection and pulled out onto the road ahead; behind them, the truck slammed on its brakes and skidded diagonally across the road, and a chain of rear-ending cars piled up in an instant into a steel serpent, blocking the pursuing patrol cars on the other side.

"I joined the Hunter House Faction for more security," Kingsley cried out, still reeling from the shock. "Not to put my life on the line at work! This isn't the Nest—"

"911," a woman's voice came from below the seat. "What is your emergency?"

"Hurry," Chase kept his foot on the gas, snapping his fingers in front of Kingsley. "We might not be so lucky at the next intersection."

"Hello — hello!" Kingsley scrambled to pick up her phone. "I'm in the car that's been barreling through the Buluan District!"

She rattled off Chase's instructions at speed, then paused, glanced at him, and said, "...You want to know who I am? Well, I've been — been kidnapped into this car. He's pointing a gun at me and making me make this call. He says if they don't block off the road... he'll throw a bomb into the traffic."

Chase shot her a sideways glance and broke into a grin, a flash of white teeth.

"I'd say it's been a pleasure working with you," he said quietly, after Kingsley hung up, "but our work together has only just begun."

My stockpile of chapters is almost gone after tomorrow, aaaaaahhh

And I've been running around like crazy these past few days and haven't had time to check who the new sponsors are — the bonus chapter debt is still at 7. Well, as long as I don't look, it stays at 7... No, I mean, I will definitely write those bonus chapters. I promise.

Today is packed again — Qidian in the morning, errands in the afternoon, and then some unexpected last-minute event tonight that I absolutely cannot skip... I had no idea this thing was happening, and my suitcase only has jeans, sneakers, and T-shirts, so they might not even let me in the door — hey, if they don't let me in, doesn't that mean I get to come back and write? See, I'm such a responsible, work-minded person.

PS: Prices are going to be the death of me... Especially to my friends in Shanghai — how do you people survive? I was absolutely floored by the prices. I paced back and forth in front of a single bottle of mouthwash four times, like I was working up the nerve to propose to it. The store clerk was already staring at me before I finally steeled myself and grabbed it. A small bottle of mouthwash is like under ten yuan anywhere else, right?! What is Shanghai mouthwash made of — can you drink it after rinsing for beauty and wellness benefits or something?!

Chapter 18: Mai Minghe's Fourth Person

The exit of St. Louis Hospital (Nest version), according to the redhead, was inside the guardhouse outside the hospital building.

To get there, they had to go up to the first floor, cross the lobby, and walk out the main entrance—and the whole way, they'd have to avoid not only Residents, but also the redhead's companions; without someone to lead the way, it was a genuinely thorny problem.

Mai Minghe was grateful.

"Young man, what's your name?"

She smoothed the white sheet back into place—a habit she had kept for seventy or eighty years; even after climbing down from a mortuary slab, she still had to leave it neat—and sighed: "What a shame we don't know each other back in Blackmoor City. Otherwise, no matter what, I'd have knitted you a sweater and sent it over. Look at you—you didn't dress warmly enough today. It's November and you're still wearing short sleeves."

The redhead glanced at her as though she were the strangest thing in the entire Nest.

"...It's not like you're my great-aunt," he finally muttered after a long pause. "My name's Jonah. But I'd advise you, once you're back, to keep pretending we don't know each other. Don't let my House Faction find out about you."

She still had countless questions and very much hoped she could ask Jonah in a safe environment—but he was right; none of those questions were as important as the Artifact.

Questions about the Nest she could slowly tease out, bit by bit, in time.

"Let's go," Jonah said. "We reset, but it's still safer not to take the same route back."

As the two of them left, Mai Minghe switched off the light on her way out. In the instant before the light died, the body lying beneath the white sheet in the corner of the morgue swept across the edge of her vision one last time—and then was swallowed by the darkness.

The morgue door was heavy; left unbraced, it swung shut on its own, closing behind them with a heavy thud.

Mai Minghe followed behind Jonah, turning down the other end of the corridor, and for reasons she couldn't quite name, her mind felt hazy and unsettled.

Her thoughts kept drifting back to that silent, sheet-covered shape in the morgue—it struck her as a truly genuine corpse: no reaction when Jonah turned on the light, no reaction while the two of them talked, and no reaction when they left.

"Do they actually use the morgue to store real corpses?" Mai Minghe asked. "The moment I think about how we might have been lying right next to an actual dead body just now, my heart just—it gives me the creeps..."

"Hm?" Jonah answered absently. "Just now? A dead body?"

She swallowed back a sentence that had nearly slipped out, and raised her eyes to look at his back.

Jonah's red hair was cut very short; below the neat line of his hairline at the back, there was still a faint dusting of light-orange fuzz that hadn't been shaved clean, hovering like a mist across the nape of his neck.

Something stirred and settled uneasily in her chest, and she could hardly have said what she was thinking—she said vaguely: "Right... just now."

Jonah was quiet for a second or two.

In the rhythm of their footsteps, he said, "I don't know—maybe someone would do that. It is a morgue, after all."

Mai Minghe gave a low "mm" to show she'd heard.

She turned to look behind her; at her back stretched a straight corridor, leading to the staircase they had come down earlier.

If she turned and ran from here, she had nowhere to change direction—fleeing in a straight line, it would be very hard to shake off a pursuer... No, no, maybe she wouldn't need to run at all?

Maybe she was overthinking it?

Right—don't rush, think it through first, Mai Minghe told herself.

1. The morgue was a "reset" location: a person went in, lay down, and played dead; after enough time had passed, the hospital Residents would forget them.

2. Before they entered, someone was already lying in the morgue—or at least something person-shaped.

3. After they came out, Jonah had clearly forgotten that someone was still lying in the morgue.

Goosebumps rose in waves across the skin of Mai Minghe's thighs, every pore seeping cold.

Reasoning from these three known facts, there was only one conclusion to draw: Jonah was a Resident.

But that conclusion was absurd—he was plainly a flesh-and-blood living person, and he had saved her. She must have missed something; she needed to think it over again.

Jonah's pace was fast, and after following him at a brisk stride for a while, Mai Minghe found they had climbed up a staircase on the other side of the hospital and emerged onto the first floor, not far from the emergency room.

The hospital corridors and waiting areas were all brightly lit, but the nurses' station was completely empty.

Aside from the all-round emptiness, this place was an exact replica of the real human world. On the surface of the nurses' reception desk, there was even a paper cup—only without anyone to drink from it, as though the apocalypse had arrived without warning and humanity had abandoned the place.

Along the corridor they were in, there were several examination rooms; some doors were shut tight, others stood half-open, revealing a sliver of impenetrable dim darkness.

The whole way, there was nothing to be heard but their own footsteps and breathing. Jonah had chosen a very good route—not a single Resident encountered, every danger avoided.

"There's often something in the emergency room," Jonah crouched behind a wall, carefully peered out, surveyed the space for a moment, then said to Mai Minghe: "When we pass through, we have to stay absolutely silent."

Mai Minghe nodded, but a thought forced its way into her mind.

...But when they were playing dead, they hadn't needed to stay silent?

She genuinely knew nothing about the Nest or about "life gates," but thinking about it logically, she felt that when a person was pretending to be a corpse, they shouldn't be chatting and

laughing back and forth the way the two of them had just been doing.

A corpse—shouldn't it be like the figure lying in the corner... motionless, utterly silent, no matter what happened?

What if the person in the corner was a Hunter who was truly in the middle of resetting...

Then had she actually reset successfully?

Mai Minghe looked down at her fingertips.

As for how to verify whether Jonah was a Resident or a living person—when she thought carefully, she actually did have a way.

Although she had wiped most of the blood off onto the lanky patient earlier, a thin line of dark blood still remained deep under her fingernails, not entirely cleaned away.

Mai Minghe used the nail of another finger to work out a little of the dark red residue and held it between her fingertips. When Jonah stood up and said quietly, "Let's go," she immediately reached out and grabbed his arm, calling out: "Wait."

Fortunately, he was wearing short sleeves; the dark red blood on her fingers transferred cleanly onto Jonah's skin.

Nothing like the writhing and thrashing the lanky patient had shown happened at all.

"What is it?" Jonah half-bent, stepping back behind the wall. "Did you spot something?"

He looked a bit pale—but who could look rosy-cheeked in a situation like this; Mai Minghe suspected her own complexion was worse—yet apart from that, he seemed completely normal, no pain, no reaction, not even noticing that the round-headed one's blood had gotten on his arm.

It seemed he wasn't a Resident after all. Mai Minghe quietly breathed a sigh of relief.

There was probably some other explanation for what had happened in the morgue, even if she couldn't think of it at the moment—but she wasn't God; how could she possibly account for every single thing without a gap?

From now on, she'd just have to stay a little more careful and watchful.

"Say something."

"Mm... I was thinking," Mai Minghe, under his stare, needed an excuse, and hemmed and hawed: "Once we get out of here, isn't it going to be pretty dangerous? We should find some useful

weapons before we head out."

Jonah frowned, thinking it over. "We don't have much time. Who knows how long this corridor will stay safe? As long as we're fast enough—rush to the exit before danger closes in—weapons aren't strictly necessary."

It had only been meant as an excuse, but now that he put it that way, Mai Minghe genuinely felt that finding a weapon was necessary. In this life, no matter what you're doing, being prepared does no harm; a youngster like Jonah, brimming with confidence, was perfectly normal—but she couldn't just go along with his overconfidence.

"How about this—when we pass the nurses' station, I'll duck in and take a quick look around. It won't waste any time."

To leave the building they had to pass the nurses' reception desk anyway; if she went in one end and came out the other, it would only take a few glances.

Jonah wasn't thrilled, but he didn't argue.

"Then I'll come in with you," he tilted his chin in indication. "If there's nothing strange inside the nurses' station, it's actually safer than being out in the open—gives us some cover."

Decision made, the two immediately crouched low, moved lightly on their feet, and slipped out from behind the wall.

Scanning left and right as they went, they hurried toward the nurses' station—like two frantic beetles, four legs rustling and scraping across the floor—and slipped behind the partition of the nurses' station.

The nurses' reception desk was rectangular, with entrances on either side directly facing each other. Mai Minghe was perpetually afraid that the moment she looked up, a face would appear at the opposite entrance; so, almost compulsively, every few seconds she had to sweep a glance over before she felt at ease.

On the side facing the lobby were three nurses' workstations, fitted with computers, office chairs, telephones, and various odds and ends like folders and forms—if not for what she had just experienced, she could hardly believe this wasn't the real St. Louis Hospital.

How could there be phones and computers in the Nest? Who had brought all this in?

The letters on the keyboard had worn white, as though someone had genuinely typed on it for years; a small cactus—real or fake, she couldn't tell—sat grey and dusty in the corner of the desk.

For a moment she almost forgot her objective entirely, caught in the strange wonder of a TV viewer first setting foot on a film set—even the most mundane, unremarkable things, the duty roster and the ballpoint pen, seemed to take on a fresh novelty that made them worth a second look—but unfortunately, she couldn't find anything that might serve as a weapon.

Mai Minghe had just stretched out her hand, wanting to listen for a dial tone on the phone, when Jonah immediately stopped her.

"Don't touch anything that could make contact," he warned her in a breath. "There's no telling what it might attract."

He had probably been traumatized by her pressing the call bell four times in a row—his whole face read: "Have you learned nothing?"

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and thought for a few seconds.

"There's nothing here," Jonah crouched behind the workstation; that way, no one looking in from outside the nurses' station would see anyone inside. He pointed to the entrance on the other side and said, still in a whisper: "Let's go, don't waste any more time."

"Okay."

When Jonah crouched low and moved to the front of the entrance, he suddenly stopped and looked back at Mai Minghe. "What are you just standing there for? Come on."

Mai Minghe pulled out an office chair; the four wheels rolled and rumbled, breaking the quiet, and stopped in front of her.

She bent slightly forward, both hands pressed on the back of the chair, looking at the face across from her.

Jonah looked no older than thirty—as a grown adult, he had barely begun his journey in life. His eyes were a little red, his lips dry, his body carrying a faint shimmer of warm sweat—very human.

She didn't know the truth of it, but she couldn't help feeling sad. Like a conditioned reflex, she felt sad for a child so young, and sad for the mother who had raised him little by little.

"You go ahead," Mai Minghe said, her voice a little hoarse. "I'm not going with you."

Jonah furrowed his brow, stared at her for a moment, as if he thought she was talking nonsense.

But after two seconds, his brow relaxed.

"...You noticed something?" He no longer seemed to care about being seen—he straightened up beside the nurses' station entrance and flashed Mai Minghe a bright smile. "Tell me about it."

"Not counting the lanky patient who was already in the room,"

Mai Minghe said quietly: "After I pressed the bell four times, a nurse came—plus the pair of hands under the bed and the underground Resident controlling the round-headed one... that's three 'figures disguised as nurses' in total. The fourth one to enter the room was you."

Truth be told, I thought that after posting the Mai Minghe and Sydney Ginn sections, someone would definitely spot the foreshadowing about "the fourth person" and "the exit" — but nope! (In Sydney Ginn's section, it was mentioned that returning to Blackmoor City also goes through the passage.) So this round goes to me — anyone who goes back to leave a comment about it now doesn't count!

I suppose my dear readers took pity on me and let me have this one win — after all, I've had such a rough time lately, running around exhausted and stressed and irritable every single day... Ugh, I won't get into the unpleasant stuff.

My backlog is gone. Starting tomorrow I'll have to live by my wits and perform for you all on the spot (not really) — I opened the Artifact Report page and took one look: variety arts, miscellaneous rambling, stand-up comedy (not actually).

First I lured everyone in with a novel, and now that the stockpile's dry, I'm putting on a ballet called **Swan Lake: Wielding a Broadsword** to pay back what I owe my dear readers — is that okay? Quite the innovative scam operation we've got here.

Chapter 19: Mai Minghe's Reproductive Unit

Looking back on it now, Jonah had kept quite a close watch on her.

He would turn his head every so often to check whether Mai Minghe was keeping up, and whenever she hesitated or slowed down, he would urge her to keep moving. Even for someone genuinely warm-hearted, his concern for her safety seemed almost excessive—not only was he willing to forgo the Artifact, he was even ready to abandon his companions for her sake.

Of course, all of this reflection on Mai Minghe's part was hindsight.

"You're that sure about it?"

Jonah still kept his voice low—no longer a whisper exactly, but as though he didn't want anything else to hear him either.

"This is your first time in the Nest. How can you be so certain that ringing the bell would definitely bring a Resident out? What if one of them didn't go, or went but found they couldn't outcompete the others and simply didn't enter the room?"

"If I really am just a Hunter who got caught while trying to escape and was thrown into the ward, yet you're this suspicious of me, wouldn't you just be throwing away a valuable ally for nothing?"

"...So are you?" Mai Minghe asked quietly.

Jonah licked his dry lips, thought for a moment, and smiled.

"...No."

The word had barely left his mouth before Mai Minghe had already kicked a chair, sending it flying straight at him.

She didn't wait to see whether it connected—she spun around and ran immediately. A clang rang out, as though the chair had struck something hard, sending a heart-stopping echo through the empty, silent waiting hall.

It didn't sound like it had hit a human body, but Mai Minghe had no time to look back and find out. She burst out of the nurses' station, sprinted across the hall, and charged toward the

corridor she had come from—she remembered there were several examination rooms along it, their doors left ajar, and if she could dash into one and lock it, she might be able to hold Jonah off.

A sharp whistle pierced the air behind her, followed immediately by Jonah's voice: "Come!"

What was he calling?

Mai Minghe forced herself to pump her legs even faster, twisted around a corner, and plunged into the quiet corridor—strangely, not a single footstep sounded on the floor behind her, as though Jonah hadn't given chase at all.

She couldn't suppress her curiosity and shot a quick glance back over her shoulder.

The corridor was empty, pale light soaking into the desolate silence.

Jonah really hadn't come after her.

Never mind why he hadn't; she'd already run this far—even if he started chasing now, he probably couldn't catch up, could he?

Should she still duck into an examination room?

The question flashed through her mind, and she made her decision at once: yes.

She knew nothing about this St. Louis Hospital inside the Nest, and running around blindly might land her in any number of dangers. She had at least glanced into the examination rooms as she passed—they weren't entirely unfamiliar territory.

The door of the first examination room was firmly locked; she tried the handle and found it wouldn't turn, so she immediately ran toward the next room, whose door stood half-open—it was a heavy sliding door sheathed in a steel panel. The moment she got a clear look at it, she cursed under her breath and kept running.

Fortunately, the next examination room wasn't far, and its door hadn't been shut all the way either, leaving a gap; she gave it a quick push, only to find it wouldn't budge more than a fist's width, as though something was jamming it.

"Why didn't you go into that last room?" Jonah's voice asked.

Mai Minghe's heart skipped a beat.

She slowly raised her head and followed the sound, and there, wedged in the angle where the ceiling met the wall, she saw a human face hanging upside down.

Of course—Jonah had climbed the walls before. He had crawled along them to get here; no wonder she hadn't heard any footsteps.

Jonah's abdomen faced the ceiling, his hands and feet clinging firmly to the plastered wall like some enormous insect. She had no idea when he had gotten above her, nor how he was managing not to fall.

His neck bent downward, his eyeballs drooping, fixed on Mai Minghe with a wide expanse of white showing—Jonah at this moment reminded her of a certain kind of doll whose eyes open and close with gravity, the kind that always made her feel, whenever she held one, as though she were holding a living thing pretending to be lifeless.

She also understood now why the door wouldn't open.

One of Jonah's hands wasn't gripping the ceiling at all—it was thrust into the gap in the door, clamped firmly around one corner of the panel so she could neither push nor pull it.

"Don't be in such a hurry—just wait a little longer,"

Just as the question surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind, Jonah opened his mouth; his upper teeth, upside-down, flickered in and out between his lips. "My child is almost here. Reaching full maturity still depends on you."

What child?

Mai Minghe stepped back sharply from Jonah, then quickly cast a glance down the depth of the corridor.

What came around from behind the corner was a very small shadow. Had it not been crawling toward her with a faint rustling sound, Mai Minghe might never have thought it was alive.

At first glance it looked like a ball, or a crumpled plastic bag; but within a few seconds she could see it clearly—it was roughly the size of two fists, a wrinkled mass of pinkish flesh, and along both its sides, numerous slender legs were moving in rapid alternation, blurring into a smear of shadow.

What on earth was that thing?

The thought had barely crossed her mind when she felt a sudden chill on both her cheeks; two hands dropped down from the ceiling, fingers like iron claws, locking around her skull.

Mai Minghe jolted in fright and struggled with everything she had, fists pounding up against those arms again and again, each blow landing with a dull thud against hard muscle—but it didn't loosen the grip by a fraction. The two male hands pressed deep into her cheeks, seized her jaw, and forced her mouth open.

The wrinkled pink ball of flesh seemed to grow suddenly excited, crawling faster, several tentacle-like legs climbing up along her pajama pants.

Never before had she wished so badly to have a weapon in her hands—anything at all, even a length of pipe would do; but she had spent the first half of this night as a bedridden old woman, and aside from the clothes on her body, she was completely empty-handed.

"Don't be afraid," Jonah's voice soothed. "Look—am I not perfectly fine right now? As long as memory endures, a person isn't really dead. After I entered Jonah, his memories as 'Jonah' are still continuing, which means 'Jonah' is still alive... there's simply one more symbiote, that's all."

No wonder the round-headed one's blood had been useless against him—because the blood had been smeared on Jonah's body, not on the Resident's true self.

Mai Minghe flailed and swept her hands frantically across herself, trying to knock the thing off, but the flesh-ball moved like a nimble cockroach—its legs scuttling lightly and swiftly, darting away from her palms again and again, pressing ever forward toward her head.

"You could try covering your mouth the way Jonah did at the time," said the Jonah above her head.

What kind of advice was that—utterly insincere?

Now that he had said it, she honestly didn't know whether she should cover her mouth or not—or was that precisely the effect he was going for?

Mai Minghe truly regretted pressing the bell four times; since falling out of the hospital bed, she had lurched from one danger to the next, each situation more unpleasant than the last.

In that moment of hesitation, the thing had already crawled up to her chest, and up close it looked more and more like some hybrid of a brain and an insect—a raw, icy smell rose from her chest, five or six thin legs stepped across her collarbone, and an ugly, slick, wrinkled thing, its folds of skin layered over one another, appeared in Mai Minghe's field of vision.

Mai Minghe suppressed the instinct to raise her hands, twisting her head desperately to dodge, and rapidly pulled off her outer robe—the older you got the colder you felt, and she was no

exception; she slept in several layers, and the outermost one had its buttons undone, so she could yank it off in one go.

Two long, slender legs had already crept into her mouth—revolting, and maddeningly itchy.

Mai Minghe forced her gaze upward, fixed on her target, swung her arm, and with a sharp crack lashed her robe across Jonah's eyes with all her strength.

If he was using a human body, surely he couldn't escape the limitations of human physiology?

Who could stay perfectly still and composed after taking a hit straight to the eyeball?

Sure enough, Jonah let out an involuntary cry of pain, and the hands gripping Mai Minghe loosened slightly.

The moment she felt the hold slacken, she immediately bent low, pulling her head free from Jonah's reach; at the same time, Mai Minghe wrapped her hand in the robe and grabbed the thing that had been crawling into her mouth, pulling it out.

Thank goodness the skeletal patient had already wrung her dry of anything to vomit, because if she hadn't been, the sight of that squirming ball of flesh thrashing its limbs right in front of her face would have made her retch all over again.

Mai Minghe wrapped it in the robe, gripped it in her hand despite the revulsion, and ran.

She couldn't afford to be choosy this time; when she realized she had run back to the steel-paneled sliding door, Mai Minghe suddenly had an idea. She charged inside, immediately spun around by the door, and sure enough saw Jonah on the ceiling, eyes half-narrowed and blood-red, crawling rapidly toward her with his face twisted in fury.

"You slippery old woman—"

Mai Minghe kept her face expressionless and pulled the door with one hand.

These Residents.

"I told you, I'm not an old woman," she said quietly, and tossed the ball of flesh to the ground, landing it right on the sliding track. She pulled hard on the door, and it pressed down onto the flesh-ball.

Jonah's scream sounded as though it might tear his throat apart: "No, wait!"

The heavy sliding door, made of lead sheathed in steel plate, came crashing down on the wrinkled flesh-ball just as it hit the floor, before it could steady itself. Without so much as a cry, it was crushed and burst open, blood and shredded flesh spattering in all directions—in an instant, all that remained between the door and the wall was the largest fragment, a flat piece of flesh, its thin legs still twitching.

Before she could kick the remains aside and shut the door all the way, a hand covered in bulging veins slammed against the door frame with a crack.

Through the gap in the door, half of Jonah's face barely looked human anymore; his nostrils flared open and snapped shut like a pair of bellows that had opened on his face.

"My child!" he shrieked.

Mai Minghe braced against the door with all her strength, not daring to let him wrench it open and come through, while at the same time she swept a quick glance around the dim interior, then couldn't help letting out a quiet, resigned sigh.

Just as she had expected, this room was a medical imaging room.

Rooms for X-ray scanning required radiation shielding on the doors and walls, and few hospitals would install windows in an X-ray room—not because special shielded windows didn't exist, but because they were expensive and not cost-effective—which meant that once you were chased into an X-ray room, you were a turtle in a jar with no way out.

That was also why Mai Minghe had passed this door without entering the first time: if she went into an ordinary examination room and locked the door, she could still escape through a window, but in an X-ray room that would be impossible.

"Does something like you really need to pass on offspring?" Mai Minghe said through gritted teeth, still straining against the door. "This is the Nest—you don't need to go in for ecological reproduction here, do you?"

"Once I've killed you," Jonah's words came out in a wet, rasping hiss, as though each syllable was sticking to the next. "Your corpse will dissolve in the Nest, and from your constituent units, I will rebuild my child..."

"You mean, using my flesh and blood to rebuild your child?"

Mai Minghe leaned against the wall with her whole body braced against the door, muscles trembling, still unable to force it completely shut. She scanned the room for anything that might

serve as a weapon while buying time with conversation: "My flesh and blood probably aren't disgusting enough to make one."

Jonah suddenly burst out laughing.

"Flesh and blood? I don't want your withered old flesh and blood at all! As long as you have ever given thought to the matter of 'reproduction,' your mind and body have already been marked. The you who once considered 'reproduction' is still a part of who you are today, and as long as I can obtain that part—"

Mai Minghe froze.

She hadn't expected that, here and now, she would be pulled back into memories from years ago: the anxiety over her day-by-day declining fertility, the confusion over what choice to make, the unease about the prospect of old age...

Without realizing it, her grip loosened slightly.

Jonah caught it.

The sliding door was shoved open with a sudden, forceful push—she had barely startled when a red-haired head poked through the gap.

Digging a saved draft chapter out of my iPad, I've scraped by another day—it feels just like finding a thousand yuan in the pocket of a winter coat!

Chapter 20 — Mai Minghe and the Jonah Who Begged for Help

The shock hit Mai Minghe like a thousand volts crackling through her body all at once; she threw every ounce of strength she had into pushing the door forward—and she was fast enough that the sliding door clamped tight around Jonah's neck just before he could squeeze himself through.

If she could simply choke him out that way, things would have been simple.

Unfortunately, the door was pressing against the side of his neck, over the carotid artery—enough to flush his face deep red and make his breathing labored, but not enough to crush his windpipe fatally; as long as he could still breathe, he still had strength, and one hand hooked around the door's edge as he shoved hard back toward Mai Minghe.

The man could even talk.

"Did you know?"

His breath was ragged, but his words came out clear and complete: "...Anyone who lingers in the Nest for more than seven days, or who dies within it, is not merely broken down in body—their mind, their memories, their emotions, their experiences, even a single passing thought, are all dismantled piece by piece and transformed into other forms, becoming part of the Nest. You've lived a long life, haven't you? Quite a few experiences. And no shortage of wicked thoughts too, I'd wager. When you die here, I wonder what extraordinary things will emerge... People who die in the Nest at seventy or eighty years old are very rare indeed."

She half understood, and half did not.

After death, emotions, memories, and experiences would all become part of the Nest? What did "part of it" mean—would her own memories each become a Resident?

As if he had heard her thoughts, Jonah laughed, his breath hoarse: "What things will come walking out from eighty-six years of a life... I'm so looking forward to it."

Was this speech of Jonah's meant to shake her again, the way it had before?

Mai Minghe braced against the door with everything she had, teeth clenched, thinking: then he had miscalculated.

"Is it because Jonah always has to train new people that you can't help trying to enlighten me too?"

Even as her muscles trembled and her whole body shook, she still had no trouble finding words; she said, her voice quivering: "You live inside someone's body like a roundworm in an intestine—you have no experience of human life. What person makes it through this life without setbacks and hardship? But the thing is, life always finds a moment you least expect to offer you a little light and warmth.

"Even if you kill me here today and use me as raw material to produce a Resident, I won't be in pain, and I won't be angry. I didn't have many days left to begin with—lying in bed day after day, like a dried-up husk. The best of it has been gone forever. But before my life ended, I got to be young again, to live again, and to die in the image of myself as I was in my memories—who could be lucky enough for that? This is the gentleness Heaven has given me. I'm quite happy about it."

"Shut up!" Jonah couldn't get a word in, and he let out a hoarse shout: "Shut up!"

"When a person gets older, they can't help rambling a bit—once they start talking, they just can't stop."

Jonah seemed genuinely furious; he led by example and shut his own mouth first, pressing his lips into a tight line; a person and a disembodied head then engaged in a silent reverse tug-of-war for a while, accompanied only by each other's heavy, labored breathing.

Mai Minghe, true to form, could not hold herself back, and spoke again.

"You've burrowed into Jonah's body—doesn't that mean he has no independent will left at all? Hey, young man, are you still in there? Get a handle on that brain-worm of yours—this can't go on."

Jonah's face had long since burst into patches of broken capillaries from the pressure, covered in large, vivid blood spots all across his skin, like a swollen purple grape—yet he seemed entirely unbothered, showing no reaction to Mai Minghe's words at all, and kept pulling at the door.

People were dangerous when they went down a dead end, but it turned out that something that wasn't a person, going down a dead end, was just as hard to deal with...

Mai Minghe knew her own physical strength was no match for Jonah's.

Even if she had recovered her youth and regained a strong body, that was only in comparison to her eighty-six-year-old self; Jonah was powerfully built and had routinely walked the line

between life and death, and the two of them had never been on the same level to begin with—and what was more, the elderly had poor appetites, and in the day before she fell into the Nest she had eaten only a few crackers and a little egg, all of which she had vomited back up, and now, looking at the mutilated remains of the "child" on the floor, she was actually beginning to feel a faint twinge of hunger.

That she had managed to hold on this long was purely due to the advantage of her position; if the stalemate continued, she was bound to lose sooner or later.

Mai Minghe glanced once more at the remains of the "child" on the floor and suddenly sucked a sharp breath through her teeth: "Hm?"

The flicker of startled suspicion was enough to involuntarily slacken her grip.

Jonah reacted at once, and sure enough followed her gaze, glancing downward—Mai Minghe had been waiting for exactly this moment; she immediately seized the chance, threw her full body weight behind the door, and slammed it forward with all she had; a dry, cracked screech tore out from between the door and the wall, as if a frail, crumbling rubber tube had been caught in the gap.

"A child's trick, and it actually got you to look down," Mai Minghe said—though inside, she cursed under her breath.

She had hoped that while Jonah looked down, she would have a chance to slam the door shut completely.

Now, of course, the situation was hardly any different from before, and there was no telling how much longer the stalemate would drag on.

Air passed in and out of Jonah's throat in fitful, broken intervals, as though each breath was harder than the last.

Had it caught on his windpipe?

Because he had turned his head, she couldn't quite tell from her angle.

"I... I..." Jonah's face was to the wall, and his voice came out muffled and hoarse—less like speech, more like a balloon slowly leaking air. "I'm... a Hunter with Morgan House Faction..."

Now of all times, he was still bothering to introduce himself?

The doubt had barely formed in Mai Minghe's mind before a sense that something was different came over her; she kept listening.

"My name is Jonah Janko... This is already my fifth day in the Nest..." he said with great difficulty. "I beg you... go to Morgan House... ask for rescue..."

A layer of goosebumps prickled softly across Mai Minghe's skin.

Whether it was because the door had caught something critical and temporarily severed the Resident's control, she couldn't say—but the one speaking to her now was not the Nest's Resident bent on killing her, but Jonah, a Hunter from Blackmoor City, begging for his life.

"Where are your companions?" Speaking was a strain for Mai Minghe too at this moment. "Can't you call them here? You can see my situation—I can barely keep myself alive."

Her limbs had long since begun going weak in waves; all she could do was keep telling herself "one more second," and when that second passed, "one more second," and that was how she had held on until now.

"Get out of the Nest... get out now..." Jonah was still speaking in broken fragments.

"I can't get out," Mai Minghe cut him off. "Can you keep control of your body and stop the Resident from coming after me? From here to the exit of the Nest is still a long way—"

"No, no... it lied to you."

Mai Minghe snapped her mouth shut, and her teeth clicked together with the force of it.

"However the passage brought you here... is how you go back..." Two rattling clicks came from Jonah's throat, and then silence.

Just as Mai Minghe's heart clenched and she thought the Resident had wrested back control, he spoke again without warning: "Fell in through the television... the television... go back that way. You've already passed through the passage once, so when you see it again, you'll feel it..."

"But the moment I let go, the Resident will regain control of you, won't it?" Mai Minghe couldn't fully conceal her agitation. "Never mind that I might not even make it out—even if I could run, I don't know if I'd find the tele— before it catches me—"

The word "vision" lodged itself in her throat, unfinished.

Her gaze came to rest on the far end of the room.

After a few seconds, Mai Minghe asked in a low voice: "When I see the passage, I'll know that's what it is—is that what you mean?"

Jonah's throat hissed faintly, as though he could no longer answer her.

Mai Minghe couldn't help swallowing, her heartbeat loud enough to hear inside her own ears.

In the dimness, she could just barely make out, at the far end of the room, a small door.

Although the medical imaging room had no outward-facing windows, a small room had been partitioned off inside it, and that door led to the small room; beside the door was a glass window facing directly toward the X-ray machine.

When she had been searching for a weapon, she had only looked at what was close at hand, so she had noticed the small door and the glass window without thinking anything of them; but now she suddenly realized something—when she used to go for X-rays, the doctor would always sit in that little room.

Why sit in there?

Because the doctor had to operate the equipment and view the images.

From the edge of the window, she could now make out the shadow of half a computer screen; with no light, everything was blurry and indistinct, and if one hadn't specifically looked for it, one might not have registered it as a screen at all.

The screen was used for viewing medical images and was quite large—and the feeling she'd had back then, lying in the bed and desperate to get to the television, suddenly ignited inside Mai Minghe like a wildfire, burning brighter and brighter.

Could it be that her passage was not a television set, but simply a "screen"?

But then—when she had passed the nurses' station and seen the computer screen on the counter, why had she felt nothing?

That question didn't matter right now, and this was not the time to think about it.

"Hey, Jonah?" Mai Minghe called out. She wanted to confirm her guess with him, but from Jonah's throat came only a low, wet gurgling.

"How am I supposed to find Morgan House Faction? Do you have... do you have their phone number?"

You wouldn't find a Hunter faction in the Yellow Pages, would you—oh, right, there were no Yellow Pages anymore. People in the old days had worried about no one being able to find them, so they'd list their home numbers in the public phone directory; people nowadays were exactly the opposite, as if what they feared most was something called "a privacy breach."

The world had changed.

How was she supposed to find "Morgan House Faction"? Would it be on a smartphone? She couldn't let a perfectly good young man be done in by some rotten worm.

But Mai Minghe called out to him a few more times, and Jonah gave no response whatsoever.

She looked at the screen in the small room, and inside her chest the wildfire burned.

If her guess was wrong and she made a dash for the small room only to find she couldn't return to Blackmoor City, that would certainly mean death; but if the stalemate dragged on indefinitely, death was just as inevitable.

Since danger lay on either path, she might as well act.

Mai Minghe took a long, deep breath, and lowered the foot she had been bracing against the door.

She let go; the moment the pressure on the door eased, the Resident snapped awake. At the very instant Jonah's shoulder forced the sliding door open, Mai Minghe took a step and broke into a run toward the small room.

Today is another day I find myself on a plane; by my estimate I'll have to fly at least three more times in the next two weeks—all the major airlines are popping champagne right now, except for China Eastern.

Just seeing the words "China Eastern" when I'm booking tickets is enough to make me feel unwell—I have to scroll past it immediately. There's a saying that people won't remember what you said or what you did, but they'll always remember the way you made them feel. That's exactly how it is with China Eastern and me—I've long since forgotten what it was that disgusted me in the first place, but that disgust has weathered the passage of time and stands unyielding to this day. The mere thought of China Eastern can make me motion-sick sitting on the toilet, so I'd rather take a Southern Airlines flight that doesn't arrive until eleven at night than give a single cent to an afternoon China Eastern flight.

Chapter 21 — How Can You Tell If I'm Making Excuses?

Friends, grandmas, extraterrestrials — honestly, I don't know myself whether this counts as a fake excuse note or not.

Grandma, put the shoe down first, let me explain for a moment, and then see if you can hold back from swatting me like a cockroach.

I was originally supposed to fly out yesterday. I checked the weather in the morning, Shanghai was clear and sunny, I was pretty happy about it — trotted off to Pudong Airport, figured I could sneak in some writing in a quiet corner while waiting to board. Had it all planned out; I was even willing to buy a lounge pass just to get some updates done.

After all that hassle getting there, I took out my phone and looked — well, would you believe it, the flight was cancelled.

Apparently all of Guangdong was under an orange weather alert — thunderstorms — which just goes to show how warmly my home province welcomes me back.

But I couldn't just strand myself in Shanghai forever, I still had to leave — so I immediately applied to rebook. The rebooking alone took a goddamn two hours, during which there were all sorts of phone calls, checking flight information... After two hours, I successfully got rebooked onto a 9:30 PM flight that same night — except it departed from Hongqiao Airport.

Fine. Off to Hongqiao.

Every DiDi driver in Shanghai must have me enshrined on their dashboard or something.

I got to Hongqiao Airport and looked at the departures board — there was an extra line of text. Above "Scheduled departure 21:35," a new line had appeared: "Estimated departure 23:35" — I ask you, is that how human beings communicate? What is this, a competition to see who knows the most synonyms? I already had a bad feeling at that point. After all, Guangdong's rainstorms don't play favorites. What was I supposed to do — I couldn't just sit in the airport waiting to see when the plane might eventually decide to fly. I'd better book a hotel.

It's not like I'm staying overnight anyway, cheapest one will do, maybe in a few hours I'll be on my way. I thought naively.

So I dragged my luggage into a cab and got ferried to a place that looked less like Shanghai and more like a county town. Got out of the car. It really was close to the airport — a jumbo jet thundered so low over my head it nearly blew my wig off (going so hard on the writing that I started losing hair at eighteen). I took a few pictures of the planes while I was at it. Couldn't come all this way for nothing.

Checked in, walked into the room, walked right back out — why? To go buy disposable toilet seat covers. That toilet seat was yellowed like old braised stock — one look and you knew it had been marinating in ancient piss for years.

Right. This is the hotel that still costs over three hundred yuan at the cheapest. I am indeed in Shanghai.

Well, would you believe it — the universe heard me say "not staying overnight." The second flight was delayed too. Delayed until five in the morning.

Even owls can't pull an all-nighter like that!!!

I rebooked a second time, to eleven o'clock this morning.

And then I just stood there in that hotel room, holding my bag, trapped and miserable, realizing I really was going to have to spend the night here. If I'd known it would come to this, why didn't I book somewhere decent? The heavens are out to get me. First I put the door chain on (I never normally bother with that), then I pulled back the duvet and inspected the sheets — the sheets were okay, at least they looked white.

By this point I'd been through the wringer and it was already evening. Having typed not a single word but feeling utterly drained in body and soul, I reached down to feel the mattress.

...Where is my mattress?

These individual springs, poking me one by one — what are they made of, diamonds? Don't mattresses usually have some kind of padding on top? Where's the padding?? I could feel every single spring through the sheet, like I was taking its pulse — WHERE IS MY PADDING?!?!?!?

I honestly felt like crying right then. You want to know how I slept that night? I spread the duvet back out flat and used it as a mattress. Lying on top of the duvet, the sensation was exactly like lying on a sidewalk.

Then I pulled one end of the duvet out, wrapped it around myself from the side, and made myself into a stuffed flatbread. That way I had both a mattress and a blanket at once — one item,

two functions — and only then could I actually sleep.

By this point I had typed all of three hundred words and was completely spent. I closed my eyes somewhere after nine. Going to bed that early was a form of disrespect toward the neighbors next door.

So around past ten o'clock, I heard it. You might think the sounds in a hotel are more or less the same few things. You'd be wrong.

I heard a pair of high heels going click-clack-click-clack down the hallway — at least twenty laps of it (no carpet) — then the door slammed, one loud bang, and whoever it was went inside. After that, someone began moving furniture.

Half-asleep, I was lying there thinking even in my dreams: how are you moving the furniture? The tables and beds in hotels are all bolted to the goddamn floor — so what on earth is that heavy thing scraping across the floor???

And why did it go on for half an hour?! Are you renovating the hotel??

What is everyone in this place here for???

Anyway, long story short, I made it through the night. Once I post this little account of the situation, I'll have to pack up all my bags again and head to the airport. I'm exhausted, worn out, and half-convinced I smell terrible (didn't dare shower here)··· Estimated landing time is around two in the afternoon. If the flight actually lands on time, there might be an update tonight. If there's another delay, I'm going to go jump in the Huangpu River.

After everything I went through on this trip to Shanghai — you think I'm done once I get home?

No. Business isn't finished. I have to come back again on the 8th, after the holiday.

Wonderful. I'm clearly here to build character and experience life to the fullest.

Chapter 22: Sydney Ginn, After Life and Death

They say that at the moment of death, a lifetime of memories passes before your eyes like a revolving lantern; Sydney Ginn now knew that this was neither entirely right nor entirely wrong.

She lay on the cold floor of the exhibition hall, and yet she felt like a small boat adrift—the ropes that had bound her to the world of the living had come loose, and she was slowly drifting out onto a river thick with fog.

Sometimes the fog thinned and parted, revealing the scene of her first arrival in Blackmoor City; back then she had split the rent on a semi-basement apartment, and looking out the living room window at the street, all she could see were passing shoes and trouser hems.

Sometimes she saw the client from her very first transaction, turning an Artifact over and over under a desk lamp, the light falling into their eyes and rendering both their pupils and their suspicion half-transparent.

The experiences closest to her—opening the passage, attracting a stalker, being killed—felt more like things that had happened to someone else, flat and bleached-out descriptions that the fog swallowed whole. The distant, long-ago moments were more vivid: carrying out the scallion-and-meat pie her mother had baked, going over to a classmate's house every week in seventh grade... open the door, walk inside, and she could go home.

Drawn along by those faraway memories, Sydney Ginn drifted further away; the faint, desperate rattling in her injured throat grew harder and harder to hear.

Her head lay submerged in a pool of blood, which spread out around her like a river of the dead.

"Go ahead and die," a voice floated from somewhere above, whispering in a hissing, leaking sort of way.

And yet it was this send-off that called Sydney Ginn partway back.

...How did it come to this?

She had called the taxi, paid the fare, followed every instruction to the letter without daring to step out of line, and had a stiff neck to show for it by the time she got off.

She had pretended not to see the female Resident crawling out of the elevator on her right, fought her way into the ground-floor exhibition hall with great difficulty, and held her breath in tense, coiled readiness the entire time...

She had done everything, done it all, and still ended up like this. How could she not be furious.

A dark figure stooped down, apparently kneeling on the floor, studying her face.

Sydney Ginn could no longer make out details; all she saw were blurry silhouettes: a rounder shape was a skull, connected below it was a neck, and jutting out from that neck was another dark shape—the hunting knife she had driven into the other's throat.

As the figure opened its mouth to speak, the knife buried deep in its neck trembled gently up and down with each word. The blade had cut through its windpipe, and between syllables it leaked air with a hiss: "...I really should thank you—you've reminded me what it was I forgot. It was the hiking backpack."

Even though Sydney Ginn still had thoughts, none of them showed on her face. Blood had stained her neck a black-red, as though her throat had been erased; her body had gone still, utterly motionless.

When she had leapt onto the first taxi, she must have accidentally stepped on the "Copied" square.

She still remembered the moment she lifted her foot—someone had given the hiking pack on her back a sudden violent yank, nearly sending her tumbling backwards; when Sydney Ginn caught herself and turned around, she was looking at her own face—no distortion of any kind, the features smooth and fine, like looking in a mirror.

She had frozen.

"When did you copy yourself into me?" that other "Sydney Ginn" demanded, glaring at her and getting in the first word. It seemed to want to shove her, but wasn't quite brave enough to make contact, and snapped: "Get away from me!"

So the square labeled "Copied" really just meant she would be copied, and nothing else?

That actually made sense—copying something didn't necessarily mean the original would be damaged...

Apart from the existence of a copy, Sydney Ginn felt, going over herself from head to toe, that nothing was wrong; if there was one thing that made her most uneasy, it was this—"Sydney Ginn" seemed to have inherited both her body and her mind simultaneously, and was now utterly convinced that it was the real one.

...Then how could she be certain, one hundred percent, that she wasn't the Resident? She, too, was absolutely sure she was the real Sydney Ginn.

No—no, that was impossible; the one in front of her was the Resident, and it was about to take her place and go to the Museum of Modern Art.

There was one key piece of evidence that proved she was the real Sydney Ginn—the backpack, the hunting knife, and her phone were all still on her, none of them copied into a second set; the other one had nothing on her, not a single thing.

"At the time, my mind was entirely on how to jump onto the taxi, so I forgot to take the hiking backpack. I was standing in the square the whole time—it was too heavy to keep on my back, so I'd set it down on top of my feet..."

The dark figure hovering before her, shaped like a human face, went on leaking air: "What happened afterward that made me fail to pick up the backpack—that I forgot, because I handed that stretch of memory over to the driver."

Even at this point, "Sydney Ginn" apparently still did not believe it was the Resident.

It paused there, as though something had occurred to it: "I'd actually meant to ask you—Passenger Rule number four: can you lift your head once the fare is paid? But you're a Resident; you don't follow the Passenger Rules, so what could the consequences possibly be... never mind, it doesn't matter. I made it off the taxi just fine either way. I didn't expect you to bring my things to me, though."

...How could she not be furious.

At the time she had not dared to keep fighting with "Sydney Ginn," afraid of stepping into some punishment square; so she had called another taxi, paid the fare with memories, rode the whole way with her head bowed, following behind "Sydney Ginn," and got off at the Museum of Modern Art.

Whatever it did, she did the same, until she finally followed it into the underground exhibition hall, seized her moment, and drove the hunting knife deep into its throat.

Sydney Ginn had heard that Residents couldn't be killed. Even if they died for a moment, they could regenerate somewhere else.

But Residents were bound by rules that went beyond life and death, so an attack could still have some kind of effect—what she hadn't anticipated was that driving a knife into a Resident's throat would only result in a leaking windpipe.

She had let go of the knife handle in a daze, staring at "Sydney Ginn."

When it tried to spit, nothing came out of its mouth, which gaped like a dried-up black hole; now with the knife buried in its neck, it only hissed and leaked air, unable to bleed.

The other stood motionless, its eyes rolling down to look at the hunting knife, then lifting back up to look at her.

For a second or two, neither of them moved.

"Sydney Ginn" slowly spread her familiar teeth at her in a grin. She had brushed every single one of them countless times, studied their color and shape in the mirror until she knew them at a glance—and yet here they were, in someone else's mouth.

...Disgusting.

"My neck has been stabbed with a knife," the Resident said, matter-of-factly, after that second or two. "Since you copied yourself into my likeness, your neck should be pierced as well."

The moment those words were spoken, Sydney Ginn's neck opened its mouth.

...Why? How could this be?

So this was how cold the outside world was; when the blood vessels and muscle were torn open in one stroke, it was like ice water being poured in along the wound—and the pain came only belatedly, trailing behind.

The sudden cold at her throat was instantly swamped by the scalding spatter of blood that splashed across the face of her "self" opposite her—Sydney Ginn pressed one hand hard against her gaping throat, instinctively trying to clamp the wound shut again, but blood kept bubbling up through her fingers.

With her consciousness shattering at the edge of death, she crumpled to the ground.

Her eyelids froze half-open, half-closed, and her soul drifted into the deep, dense fog.

Sydney Ginn forced down the crawling dread that raised every hair on her body, pressed one hand tight against her neck, and seized the hunting knife's handle with the other.

Her palms were slick with cold sweat; her legs had gone so weak she couldn't stand, and she could only slowly slide down until she was sitting on the floor. A few steps away, the corpse that looked exactly like her lay on the ground, its eyelids half-open, the pupils beneath already clouded over like a dead fish's.

"Sydney Ginn" hadn't driven the blade deep enough, and had missed the critical structures—perhaps the one small mercy in all of this.

She knew very well that when a blade penetrated the body, pulling it out would only deepen the wound and cause heavy bleeding; the first rule of first aid was "do not remove anything from a wound." Sometimes a blade lodged in the body could temporarily act as a plug, sealing the wound and reducing blood loss.

The reason "Sydney Ginn" had died from the same injury while she herself was still alive was almost certainly due to that one crucial difference—the hunting knife stanching the bleeding. So Residents weren't unkillable after all, at least not the "Vulture" kind.

The logic of killing it was just a bit convoluted: you had to let it copy itself into a second version of you first, then, after you received a fatal wound, remind it to copy the fatal wound onto itself—only then would it die.

Even a wound that merely looked fatal would do.

Even though she knew she wasn't going to die, having a knife lodged in her throat was a torment to every nerve in her body; and besides, she couldn't call an ambulance in the Nest, couldn't go to an emergency room, and certainly couldn't climb all the way to the top of a high-rise and jump off with a knife in her neck just to get back to Blackmoor City for medical treatment...

She would have to handle it herself.

She dug a spare T-shirt out of her backpack and wrapped it tightly around her neck and the knife, winding it so tight she kept seeing stars and gasping for breath. She felt along the skin for the knife tip, located it with her fingertips, and got ready—the moment the knife was pulled out, she would press down on the wound immediately; she couldn't risk a major hemorrhage.

Sydney Ginn knew the Nest was dangerous, and had no doubt given herself first aid more than a few times; but even with her self-taught basic first aid knowledge and her well-stocked pack, this kind of injury was truly beyond anything she had imagined.

Even she herself didn't know how she had managed to stop the hemorrhage and then clumsily sutured the knife wound closed—it was nothing short of a miracle.

Despite the successful "surgery," Sydney Ginn couldn't hold on any longer and lost consciousness for a while.

When she came to, the underground exhibition hall was still perfectly silent; she and the stiffened corpse of her dead self lay slumped on either side of the enormous candle, and if she cocked her ear to listen, the place felt like a tomb.

Sydney Ginn rested for a long while before she slowly climbed to her feet.

The serious injury, the lingering fear, and the exhaustion made her want nothing more than to go home, to curl up under her covers, breathing in the familiar scent of jasmine laundry detergent, and sink into a long, deep sleep.

But it wasn't time yet.

Sydney Ginn was also quietly astonished; she hadn't expected that, faced with an Artifact, she would show a toughness that seemed beyond ordinary human limits. With a knife wound to the throat, how could an ordinary person survive?

She walked step by step to the candle, hesitated for a moment, and placed her hand against its surface.

A small line of text immediately floated up beside her palm: 2009.4.22.

...So the history encoded at this position corresponded to April 22nd, 2009?

She was currently standing several meters below the top of the candle. Why did this particular spot represent April 22nd, 2009?

Sydney Ginn thought for a moment, walked to the very top of the candle, and reached out to touch it—and sure enough, she saw her own birthday: 1998.9.29.

So that was it... her gaze followed the length of the candle downward.

That meant the flow of time encapsulated within the candle ran from the day she was born all the way to the present day while she was still alive; the candle held no future.

Because the future was chaos, unfixed—and therefore could not be foreseen?

Though her greedy hope of glimpsing the future had come to nothing, which was a little disappointing, looking at it from another angle it was a strange kind of comfort: since fate was not already written, she could still choose what to do and where to go. A person wasn't a small insect sealed inside a transparent cage, every possible path already defined.

In this bewildering, disorienting world, a person still had this small measure of control over themselves.

Of course, Sydney Ginn wasn't arrogant enough to think the Nest had custom-built this Artifact especially for her—whoever touched the candle, it should show history beginning from that person's date of birth.

She walked on a little further and, judging the distance by feel, placed her hand on the candle again to search.

2026.5.2. She found without difficulty the moment she had first encountered the stalker Anthony.

Sydney Ginn had an idea.

She crouched down and found an ignition switch beneath the metal trough. With a *click*, flames ignited beneath the candle's base.

She wanted to try—to snuff this whole thing out before it could begin.

All the sleep debt I'd racked up from the exhausting scramble of recent days came knocking the moment I finally got back... No matter how much coffee I drank, I was drowsy from the moment I opened my eyes in the morning until I fell into bed at night... By eight o'clock I simply couldn't take it anymore and had to sleep...

Chapter 23 – Sydney Ginn: If the Mountain Won't Come to You

The exhibition hall was as dead-still as a cave, broken only by the soft crackling of the flame.

Sydney Ginn's nerves were strung as tight as a bowstring; every little crack of the flame was like a finger plucking that string.

She had read through the long description of the Artifact "Candlefall" in full, and stood there turning it over in her mind for a good while before she could consider it even halfway digested.

She walked another circuit around the underground exhibition hall, making sure nothing lurked in the corners and shadows ready to launch a second attack—being attacked by herself once was already more than enough.

When she passed the corpse, she quickened her pace to move past, then suddenly stopped and turned back.

The corpse of her dead self always made Sydney Ginn feel deeply unsettled.

She had no wish to look at it, and even less to be looked at by it, so she simply covered its face with a towel, smothering that accusatory, scrutinizing gaze her own eyes had fixed on her, and only then returned to the candle.

Using a small flame to heat such an enormous candle naturally took a good deal of effort.

She had completed a full circuit of the exhibition hall before the candle had at last melted enough to proceed to the next step: the section of wax representing early May 2026 was beginning to soften and slacken from the bottom up, drooping heavily toward the floor like a belly swollen with child—except that the "belly" was gradually turning translucent, dark shapes drifting and shifting slowly within it, as though it were pregnant with a womb full of ghosts.

Sydney Ginn hurried over in a few quick strides, bent down, and peered at the past world showing through the melted wax.

The first thing she saw was herself.

According to the Artifact's description, because she was the one who had touched the candle, what the wax revealed was primarily her own personal history—the reason for "primarily" being that no person can survive apart from their broader environment, so significant events in the world around her that had shaped her would also surface within the wax.

The exact words in the description were as follows:

"...In today's highly integrated world, the historical turning points that carry decisive influence are more often than not caused by a handful of people. The mass movements that occasionally succeeded in the past are now almost impossible to replicate.

"Yet the decisions of a small number of oligarchs can influence and reshape the fate of all humanity. By the same token, when applied to personal history, the candle will faithfully render the key figures and key events that influenced and reshaped the individual's immediate environment."

This passage had seemed somewhat obscure at first reading, but after watching the history in the wax for a while, Sydney Ginn understood.

For instance—why had she come to meet the harasser Anthony in early May?

The most direct cause was that a female friend had invited her out to a bar that night.

Amber was not a Hunter and had no passage, but she worked in finance for the Morgan House Faction and had crossed paths with Sydney Ginn a few times before; the two of them got along well enough. It was that very night, at the bar, that Sydney Ginn had met Anthony—all gilded surface and nothing beneath.

But thinking one step deeper: why had Sydney Ginn, who hated the smell of alcohol most of all, agreed to go to the bar with Amber that day?

Because at the end of April, a regional war that had dragged on for years—exhausting the entire world with inflation and wearing everyone to the bone—had finally ground to a halt after immeasurable bloodshed, ending in what amounted to a farce.

The outcome of the war was far from satisfying to anyone with a sense of justice—no matter which side their sense of justice supported—but after years of tragedies that had repeated themselves until people were nearly numb, the whole world had collectively let out a breath; on the day the war was declared over, there were no shortage of celebratory parades and spontaneous public festivities, and even the news anchors seemed somehow lighter.

Artifact Hunters had one foot in the Nest and one foot in the human world, and their outlook always kept them a few paces removed from worldly affairs; Sydney Ginn was no exception.

But even she had felt those days as if sunlight were falling warm on her skin, her mood as brimming and expansive as the approaching summer—when Amber suggested going out for

drinks to celebrate, Sydney Ginn thought she could always have fruit juice, and agreed without a second thought.

If the war had not ended, Amber would not have invited her to celebrate; without going to the bar, she would never have met Anthony; without him becoming her stalker and harasser, Sydney Ginn would never have entered the Nest, would never have had a knife driven into her throat, would never have been standing beside her own corpse—and would certainly never have found this giant candle.

Everything she had endured today, traced back to its root, had come about because of some bald old man on the other side of the world who had started a war... so how could the people and events closer to her—those that had shaped her—possibly not be enfolded into the candle?

"When you are reshaping what lies within Candlefall, you will find that the greater the physical distance between you and your target, the harder it becomes to alter their past."

Immediately following this, the description for "Candlefall" contained this passage:

"Someone standing right beside you can have their past changed with the utmost ease—simply reach into Candlefall and nudge or mold the wax itself, and you can shift their position, experiences, and actions; the past will change naturally as a result.

"Someone on the other side of the city can still be changed, albeit with difficulty—but you will find that the portion of Candlefall encasing them is somewhat stiff and uncooperative when you try to mold it. Fine details are hard to adjust; at most you can alter a rough outline—and as for how much of a difference that change will actually produce, that is even harder to say.

"And what of someone on the other side of the world? Regrettably, even if such a person appears within your candle, you cannot exert any influence over their past experiences."

That hardly mattered, Sydney Ginn thought, gazing at the still-slightly-hazy scene within the candle. What she wanted to change was about to come out through the bar's back door and step right up beside her.

The wax had turned transparent and become a pool of liquid that hung suspended just above the floor, as though it were a glimmering basin of water floating in midair. She reached out and touched it gently, and found it was not hot.

Reflected in that pool was a night in Blackmoor City blazing with countless lights; leaning closer, Sydney Ginn could even catch the distinct smell of the bar—alcohol, tobacco, and perfume

mingled together.

Within the pool formed by Candlefall, tall buildings, the bar, shops, and streets all looked like tiny miniature models. A figure the size of a fingertip—herself—stood at the bar's back door, gazing up at the starless night sky over Blackmoor City.

Right there.

There was no need to stir the wax and search for the right moment; she only had to wait—in this regard, working with Candlefall was a little like scrubbing through a video's progress bar: she could drag it backward or forward, or let it play forward naturally in time.

She remembered that before meeting Anthony, a motorcade of several black Mercedes SUVs had driven past nearby—every window reinforced against blast—and she had stared long enough to catch herself; shortly after the motorcade passed, the back door of the bar, painted dark red, had—

There it was.

The moment the bar's small back door was pushed open the tiniest crack, Sydney Ginn immediately extended her little finger and pressed its tip firmly against the door from within the Candlefall.

The shortest finger, and yet it was nearly as large as the bar door itself—pressed there against it, the sight was genuinely strange.

Through the door, Anthony shoved again and again, his force no more than a small insect kicking its legs against her fingertip; but how could someone so tiny within the Candlefall ever push open her enormous fingertip?

She leaned close to the wax and heard, muffled beneath the raucous music behind the door, a curse: "...This damn door—what is wrong with it?"

The tiny Sydney Ginn who had stepped outside the back door for some air paid no attention whatsoever to the enormous finger stretching across the air beside her.

When she heard the cursing from behind the door, she only glanced back briefly, then stepped a few paces away—a competent Blackmoor City resident always kept a certain wariness and cool distance from strangers, let alone a stranger who was cursing.

The would-be harasser behind the door shoved furiously a few more times, then finally gave up, and seemed to turn and walk away; quiet returned behind the door.

That should do it, Sydney Ginn thought, not quite daring to pull her hand back yet, still holding the door shut.

As long as they never met in the first place, none of what followed would ever happen.

The rage and indignation she had originally felt toward Anthony seemed, after witnessing "her own" death, to have been soaked through by a cold shiver, and was no longer as fierce; her first priority now was simply to use the candle to run the experiment—revenge had fallen to second place.

As for what effect changing history would have on the "present," the Artifact's description had offered a detailed explanation:

"...After the point where a change occurs, history will continue to develop naturally according to its own internal logic, and the person's 'present' will shift accordingly.

"There is a time-travel paradox that asks whether a person can go back and kill their own grandfather. Because if the grandfather dies, the person would not exist—but then no one would have gone back to kill the grandfather in the first place... and so a paradox is formed."

When it came to traveling through time and changing the past, it seemed there was always a great deal to explain—whether in film and fiction, or with Nest Artifacts.

"'Candlefall' will not fall into any such paradox. The candle constitutes a fixed segment of time—beginning from the birth of the person who touches it, and ending at the very moment they touch it. Therefore you cannot change the past before your own birth.

"However, changing history through 'Candlefall' will still affect the present. For example: if you melt open the wax for a month ago and crush your past self within it—at the instant of that crushing, you will also vanish from before the candle, and the candle will return to its original state.

"That is an extreme case. If you caused yourself to break your leg a month ago, then naturally, a month later, you would not have met a potential client on the ski slopes—correct? As stated above, history will always move forward according to its own internal logic and produce the consequences that naturally follow."

In other words, if she prevented herself from meeting Anthony that night, Sydney Ginn would also vanish from beside the candle—with no harasser, she would have no reason to enter the Nest; and having never entered the Nest, she would of course not be here now.

"However, to preserve the continuity of the timeline, memories of using 'Candlefall' and altering history will still be retained in full—they will not be lost because you have made changes to history."

In other words... if Sydney Ginn prevented herself from meeting Anthony, she would not be in the Nest today; and yet she would still remember that in the "previous version of history," she had met Anthony, entered the Nest, and altered history.

Retaining the user's memories was enough to preserve the continuity of the timeline? But why?

Sydney Ginn turned it over for a while, arrived at no answer, and let it go. Being able to retain her memories was a great boon; great boons don't hold up to scrutiny, so it was best to simply accept it without question.

Only by keeping her memories could she come back and find "Candlefall" again—and compared to such a precious Artifact, what did the nauseating memories Anthony had brought matter at all?

Within the Candlefall, the tiny Sydney Ginn stamped her feet, turned around, and seemed to be heading back inside the bar.

Sydney Ginn moved her little finger aside and watched that tiny version of herself pull open the door and disappear into the flickering lights and music on the other side.

Good—it was all done. She could extinguish the flame and let the candle solidify once more.

Only when Candlefall had solidified again would it set into the shape of a new time and a new history.

The pool of transparent liquid wax suspended in midair slowly turned white, grew cloudy, rose back up little by little, was drawn back into the body of the candle, and once again became smooth and unblemished—no matter how one looked at it, it was as though it had never melted at all.

Sydney Ginn took one last look at the shrouded corpse not far away, closed her eyes, and waited quietly for the brand-new "this moment" that would come after changing history.

After a little while, she opened her eyes.

She had not returned to Blackmoor City; she was still inside the Nest.

The pool of blood beneath the shrouded corpse had nearly dried to a dark, purplish-black; the candle stretched long and unbroken into the distance; the exhibition hall was utterly silent.

In her mind, the string of memories—being stalked and harassed by Anthony, entering the Nest, being copied by a Resident, melting the candle—were all there, clear and complete, exactly as the Candlefall's description had said: none of them had disappeared.

There was only one difference.

The place where she and Anthony had first met had changed from the back door of the bar to the front door.

These past two days have been absolutely exhausting... I overdid it a while back and still haven't recovered. We're 18 now, not 17 anymore—not as young as we were—and I'm really starting to feel the toll on my body. Sigh.

When you're this tired you can't tell if you're sleepy or just hungry, and you spend the whole day thinking about food, but the moment you eat anything you pass out right after—which only makes things worse... These past two days have really been... rough...

Chapter 24 — Sydney Ginn's Altered History

The wound on her neck had stopped hurting much. Her toughness and resilience truly surpassed her own expectations.

But Sydney Ginn's irritation only grew thicker, like a heart overrun with weeds that couldn't be pulled no matter how hard you tried.

Who would have thought history had such resilience — changing one small detail still couldn't alter the course of events. People always say that sometimes missing one turn can change your entire fate. What a lie.

A stalker, putting on the airs of destiny and fate — just thinking about it was nauseating.

Sydney Ginn glanced at the corpse.

She had killed a Resident for the first time — supposedly one that couldn't be killed — and she'd managed it only by talking her way through it, so she couldn't help feeling uneasy. She was afraid that in the blink of an eye it would stagger back up from the floor again, so every now and then she had to take another look.

But she was worrying too much. Death had already soaked through that body like cold water, fixing it completely in place.

After watching the corpse for a while, she finally relaxed a little and opened the fire trough again.

Time to try once more. This time, Sydney Ginn intended to cut off any possibility of the two meeting right at the root.

She melted the candle for the same window of time, watching the transparent Candle Tears fall and pool mid-air into a lake once more.

In the lake-like Candle Tears, a tiny Sydney Ginn and a tiny Amber stepped out of a miniature taxi together, laughing and talking as they walked into the bar — Sydney Ginn watched them enter through the front door, then shifted her gaze back out to the street, sweeping it up and down.

She clearly remembered that on that night, when the stalker Anthony had approached her, he'd said: "You must have arrived at the bar before me. Otherwise, when a girl like you walked

through that door, there's no way I would have failed to notice."

She couldn't take a pickup line at face value, but thinking back on it afterward, it did seem like Anthony had arrived a step later than she had.

Sydney Ginn pushed down the restlessness in her heart and kept her eyes locked on the bar's front entrance, not daring to look away for a second.

There had been a lot of people going to the bar that night, and in the span of just twenty or thirty minutes, four or five groups of strangers stepped out of several cars in succession — she had never seen so many miniature living people, clustered together in twos and threes, walking through the night under the lights, which made them even harder to make out; she stared until her eyes nearly blurred, and at last she spotted Anthony rounding the corner from down the street.

According to the description, "suicide" via the Candle Tears seemed to be possible — but it said nothing about whether it could kill someone else.

Sydney Ginn decided to try.

What could be more final than turning him into a dead man outright?

She had never been willing to kill lightly. In fact, ever since she had become a Hunter, although she had seen no shortage of dead people, not a single one had actually died by her hand.

But tonight, it was as if something inside her had cracked open, and something not quite the same as before was trying to push its way out.

Come to think of it, she had already killed "herself"; trying to kill someone from the past — a stalker, at that — what was the big deal?

If she couldn't kill him, she would think of something else — whatever the outcome, at least it would count as learning more about what the Candle Tears could do.

Sydney Ginn's finger hovered above Anthony's head, like a massive celestial body about to come crashing down on the earth and crush the dinosaurs.

He was still completely oblivious, hands shoved in his pockets, tall and loose-limbed, looking every bit like a decent man.

...Crushing him to death still meant washing her hands afterward.

Sydney Ginn curled her knuckles and brought them down hard on that carefully styled head.

She had expected the sensation to be something like squashing a large bug, but instead it was like pressing down on a slippery ball; the stalker stumbled, and her forceful strike had only shoved him half a step to the side — he quickly steadied himself, and not only was he still alive, he didn't even seem to feel any pain.

Anthony looked down, muttered a curse, and kicked a pebble away.

...Could it be that she couldn't reach in and kill someone else directly? That the only one she could kill was herself?

That was truly funny.

Despite her frustration, two more attempts seemed to bear out the theory: she tried pushing the miniature Anthony into the road, but an oncoming car swerved in time, leaving him with nothing worse than a few curses from the driver; she managed with great effort to knock a sign light loose, timed it carefully, but it bent in mid-air and crashed to the ground right in front of Anthony's nose.

The stalker was apparently no ordinary person — he brushed past danger several times in a row without anything happening to him, and walked into the bar as if nothing had occurred.

"One of the most powerful Artifacts" — the broadcast was full of hot air. It couldn't kill a person, couldn't prevent a meeting; what was the point of this broken candle containing the past at all?

In the end, wasn't everything exactly as it had been? Nothing had changed at all?

Suppressing her frustration, Sydney Ginn swept through the Candle Tears, searching for herself.

She had already grown quite practiced at working the Candle Tears, and quickly found the moment the two had met: a tiny Anthony pushed open the dark red back door, spotted a tiny Sydney Ginn, walked over to her, and struck up a conversation.

"I didn't have the courage to ask for your number at first — I'm not the type who goes around talking to girls," Anthony said with what seemed like genuine feeling. "But do you know what? On my way here just now, a sign light suddenly crashed right in front of me — this close... if I'd been half a step faster, I would have died. Thinking about how full of surprises life is, I couldn't bear to let this pass..."

She had actually helped him upgrade his material?

Sydney Ginn had played a computer game called The Sims as a child, and now, watching the two of them talk in the Candle Tears, a strange, hazy sense of familiarity came over her, leaving her somewhere between the urge to laugh and the urge to cry.

But this was not a computer game.

Sydney Ginn watched that tiny, oblivious version of herself exchange numbers with Anthony just as she'd expected, and could only sigh inwardly with weary irritation as she closed the fire trough — she needed to let the Candle Tears cool and solidify first, to let this chapter of history "set," and then melt it again before she could change it once more.

The tiny Sydney Ginn — she had lost count of how many times now — pushed open the back door and stepped out of the room thick with tangled music and the smell of alcohol, standing outside to get some air.

A convoy of all-black Mercedes SUVs rose silently out of the night; each vehicle, fitted with anti-terrorism and armored modifications, maintained an equal distance from the others as they passed in succession before the bar's back entrance.

As the last vehicle was about to drive past, Sydney Ginn reached out and flicked it toward the back door — the matchbox-sized SUV was caught by the force, lurched involuntarily, veered off the road, and with a shriek of tires slammed its nose squarely into the bar's back entrance.

The bar's back door, which had not been fully shut to begin with, now had its panel caved in and its hinges twisted by the impact, hanging crookedly at an angle — anyone could see at a glance that it would never close again.

The tiny Sydney Ginn stared at the SUV only two paces away, her face drained of color.

Oh — she had forgotten to protect her past self... Never mind, she hadn't been hit by the car, and alive was good enough.

It wasn't as if she had wanted to get so tangled up with a stalker in the first place — so why was she putting herself through all this trouble? Letting her past self get a good scare was no less than she deserved.

Sydney Ginn watched with a faintly disgusted indifference as that tiny version of herself hurriedly backed away a few steps and called out to no one in particular: "Someone help! There's been a crash!"

If the bar had to temporarily shut down because of this, it might scatter the two before they could meet —

Before Sydney Ginn had even finished the thought, the driver's door of the SUV was shoved open, and a man in a black suit half-tumbled out and quickly swung around behind the wide-open door, dropping into a half-crouch; his left temple had been split open by the impact, and blood, curls, and an over-ear earpiece were all tangled together in a matted mess.

But what stood out most was the 9mm pistol held between his two hands.

Nearby, the tiny Sydney Ginn's gaze landed on that black pistol, and her lips pressed together instantly.

After the vehicle was struck and disabled, his first move was to leap out — so he wouldn't be a sitting duck; he sheltered behind the car door to use it as cover against any potential sniper; even though he had clearly taken a significant blow, that 9mm was still held steadily in a position ready to return fire at any moment, his slightly bent elbow not trembling in the slightest...

Both the Sydney Ginn inside the Candle Tears and the one outside it could see it: this was a personal bodyguard with highly specialized professional training.

Then the other vehicles —

Sydney Ginn turned at once, and sure enough found that the convoy had not wasted a single moment — the other four SUVs had already split off in separate directions, each changing lanes and altering course in an instant before accelerating away, disappearing into the night and lights in every direction.

The level of professionalism here was very high, she thought.

At the exact moment the rear vehicle was struck and lost control, the convoy had immediately abandoned it and broken formation, each turning onto a different route and rapidly increasing the distance between them... this was clearly a contingency plan prepared well in advance.

Such a plan generally has only one purpose: to protect whichever vehicle in the convoy carries an important figure, so potential enemies cannot tell which car that person is actually riding in.

"...No, at present we cannot confirm what was done to the vehicle. Yes, no attacks so far."

The man in the black suit crouched behind the car door, speaking in a low voice into his earpiece: "The situation with the car is strange, but I've detected no signs of Artifact use in the

vicinity... Yes, there's a bar here, and there are witnesses nearby — they've probably already called the police."

Artifact? Had he just said Artifact?

Sydney Ginn's interest sparked immediately, and she leaned in closer — fortunately, the man in the black suit was nothing more than a tiny figure within the Candle Tears, unable to see that floating between heaven and earth above the car was a gigantic human ear, listening to every word he said.

"...Understood," the man in the black suit replied quietly after a few seconds. "In the negotiations and handling that follow, I will not mention Mr. Wellesley's name."

Mr. Wellesley?

Sydney Ginn froze.

An important figure, and surnamed Wellesley... could it be that the person so carefully protected by this convoy was Wellesley himself — Blackmoor City's foremost figure in both wealth and standing?

Wellesley was indeed a person of great status, but he wasn't a head of government; that his security should be this tight clearly meant he knew he was in danger...

Could it be that his death, not long from now, was not from natural causes but something deliberately brought about?

Had he noticed, months in advance, that someone wanted to assassinate him — and that was why he had taken such thorough and careful security measures?

Curious as she was, Sydney Ginn hadn't forgotten her original purpose, and glanced back at the back door.

The crash had drawn all the bar patrons outside — some were watching the spectacle, some were on their phones, and some were taking photos and posting on Twitter; the man in the black suit had a sharp read on the situation and, to avoid causing a scene, had already holstered the 9mm back beneath his jacket — though one hand remained pressed over it, ready to draw at any moment.

Among the crowd of onlookers, the tiny Sydney Ginn and Amber were speaking in low voices; a few steps away, the tiny Anthony was glancing toward them again and again.

Within seconds, he walked over and greeted the tiny Sydney Ginn with a smile.

Unbelievable — was there truly no way to keep herself from running into Anthony?

Sydney Ginn cursed under her breath, but after a brief consideration, she decided to set the stalker matter aside for now.

Wellesley appearing in her Candle Tears history meant that he and her fate were bound together in some way... and that was exactly what made it interesting: what possible connection could the soon-to-be-dead richest man in Blackmoor City have with her?

She set little Sydney Ginn and the stalker aside, and working backward along the timeline of when Wellesley's motorcade had appeared, she traced the thread until she had a rough location, then lit a new wax channel.

If she could keep an eye on Wellesley's history, she was sure to dig up quite a bit of information...

The more you wait for something, the slower it comes.

Sydney Ginn fidgeted restlessly—touching the melting candle one moment, adjusting the flame the next—impatient and anxious, her thoughts scattered; her gaze wandered here and there, yet it was only after quite some time that she suddenly realized two things.

First, the stretch of Candlefall from when she and Anthony had met due to the car accident had solidified again, setting into the latest version of history.

Second, the corpse on the exhibition hall floor had vanished at some point without her noticing.

I finally managed to recover a little today! But then I looked at the date—it's already the 5th, and in the blink of an eye I'm going back to Shanghai again...

Following those seven Calabash Brothers from a while back, I don't even know how many Minions I owe everyone now—let me check...

Okay, I'm back after checking, and I owe way too many—can't fit it all in the author's note, so I'll open a separate chapter tonight and thank everyone properly first (。

Thank you all for your enthusiastic support, darlings—I've already bought property in the OB/GYN department of Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, and I'll be living there from now on; everyone is welcome to visit bearing cakes and gifts.

Why is it always Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, you ask—because that's where I was born, and we like to keep things full circle.

Chapter 25 — Sydney Ginn, Latest Version, Present Day

Although the beginning of the story had been rewritten several times, the moment Sydney Ginn met Anthony had never changed:

On the eve of summer's arrival, in a soft and restless night, she ran into a handsome-looking venomous thing.

Of course, her eyes could not see through Anthony's smooth, attractive skin and hair to the dark, twisted liquid writhing deep inside his mind—and when a person feels they are getting everything they want, one by one, they are perfectly capable of being gentle and generous, attentive and considerate.

Especially at the very beginning.

"...That scared the life out of me just now," Sydney murmured to her friend. "He suddenly lost control—the car came straight at me. Lucky I've been keeping fit; my reflexes were fast enough that I threw myself out of the way in time... otherwise I'd be a human pancake sandwiched between his bumper and the wall by now."

Amber drew a sharp breath. "That dangerous? Thank goodness you always go to—"

She stopped herself, glanced over at Anthony, and corrected course: "Thank goodness you always go to the gym."

Amber wore her hair short, had a round little face, and a pair of ears that stuck out sharply from her straight hair like an elf's; her personality matched her looks—quick-witted and perceptive.

Sydney often told her it would be wonderful if she had a passage too, so the two of them could go adventuring together in the Nest—though she also knew that if Amber had a passage, she would be a Hunter for the Morgan House Faction, making the two of them potential rivals.

"You had a real brush with death there. Keeping up with exercise is never a bad idea."

Anthony suspected nothing; he fussed over Sydney with worried concern, the lingering fear on his face so vivid that it looked as though he himself had nearly lost his life just now.

In the space of a minute or two, his emotional range proved quite comprehensive—moving from worry to relief and gradually into righteous indignation, covering the full spectrum: "What

kind of driving was that? Was he drunk? Standing off to the side all sneaky like that, not even coming over to apologize! When the police come to take the statement, you have to spell out exactly what happened."

What would later feel false was, at the time, quite welcome. Sydney flashed him a smile and lowered her voice: "He wasn't drunk... he's probably a private bodyguard. I caught a glimpse of his sidearm just now."

"A bodyguard?" Amber slid a glance sideways and immediately let out an "Oh," her voice dropping. "No wonder he's been keeping one hand under his jacket the whole time... There's no one else in the car—did whoever he was guarding leave already?"

"Already gone," Sydney answered. "He had a whole motorcade ahead of him; the moment his car hit trouble, they all scattered immediately. No idea what went wrong with his car—why it would crash into the door like that."

The moment he heard the word "gun," Anthony's face tightened slightly. He hesitated, then reached out and pulled both women behind the bar's back door, saying repeatedly, "Better safe than sorry... what if he's not a bodyguard but some kind of lunatic? Should we go inside?"

At the time, Sydney thought he seemed quite steady and careful.

"I'd rather stand here a bit longer," Amber said, stealing several glances toward the black-suited figure behind the SUV. "I just love watching the drama unfold—you two don't mind, do you?"

Anthony glanced at her, then at Sydney.

Amber wasn't there for the drama—Sydney knew that perfectly well.

Compared to the everyday dealings of a Hunter's house faction, a car crashing into a door wasn't even interesting enough to bother mentioning.

Moreover, the look in Amber's eyes was nothing like someone watching for entertainment: a bright, focused light had settled in them, moving from the car to the figure beside it, as if that one point of light had already seized on something amid all the noise and confusion.

With a major Hunter house faction behind her, Amber had access to a remarkable amount of information. The Matthew Effect applied here as well: the more a person knows, the better they know where to look for more, and the better they know what actually counts as real "information."

Unfortunately, Sydney couldn't ask her directly what she had spotted—Anthony was right there beside them.

"Then I'll keep you company," she said.

Anthony showed no sign of reluctance.

"The public order in Blackmoor City really is getting worse and worse—I suppose even the wealthy are starting to feel the water heating up." He leaned against the wall and chatted idly with Sydney: "Ordinary people like us can't afford bodyguards; we can only look after ourselves... especially a young, attractive woman like you—you're more likely to become a target."

With his warm gaze fixed on her face, Sydney instinctively smoothed her hair and said with a smile, "I'm not particularly worried."

"Having a boyfriend is a lot safer," Anthony said. "Didn't your boyfriend come with you tonight?"

"I'm single."

Because she had a good impression of him, Sydney didn't bother taking offense at such an obvious fishing attempt; she thought for a moment, then added: "I can take care of my own safety perfectly well. Not to mention anything else—I have a small ladies' pistol at home, and a hunting knife I bought specially from Europe."

Anthony froze.

Something seemed to rise to his throat, then he held it there in his mouth without speaking, rolling the words around on his tongue. While he was sifting and weighing them, Amber gave Sydney a light tug and murmured, "His colleague just arrived."

Sydney's gaze cut through the crowd, and sure enough she spotted a car that had just pulled up; the driver who stepped out was dressed in the same black suit and strode over quickly to meet the bodyguard who had caused the crash.

Whatever had caused that bodyguard to crash earlier, the danger had long since drained away from the scene, replaced by curious bar patrons, the deeply frowning manager, and the emergency responders who had just arrived... The bodyguard had finally relaxed as well, and was now sitting in the driver's seat with the car door hanging wide open, answering questions from two police officers while letting the paramedics check his pupils.

"Dylan," the newly arrived black suit called out.

"Ivan?"

The crash-causing bodyguard looked up at the sound, startled to see who it was, and lowered the cotton pad he had been pressing against the wound on his temple. "Why are you the one who came?"

The second bodyguard, named Ivan, seemed to be lower in both rank and experience, and his manner was respectfully proper: "Something went wrong here, and the boss got a bit uneasy having to go pick something up in the middle of it, so they brought in quite a few extra people on short notice. Sister Mi was worried it would be hard for you to manage on your own, so she sent me over to lend a hand."

For some reason, his voice was pitched a notch lower than most people's. Sydney was quite certain that Amber, just like her, had been straining her ears and edging several steps forward just to catch the general gist of it.

Dylan showed little warmth or gratitude toward this reinforcement.

"Got it," he said, pressing the cloth back against his wound, looking like a man who had nothing more to say and wanted Ivan to stop talking as well—perhaps because there were police officers right beside them.

"We're still open for business as usual," a bartender called out loudly from the back door, apparently trying to remind the patrons to hurry back inside and keep spending money. "Don't worry, everyone—nothing's been affected!"

"Shall we?" Anthony tilted his head down and spoke to Sydney very gently: "Let's go back in and have a proper chat—let me buy you a drink."

Running into Anthony tonight had been a complete surprise; she found herself torn on the spot between "bodyguard crash" and "attractive man"—and it was Amber who smiled at her, tipped her chin toward the bar's back door, and said: "You go ahead. If anything interesting turns up, I'll tell you about it later."

Sydney had no choice but to remind her, "Come find me inside in a bit then"—and after Amber promised she would, Sydney went into the bar with Anthony.

As she settled into her seat, her thoughts flickered briefly to Ivan. He had said something about the boss "picking something up," hadn't he? Picking up what? And was it at all connected to

whatever had caught Amber's interest in the matter?

But she didn't let herself think too deeply about it. Because Anthony had settled in beside her, a lock of hair slipping down over his face, the light in his eyes rippling faintly beneath the shadow of his hair; as if she were some rare treasure the rest of the world had somehow inexplicably overlooked.

Later, Sydney reflected that no matter what the quarry is, a person who can be a Hunter needs a certain instinct—for instance, she hadn't felt there was anything particularly distinctive about her own appearance or dress, yet Anthony had still picked her out from among the crowd of bar patrons at a glance.

In the Nest, she was a Hunter. Back in the human world, she was the prey.

"What would you like to drink?" he asked.

"I absolutely hate alcohol," Sydney said—and hearing herself say it out loud inside a bar, she couldn't help laughing.

Using "not drinking" as a topic of conversation, she began her chat and first date with Anthony.

Over two or three months, they went from seeing each other occasionally to growing closer and closer; after Anthony visited her home for the first time, he became very nearly the most perfect boyfriend in the world—though that illusion didn't last very long.

At some point along the way—she couldn't remember which meeting it was—the two of them were talking and the conversation drifted to the black SUV that had crashed into the bar's back door in early May; it was only then that Sydney remembered she'd never gotten around to asking Amber what she had actually discovered that night—perhaps the whole thing had turned out to be not worth mentioning after all, which was why Amber had never thought to bring it up.

"By the way, I remember you said that night that you had a hunting knife you'd bought specially from Europe." Anthony's interest suddenly sparked, and he asked: "You can get hunting knives here too—what makes a European one special? Let me take a look?"

Sydney immediately leapt up from the sofa, retrieved the hunting knife, and launched into its brand, craftsmanship, and value; the more animated she became about it, the more Anthony's desire was kindled.

"I'm not trying to take it from you," he said, still performing a degree of embarrassment back then: "Could I borrow it for a while? I have a friend who specifically collects knives—I'd like to show it to him."

Sydney thought it over and figured she probably wouldn't need to enter the Nest again for the next two or three months. And even if she did, she had other weapons and tools. "Fine—just bring it back when I need it."

...She slowly opened her eyes, unable for a moment to tell whether the stiff, cold thing was her own body or the exhibition hall floor—the two had nearly fused into one.

Anthony never returned the hunting knife.

Sydney looked at the two threads of memory running through her mind, feeling both lost and bewildered, and suddenly, blindingly clear.

She turned her head without a sound, her gaze traveling across the floor and far into the distance, where it came to rest on the enormous candle lying across the exhibition hall—

And on her own back, seated before it.

So that was it.

In the second version of history—the one that had been altered for unknown reasons—Anthony had borrowed the hunting knife and never returned it; Sydney had entered the Nest without the knife, and had naturally been unable to drive it into the Resident's throat.

And so the Resident had not caused the same wound to appear on its own throat—

And so she had survived.

Today the May Day holiday ended and I went back to my usual chaos—spent most of the day running around outside, so the chapter's a bit late... I'm exhausted every single day, all I want is to go home and sleep properly...

This author's note is being typed on an e-ink screen! I keep buying them and returning them, buying and returning—I'm already on my third one. Will this one survive the 7-day no-questions-asked return window? Stay tuned... The first two I returned the moment they arrived.

(Okay, I can't break the em-dash rule, are you trying to finish me off—)